

MODULE 5

Market Your Message

Build the system that makes your right customer find you.

WHAT THIS MODULE DOES

Marketing without a clear message is noise. This module gives you the frameworks to define what you stand for, who you stand for, and how to reach them consistently. From the story structure that makes your brand instantly clear, to the growth loops that compound your reach over time, these are the tools that build audiences, generate leads, and make your marketing work harder than your budget.

IN THIS MODULE

- 5.1 StoryBrand Framework — SB7
- 5.2 Hook Framework for Content
- 5.3 4Ps & 7Ps Marketing Mix
- 5.4 Content Pillars Strategy
- 5.5 Go-To-Market Canvas
- 5.6 Product Launch Playbook
- 5.7 Brand Voice Definition
- 5.8 Viral Loop — Growth Loop
- 5.9 AARRR — Pirate Metrics
- 5.10 Flywheel Model

Start here if you are new to AI, or your prompts feel hit-or-miss.

5.1 — StoryBrand Framework – SB7

Clarify your message so customers stop, listen, and act

USE THIS WHEN

Your website, pitch deck, or marketing copy is confusing. People spend time on your website and leave without understanding what you do or why it matters to them. Your message is accurate it just doesn't land.

THE FRAMEWORK

Donald Miller's StoryBrand framework, published in 2017, is built on a single insight: **customers don't care about your story, they care about their story**, and whether you have a role in it. The SB7 structure positions the customer as the Hero, gives them a Guide (your brand), names the Problem (external, internal, and philosophical), provides a Plan, issues a Call to Action, describes Success, and shows what's at stake in Failure. When your marketing follows this structure, confused prospects become engaged ones.

Origin: Donald Miller, Building a StoryBrand, 2017

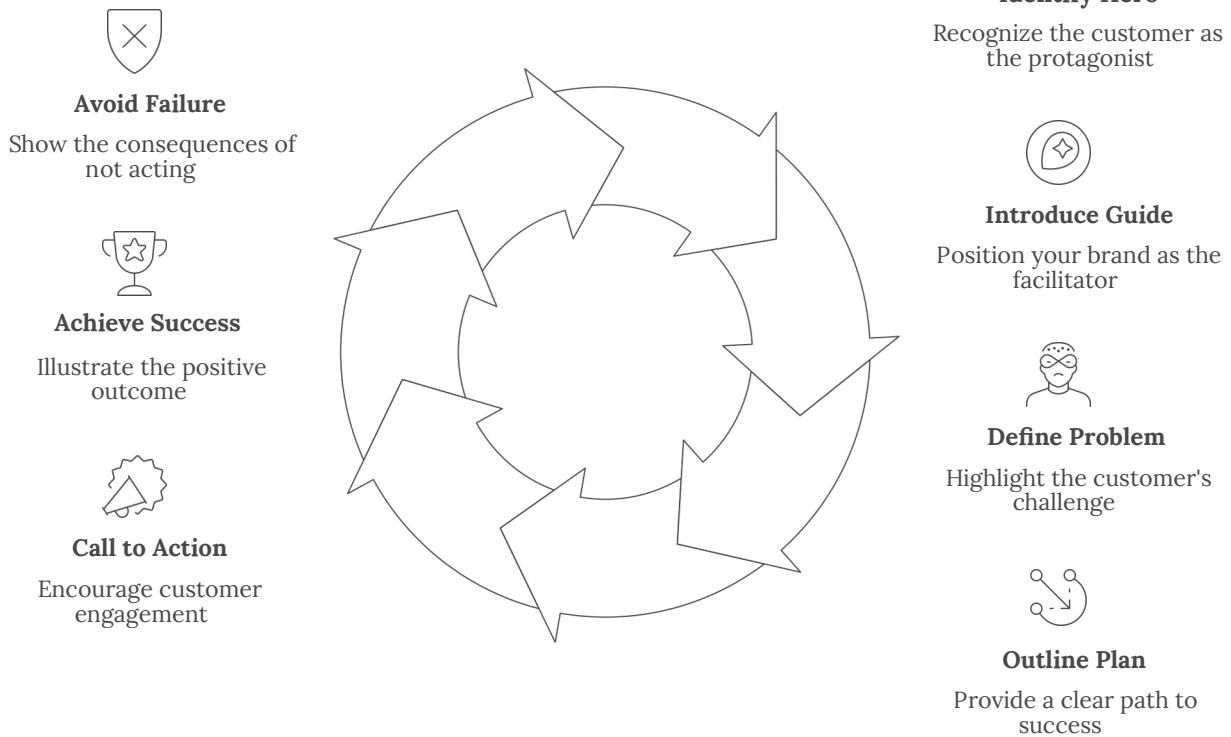
HOW TO USE IT

1. Never position your brand as the hero you are the guide who helps the hero succeed.
2. Name all three problem layers: external (practical), internal (emotional), philosophical (why it's wrong).
3. The plan must be simple three steps maximum. Complexity kills action.
4. Use this structure for your website homepage first, then apply it to email, ads, and pitches.

PRO TIP

The most common StoryBrand mistake is failing to name the internal problem. The external problem is what they Google. The internal problem is what keeps them awake. Customers buy solutions to external problems but they buy from brands that understand their internal ones. Name the internal problem explicitly in your copy.

StoryBrand SB7 Cycle



AI PROMPT — COPY & PASTE READY

Act as a StoryBrand messaging consultant using Donald Miller's SB7.

My business : [WHAT YOU DO AND WHO YOU SERVE]

Customer's goal : [WHAT THE CUSTOMER WANTS TO ACHIEVE]

Build the full SB7 for my brand:

CHARACTER : Who is the hero, describe them specifically

PROBLEM : External (practical), Internal (emotional), Philosophical (why it's wrong that this exists)

GUIDE : My brand's empathy and authority

PLAN : 3 simple steps to work with me

CALL TO ACTION : One direct CTA and one transitional CTA

SUCCESS : What their life looks like after

FAILURE : What's at stake if they don't act

Then write a one-sentence brand tagline using this structure.

Pairs well with: 3.7 Positioning Statement · 4.6 PAS · 4.7 Proposal Writing · 5.8 Brand Voice

5.2 — Hook Framework for Content

The first line determines whether the rest gets read

USE THIS WHEN

Your content is well-written and genuinely useful but it gets ignored. You're posting consistently and seeing minimal engagement. The problem isn't the content it's that nobody is stopping to read it.

THE FRAMEWORK

In a feed of infinite content, the first line of any post, email, or video is the only thing that decides whether the rest gets seen. A hook works by triggering one of four responses: **Curiosity** (I need to know how this ends), **Relatability** (that is exactly my situation), **Controversy** (I disagree and want to respond), or **Value** (this will help me right now). The 3H Hook System structures every piece of content around a strong opening that earns the scroll followed by a clear value delivery and a closing that creates engagement or action.

Origin: Social media content strategy — Hook framework methodology, 2020s

HOW TO USE IT

1. Write 5 hook variations for every piece of content the best one is rarely the first.
2. Test different hook types across your audience: curiosity works on some, value on others.
3. The hook should be the last thing you write after you know what the content delivers.
4. If the hook doesn't make you want to keep reading, rewrite it before posting.

Curiosity Isn't a License to Bait

A hook that promises one thing and delivers another earns a scroll-past on the next post, not the current one. Curiosity should point at the real value inside if the opening line and the content don't match, you're not hooking, you're baiting.

AI PROMPT — COPY & PASTE READY

Act as a content strategist and copywriter specialising in hooks.

Content topic : [WHAT THIS POST, EMAIL, OR VIDEO IS ABOUT]

Target audience : [WHO WILL SEE THIS AND WHAT THEY CARE ABOUT]

Platform : [LINKEDIN / EMAIL / INSTAGRAM / YOUTUBE]

Core value : [WHAT THE READER WILL LEARN OR GET]

Write 5 hook variations using different hook types:

CURIOSITY HOOK : Creates a knowledge gap they must close

RELATABILITY HOOK : Opens with a situation they recognise

CONTROVERSY HOOK : Challenges a common belief in the space

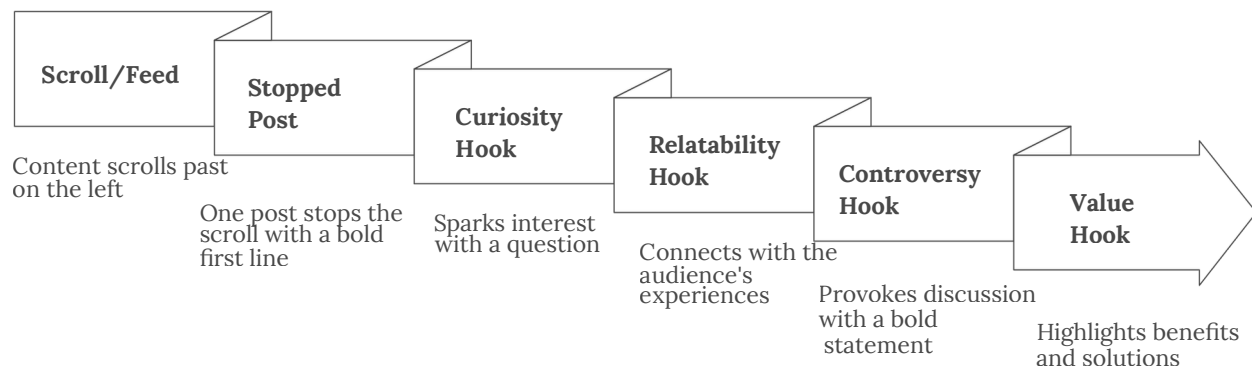
VALUE HOOK : Leads with the specific benefit upfront

STORY HOOK : Opens mid-scene in a compelling moment

For each hook: write the opening line only (max 15 words).

Then recommend the strongest one for this audience.

3H Hook System



PRO TIP

The curiosity hook is the most powerful but the most overused. The relatability hook is the most underused and often outperforms everything else because it makes the reader feel seen before they've read a word of content. Start with: 'You know that moment when...' and describe your audience's exact situation.

Pairs well with: 5.5 Content Pillars · 4.6 PAS · 4.1 Cold Outreach · 5.8 Brand Voice

5.3 — 4Ps & 7Ps Marketing Mix

Build a complete, coherent marketing strategy not just tactics

USE THIS WHEN

You're running marketing activities that feel disconnected. You're active on social media, have a website, and occasionally run campaigns but there's no coherent strategy pulling it all together. Something is always off.

THE FRAMEWORK

E. Jerome McCarthy's 4Ps Marketing Mix - **Product, Price, Place, Promotion** is the classic framework for building a complete marketing strategy. Booms and Bitner extended it to 7Ps for service businesses by adding **People, Process, and Physical Evidence**. The power of the framework is in checking coherence: if your premium pricing (Price) is contradicted by your distribution through discount channels (Place), your strategy has a gap. Every element of your marketing must reinforce the same positioning.

Origin: E. Jerome McCarthy, Basic Marketing, 1960 • Booms & Bitner, 7Ps extension, 1981

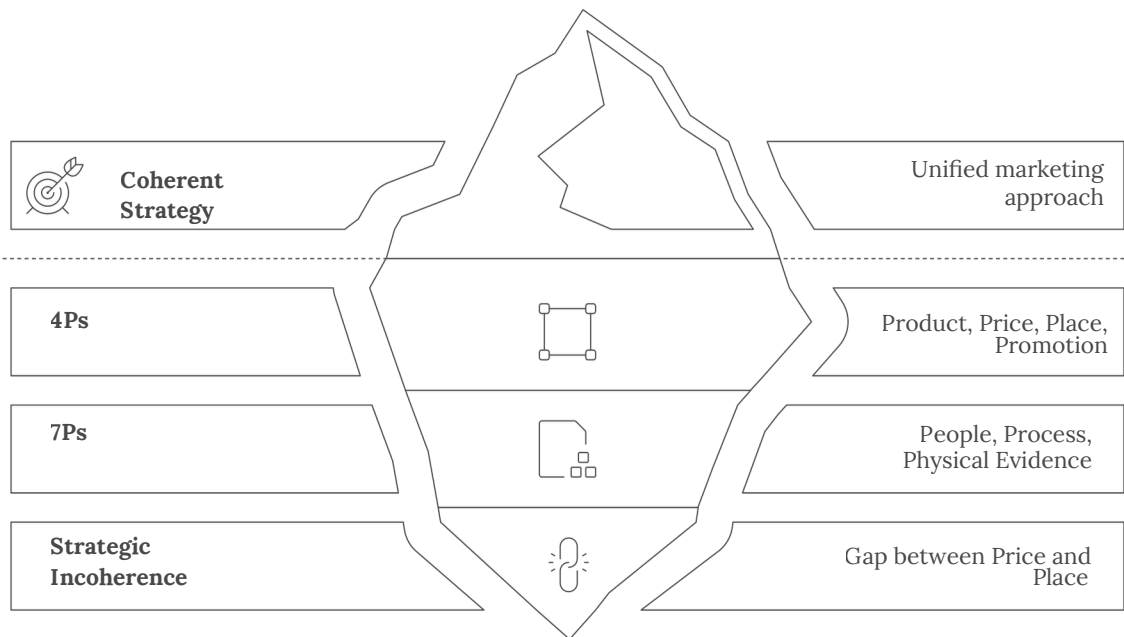
HOW TO USE IT

1. Map your current 4Ps or 7Ps before asking AI for recommendations.
2. Look for contradictions between elements, incoherence is the most common marketing failure.
3. For service businesses, People and Process are often more important than Promotion.
4. Revisit your Marketing Mix after any pricing change, channel shift, or positioning update.

PRO TIP

The most neglected P in service businesses is Process. Brilliant people and strong promotion cannot compensate for a broken delivery process customers experience the process, not the strategy. Map your client delivery process before investing more in promotion.

4Ps & 7Ps Marketing Mix — Coherence is the Point



AI PROMPT — COPY & PASTE READY

Act as a marketing strategist using the 7Ps Marketing Mix.

My business : [DESCRIBE YOUR PRODUCT OR SERVICE]

Target customer : [WHO THEY ARE AND WHAT THEY VALUE]

Current stage : [EARLY / GROWING / SCALING]

Analyse and recommend for all 7Ps:

PRODUCT : What are we selling, features and positioning

PRICE : How should we price, value, cost, or competitive?

PLACE : Where and how do customers access us?

PROMOTION : Which channels and messages drive awareness?

PEOPLE : Who delivers the experience. skills and culture

PROCESS : How is the service or product delivered?

PHYSICAL : What tangible evidence builds trust?

Flag any contradictions between elements. Identify the 2 Ps that most need improvement.
For those 2 Ps, give one specific change I should make in the next 30 days.

Pairs well with: 5.6 GTM Canvas · 3.9 STP Model · 5.4 Content Strategy · 2.7 Pricing

5.4 — Content Pillars Strategy

Post with purpose build an audience that trusts you

USE THIS WHEN

You post content randomly, whatever feels relevant that day. Your audience doesn't know what to expect from you and your posts attract different people with no consistent theme. You have followers but no community.

THE FRAMEWORK

Content Pillars are the 3–5 core topics that define what you stand for online. Each **pillar** represents an area where your brand has **genuine expertise and your audience has genuine interest**. Every piece of content you create sits under one pillar. This creates **consistency** your audience knows what you're about and self-selects if they're the right fit. It also makes content creation faster instead of asking 'what should I post today?' you ask 'which pillar am I covering this week?'

Origin: Content marketing best practice — content pillar methodology, widely adopted 2015s onwards

HOW TO USE IT

1. Choose pillars that sit at the intersection of your expertise and your audience's needs.
2. Each pillar should be specific enough to exclude broad pillars dilute positioning.
3. Allocate content across pillars by week not every post needs to be educational.
4. Review pillar performance every 90 days and retire any pillar that consistently underperforms.

Pillars Aren't Permanent

Picking pillars once and never revisiting them is how brands go stale. What your audience needed a year ago isn't what they need now. The 90-day review isn't optional housekeeping it's how you catch a pillar that's coasting on habit instead of earning its place in your content.

Act as a content strategy consultant.

My background and expertise : [WHAT YOU KNOW DEEPLY]

My target audience : [WHO I WANT TO REACH AND WHAT THEY CARE ABOUT]

My business goal : [WHAT I WANT CONTENT TO ACHIEVE LEADS, BRAND, AUTHORITY, COMMUNITY]

Platform : [LINKEDIN / INSTAGRAM / X / YOUTUBE]

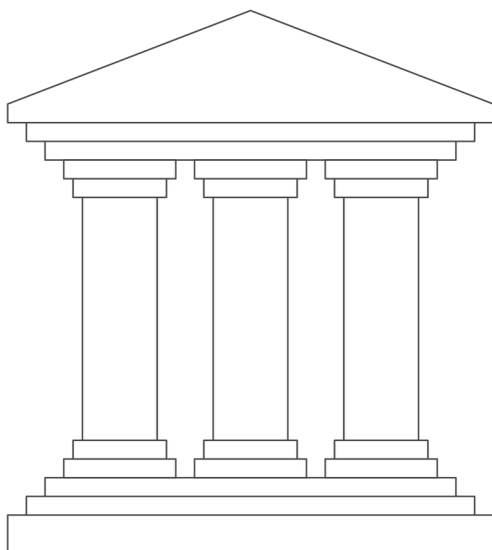
Design my Content Pillar strategy:

Step 1 : Suggest 5 content pillars that fit my expertise and audience.

For each : name, description, and 3 example post topics.

Step 2 : Recommend a weekly content mix across pillars.

Step 3 : Suggest one signature content format I should own, the thing my audience will recognise me for.



Content Pillars Strategy



Leadership

Focuses on guiding and inspiring your audience.



AI Tools

Explores innovative technologies to enhance productivity.



Sales Strategy

Outlines effective methods to drive revenue.

PRO TIP

Your signature content format is more valuable than your best single post. A consistent format, a weekly framework breakdown, a Monday mindset post, a Friday lessons-learned thread - trains your audience to expect and look for you. Consistency of format compounds faster than variety of topics.

Pairs well with: 5.2 Hook Framework · 5.8 Brand Voice · 10.8 Personal Brand Flywheel

5.5 — Go-To-Market Canvas

Plan your launch so it lands, not just ships

USE THIS WHEN

You're about to launch a new product, enter a new market, or take a new offer to existing customers and you don't have a structured plan. You're moving fast but not strategically. Things will fall through the cracks.

THE FRAMEWORK

A Go-To-Market (GTM) Canvas is a structured plan that maps seven elements of a successful launch: **Target Segment** (who exactly), **Value Proposition** (why this, why now), **Channels** (how you reach them), **Pricing** (how you charge), **Sales Motion** (how you convert), **Success Metrics** (how you know it's working), and **Launch Timeline** (sequenced actions). Without a GTM Canvas, launches become activity without direction, lots of effort, unclear results.

Origin: VC & startup GTM methodology — widely documented in startup literature

HOW TO USE IT

1. Complete the Target Segment and Value Proposition first, everything else follows from those.
2. Define success metrics before launch, not after. What number will tell you this worked?
3. Map the Sales Motion specifically, who does what, in what order, using which assets.
4. Set a 30-day, 60-day, and 90-day milestone to know whether to accelerate or adjust.



If Target Segment or Value Proposition is wrong, the other five elements just execute the mistake faster and more efficiently.

Act as a go-to-market strategist.

What I am launching : [PRODUCT, SERVICE, OR NEW MARKET ENTRY]

Launch date target : [WHEN YOU WANT TO GO LIVE]

Resources available : [TEAM SIZE, BUDGET RANGE, CHANNELS]

Build a complete GTM Canvas:

TARGET SEGMENT : Who specifically - ICP description

VALUE PROP : Why this, why now, why us

CHANNELS : How we reach them - ranked by priority

PRICING : Model and rationale

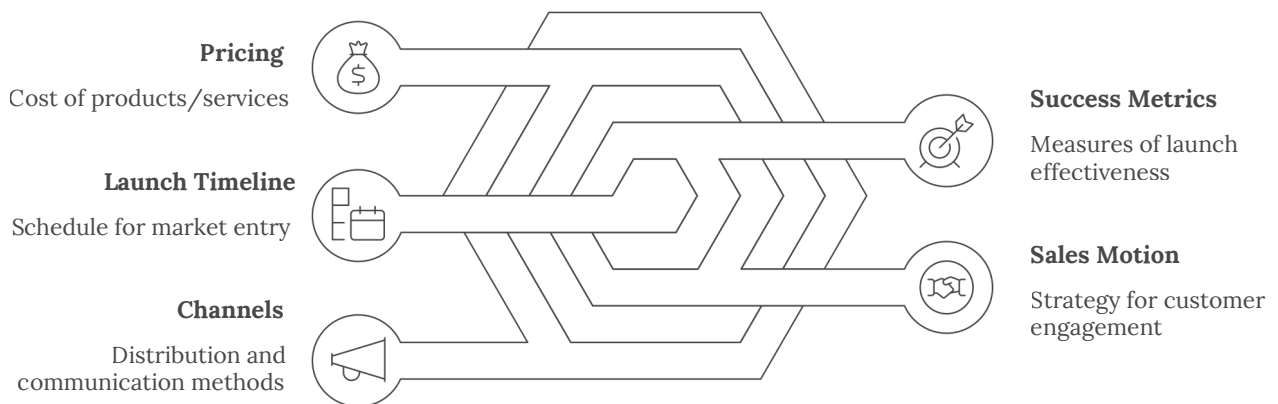
SALES MOTION : Steps from awareness to closed deal

SUCCESS METRICS : The 3 numbers that define success

TIMELINE : Key milestones for weeks 1, 2, 4, 8

Flag the highest-risk assumption in this GTM plan and suggest how to validate it before full launch.

Go-To-Market Canvas



PRO TIP

The highest-risk GTM assumption is almost always Channel, not product. Most founders assume a channel will work before testing it. Before investing in a full launch, run a 2-week channel test with minimal spend. Let data pick your primary channel, not your preference.

Pairs well with: 5.3 Marketing Mix · 5.7 Launch Playbook · 2.3 Lean Canvas · 3.4 ICP

5.6 — Product Launch Playbook

Build anticipation before you ship not just noise after

USE THIS WHEN

You launch something and get a brief spike of attention that fades in 48 hours. You're announcing, not launching. The difference is what happens before the launch date.

THE FRAMEWORK

Jeff Walker's Product Launch Formula, distilled for founders and operators, is a pre-launch sequence that builds anticipation through a structured four-phase approach: **Seed** (plant the idea and gauge interest), **Pre-Launch Content** (deliver value that creates desire), **Launch** (open with urgency and social proof), **Post-Launch** (follow up with those who didn't convert and collect testimonials). The pre-launch phase is where most founders underinvest they spend 90% of their energy on what happens on launch day and almost nothing on the weeks before it.

Origin: Jeff Walker, Product Launch Formula, 2005 — adapted for B2B and SaaS contexts

HOW TO USE IT

1. Start pre-launch content at least 3 weeks before your launch date.
2. Each pre-launch piece should deliver standalone value not tease a sale.
3. Build a list of warm leads before launch day, launch to people who already want it.
4. Define your launch window: open and close dates create urgency that open-ended launches don't.

Urgency Needs to Be Real

A close date only creates urgency if it's real fake scarcity gets noticed and remembered. If your "launch window" quietly reopens next month, you haven't built urgency, you've taught your audience your deadlines don't mean anything.



Act as a product launch strategist using Jeff Walker's Launch Formula.

Product : [WHAT YOU ARE LAUNCHING]

Target audience : [WHO IT IS FOR]

Launch date : [WHEN YOU WANT TO GO LIVE]

Existing audience size : [EMAIL LIST / FOLLOWERS / NETWORK]

Build a 4-phase launch plan:

PHASE 1 — SEED (4 weeks before):

How to plant the idea and gauge genuine interest

PHASE 2 — PRE-LAUNCH (weeks 2–3):

3 pieces of content that deliver value and build desire

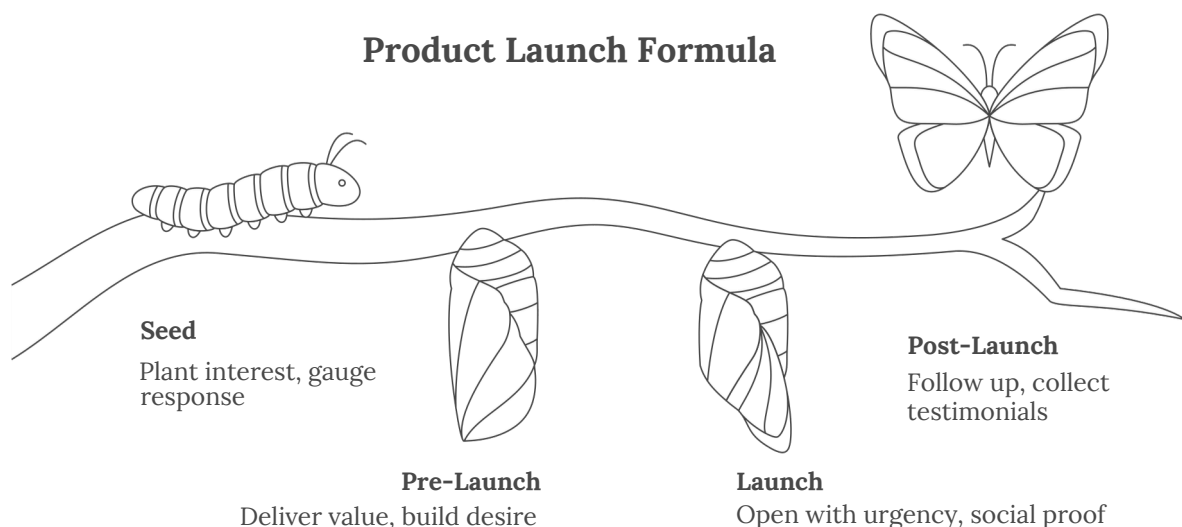
PHASE 3 — LAUNCH (launch week):

Day-by-day sequence with urgency mechanics

PHASE 4 — POST-LAUNCH (week after):

Follow-up for non-buyers · Testimonial collection

Give specific content topics for each phase.



PRO TIP

The single most valuable pre-launch action is a waitlist. Even 50 people on a waitlist changes the psychology of your launch, it creates social proof before the launch, tells you demand is real, and gives you a warm list to open to first. Start your waitlist before you finish building.

Pairs well with: 5.5 GTM Canvas · 5.2 Hook Framework · 5.3 Marketing Mix

5.7 — Brand Voice Definition

Sound like yourself consistently, across every channel

USE THIS WHEN

Your content sounds different every week. Your LinkedIn posts, website copy, and email newsletters feel like they were written by three different people. You can't brief a writer or a VA because you can't describe your voice.

THE FRAMEWORK

Brand voice is the consistent personality and tone your brand uses across all communications. It is not the same as tone: tone adjusts to context (a sales email is more direct than a thought leadership post), but voice stays constant. A strong brand voice has three layers: **Personality Traits** (the adjectives that describe how you sound), **Voice Rules** (what you do and don't say), and **Tone Variations** (how the voice shifts across contexts). When your voice is defined, every piece of content, even AI-generated sounds unmistakably like you.

Origin: Brand strategy methodology — brand voice frameworks widely documented

HOW TO USE IT

1. Define your voice by what you are and what you are not the contrast sharpens the definition.
2. Write 3 examples of your brand voice in action for different contexts before defining the rules.
3. Test your voice definition by briefing someone who doesn't know your brand and seeing if they get it right.
4. Include voice rules in every brief you give to writers, designers, or AI.

Never Sounds Like AI" Isn't Real

"Sounds unmistakably like you" is doing a lot of work in that last line, even a well-defined voice needs a human pass before it ships. Voice rules stop AI-generated content from sounding generic. They don't make it sound like you wrote it yourself.

Act as a brand strategy consultant specialising in brand voice.

My background : [WHO YOU ARE - EXPERIENCE, VALUES, STYLE]

My audience : [WHO I AM TALKING TO AND WHAT THEY VALUE]

Examples of content I love: [DESCRIBE OR PASTE 2-3 EXAMPLES]

Content I dislike : [DESCRIBE THE STYLE YOU WANT TO AVOID]

Define my brand voice across four dimensions:

PERSONALITY TRAITS : 4 adjectives that describe my voice.

For each : what it means in practice + what it is NOT.

VOICE RULES : 5 things I always do in my writing.

5 things I never do.

tone variations : How my voice shifts across:

LinkedIn post / Email newsletter / Sales copy / Bio

VOICE SAMPLE : Write one paragraph in my brand voice about:

[YOUR CORE TOPIC OR RECENT CHALLENGE]

Brand Voice Framework



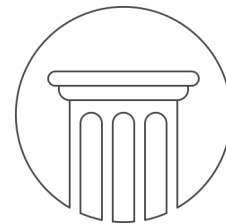
Personality Traits

The core adjectives that define the brand's character.



Voice Rules

Guidelines for what the brand should and should not say.



Tone Variations

How the brand's voice adapts to different communication channels.

PRO TIP

The most useful part of a brand voice guide is the 'what we never say' list. The don'ts define the voice more sharply than the dos. If you never use jargon, never use passive voice, and never make claims without proof, that combination is already a distinctive voice. Start with the never list.

Pairs well with: 5.1 StoryBrand · 5.4 Content Pillars · 5.2 Hook Framework · 10.8 Personal Brand

5.8 — Viral Loop – Growth Loop

Build growth that compounds, not just campaigns that spike

USE THIS WHEN

Your growth comes entirely from paid acquisition or your personal network. When you stop spending or posting, growth stops. You have no compounding engine every customer takes the same effort to acquire as the last.

THE FRAMEWORK

A Growth Loop is a self-reinforcing system where each user or customer generates the conditions for the next. Unlike a funnel (linear, ends at conversion), a loop feeds itself. The four types are: **Viral Loop** (users invite others), **Content Loop** (content generates SEO or social reach that drives new users), **Paid Loop** (revenue from users funds ads that acquire more users), and **Product Loop** (using the product creates value that is visible to non-users). Andrew Chen and Brian Balfour popularised growth loops as the foundation of sustainable, compounding growth.

Origin: Andrew Chen / Brian Balfour — Growth Loops framework, 2017

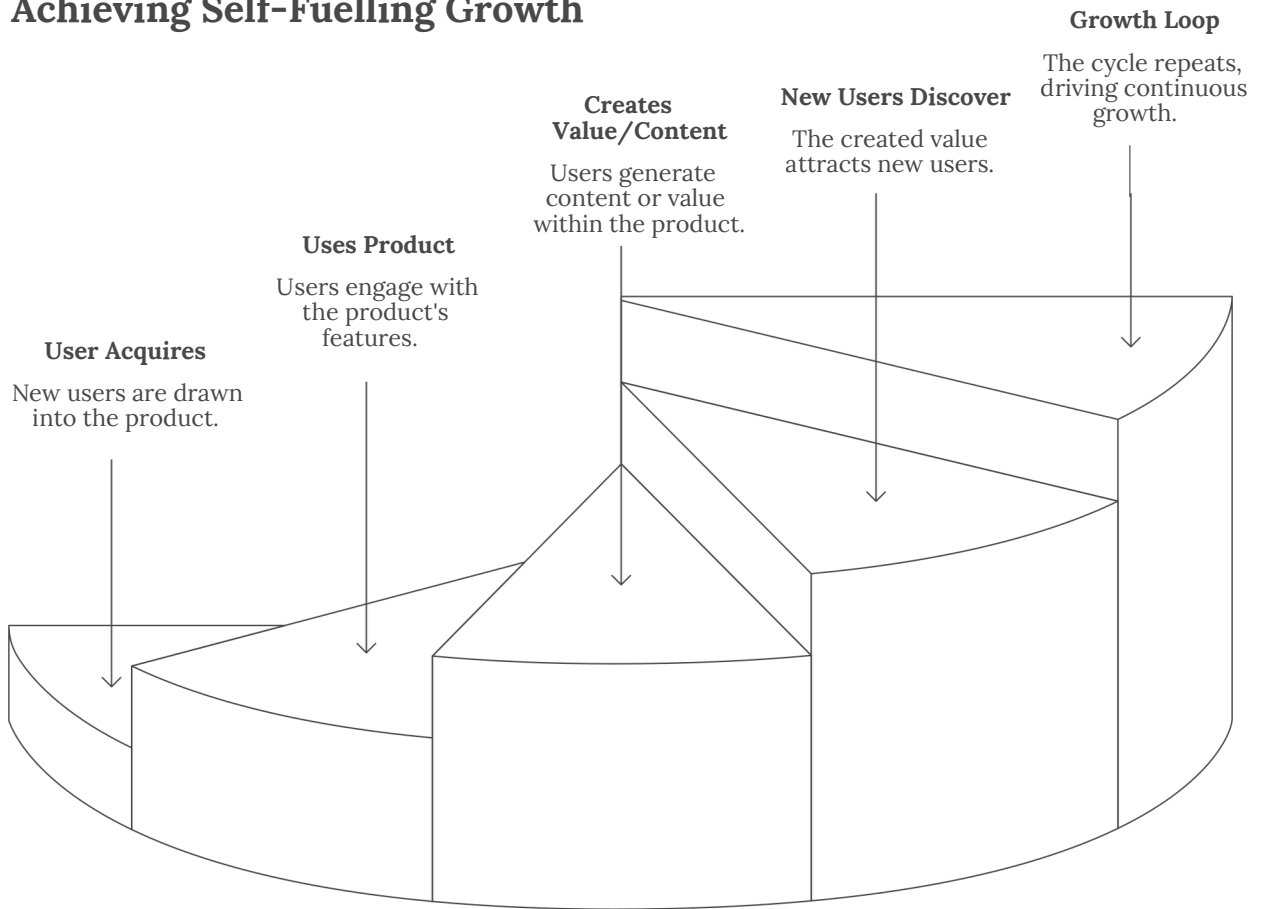
HOW TO USE IT

1. Map your current acquisition: is it a funnel or a loop? Most are funnels.
2. Identify which loop type is most natural given your product and user behaviour.
3. Design the loop explicitly, every step must be mapped and optimised.
4. Measure loop efficiency: how many new users does each existing user generate?

PRO TIP

Most founders try to build a viral loop before their product has strong retention. A leaky bucket with a viral loop just leaks faster. Fix retention first define the moment users get genuine value then build the loop around that moment. Loops only compound when the core product earns them.

Achieving Self-Fuelling Growth



AI PROMPT — COPY & PASTE READY

Act as a growth strategy advisor specialising in growth loops.

My product : [DESCRIBE WHAT IT DOES AND HOW USERS ENGAGE]

Current acquisition : [HOW YOU GET CUSTOMERS NOW]

User behaviour : [WHAT USERS DO INSIDE THE PRODUCT]

Step 1 : Identify which growth loop type is most natural for my product and user behaviour.

Step 2 : Map the complete loop, every step from new user to loop-generated next user.

Step 3 : Identify the weakest point in the loop, where do most users exit without completing it?

Step 4 : Suggest 2 specific product or marketing changes to strengthen the loop's completion rate.

Step 5 : What metric would I track to know the loop is working and improving?

Pairs well with: 5.9 AARRR Pirate Metrics · 5.5 GTM Canvas · 2.6 MVP Design

5.9 — AARRR Pirate Metrics

Find where your growth is actually leaking

USE THIS WHEN

You're investing in marketing and the numbers aren't moving. Or you have users but no revenue. Or you have revenue but high churn. You don't know which stage of your funnel is broken because you're not measuring them separately.

THE FRAMEWORK

Created by Dave McClure of 500 Startups in 2007, AARRR maps the five stages of growth: **Acquisition** (how users find you), **Activation** (when they first experience value), **Retention** (whether they come back), **Revenue** (how you make money from them), and **Referral** (whether they tell others). Most companies measure only Acquisition and Revenue the middle three stages are where the real insight and the real growth leaks are. Improving any single stage by 10% compounds across the entire funnel.

Origin: Dave McClure, 500 Startups — AARRR Pirate Metrics, 2007

HOW TO USE IT

1. Map your current metrics for all five stages before analysing you can't fix what you don't measure.
2. Identify the stage with the largest drop-off that is your biggest growth lever.
3. Fix the weakest stage before investing more in Acquisition more traffic into a broken funnel wastes money.
4. Define one specific metric per stage and review weekly.

More Traffic Won't Fix a Leak

Acquisition is the stage founders default to because it's visible, more spend, more traffic, more dashboard activity. But if Activation or Retention is where users actually drop, pouring more people into the top of a broken funnel just multiplies the leak. Fix the weak stage first.

AI PROMPT — COPY & PASTE READY

Act as a growth analytics advisor using the AARRR framework.

My business : [DESCRIBE YOUR PRODUCT AND BUSINESS MODEL]

Current metrics (fill in what you know):

Acquisition : [MONTHLY VISITORS / LEADS]

Activation : [% WHO COMPLETE FIRST KEY ACTION]

Retention : [30-DAY RETENTION RATE OR CHURN]

Revenue : [CONVERSION TO PAID / ARPU]

Referral : [NPS SCORE OR REFERRAL RATE]

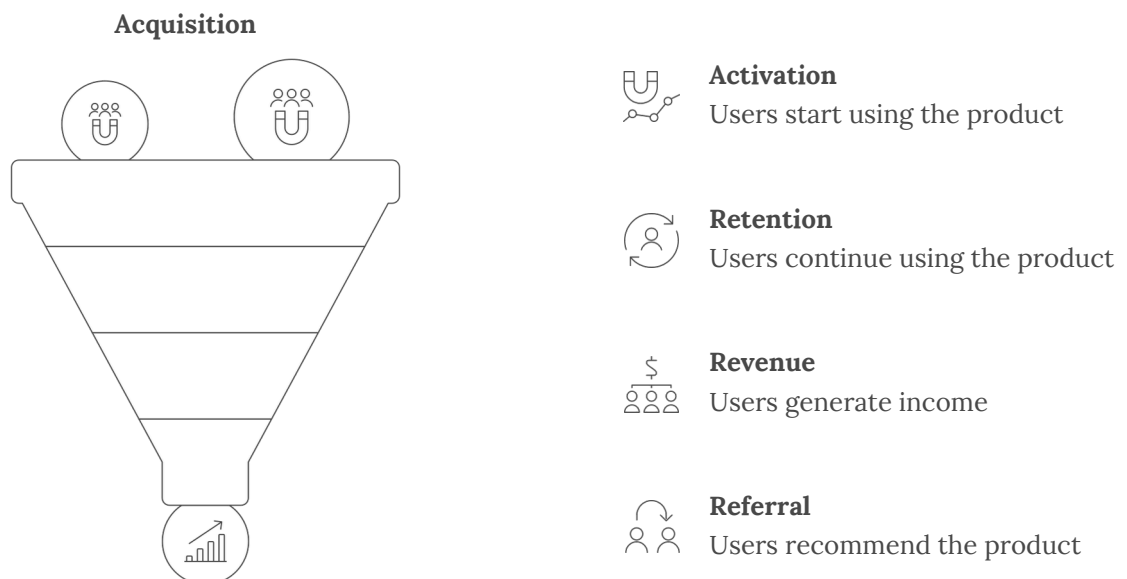
Step 1 : Identify the stage with the most critical leak.

Step 2 : For the weakest stage suggest 3 specific experiments to improve it.

Step 3 : Define one metric per stage that I should track weekly going forward.

Step 4 : If I improved each stage by 10%, model the compounding impact on revenue.

AARRR Pirate Metrics Funnel



PRO TIP

Activation is the most underinvested stage in almost every early-stage business. It is the moment a new user first experiences genuine value the 'aha moment.' If you don't know what your activation moment is, you can't optimise for it. Ask AI to help you identify and define it before running any other growth experiments.

Pairs well with: 5.8 Viral Loop · 9.3 North Star Metric · 9.1 LTV:CAC

5.10 — Flywheel Model

Build momentum that gets easier over time not harder

USE THIS WHEN

Your growth feels like pushing a boulder uphill. Every new customer takes the same effort as the last. You're working harder each quarter to hit the same numbers. Growth isn't compounding it's grinding.

THE FRAMEWORK

Jim Collins introduced the Flywheel concept in *Good to Great* (2001) as a metaphor for business momentum. **A flywheel takes enormous effort to start spinning but gains momentum** with every rotation until it becomes self-sustaining. Amazon's flywheel is the most famous **example: lower prices attract more customers**, who attract more sellers, who drive lower costs, which enable lower prices. Every business has the potential for a flywheel the question is whether you've designed it deliberately. AI can help you identify and map yours.

Origin: Jim Collins, Good to Great, 2001 — Flywheel concept · Amazon application, 2002

HOW TO USE IT

1. Map the 4–6 steps of your potential flywheel before prompting.
2. Each step must logically lead to the next if the causality isn't clear, the flywheel won't spin
3. Identify the one step in the flywheel that you need to push hardest right now.
4. Track flywheel velocity: how long does it take for a new customer to generate another?

Not Every Business Has One

Not every business has a real flywheel, sometimes what looks like one is just a list of good things that happen to be true, with no actual causality between them. If step 3 doesn't clearly cause step 4, you've drawn a diagram, not a mechanism.

AI PROMPT — COPY & PASTE READY

Act as a business strategy advisor using Jim Collins' Flywheel model.

My business : [DESCRIBE WHAT YOU DO AND YOUR GROWTH MODEL]

Current growth drivers : [WHAT IS WORKING TO GROW THE BUSINESS]

Biggest friction points : [WHERE GROWTH SLOWS OR STOPS]

Step 1 : Map my business flywheel.

Identify 4–6 steps that form a self-reinforcing loop. Each step must logically cause the next.

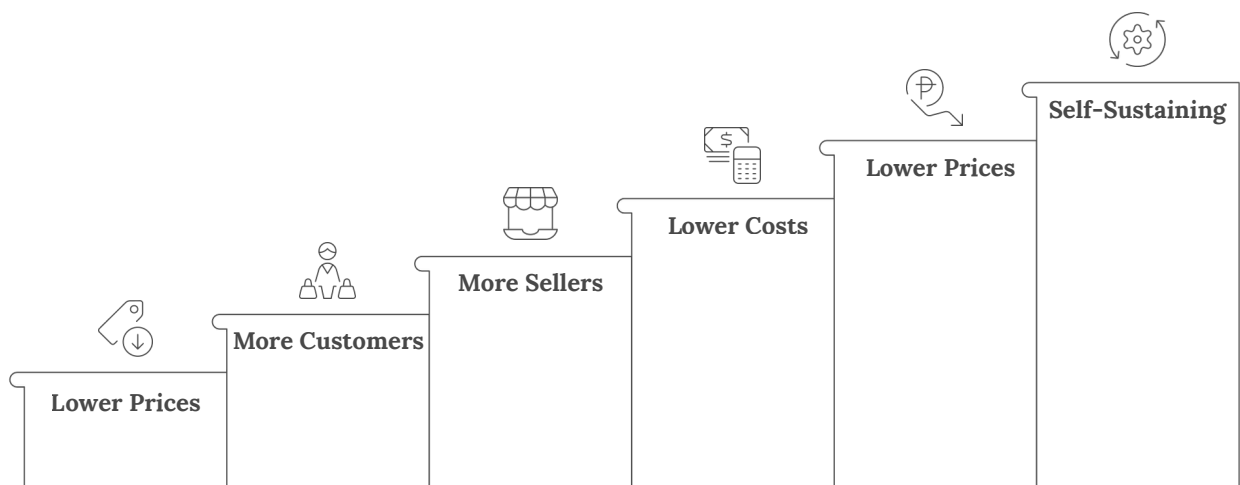
Step 2 : Name the flywheel - what is the core mechanism that drives it?

Step 3 : Identify which step in the flywheel has the most friction right now.

Step 4 : Suggest 2 specific actions to reduce friction at that step and accelerate the spin.

Compare my flywheel to Amazon's - what is similar and what is fundamentally different?

Flywheel Model — Momentum That Compounds



PRO TIP

Most founders try to build a flywheel at the business level before they have one at the customer level. Your first flywheel is simpler: a happy customer refers someone, that person becomes a customer, their success becomes your proof, proof attracts the next customer. Map that loop first and invest in making it spin faster.

Pairs well with: 5.8 Growth Loop · 5.9 AARRR · 2.8 Moat Builder · 9.1 LTV:CAC

MODULE 6

Build Your Team

Build people who build the company leadership is the product.

WHAT THIS MODULE DOES

The best product in the world fails with the wrong team. The best team in the world fails without clear direction, honest feedback, and the right structure. This module gives you the complete leadership toolkit from clarifying who owns what, to setting goals that drive real action, to having the honest conversations that most leaders avoid. It includes three Japanese leadership frameworks that bring a depth of discipline most Western management books miss.

IN THIS MODULE

- 6.1 RACI Matrix
- 6.2 OKRs — Goals That Drive Action
- 6.3 1-on-1 Framework — GROW Model
- 6.4 Hiring with AI — Talent Filter
- 6.5 SBI Feedback Model
- 6.6 Culture Code Canvas
- 6.7 Delegation Ladder
- 6.8 Meeting Design — Meeting OS
- 6.9 Radical Candor
- 6.10 Hoshin Kanri
- 6.11 Situational Leadership
- 6.12 McKinsey 7S Framework

Start here if you are new to AI, or your prompts feel hit-or-miss.

6.1 — RACI Matrix

End confusion about who owns what, permanently

USE THIS WHEN

People in your team are duplicating work, dropping tasks, or blaming each other for things that fell through the cracks. Decisions keep escalating to you. Nobody is sure who is supposed to decide what.

THE FRAMEWORK

RACI defines four roles for every task or decision: **Responsible** (does the work), **Accountable** (owns the outcome - one person only), **Consulted** (gives input before action), **Informed** (told after action). The single most important rule: there must be exactly one Accountable person per task. When two people are accountable, nobody is accountable. When this matrix is applied to your team's key processes, task duplication drops, decision speed increases, and your inbox stops filling with questions that aren't yours to answer.

Origin: Operations management best practice — RACI matrix formalised 1950s–1960s

HOW TO USE IT

1. List your team's 8–12 most important recurring tasks or decisions before prompting.
2. Map your team roles across the top use role titles, not names, so the matrix survives turnover.
3. Every task must have exactly one A, if you find two, that's your first fix.
4. Share the completed RACI with your team and run a 30-minute review, disagreements reveal your real accountability gaps.

A Chart Won't Fix Culture

A RACI chart doesn't fix a culture where nobody wants to be the one Accountable person. If your team resists filling in that column, the matrix isn't the problem, the fear of owning a visible outcome is, and that conversation has to happen before the chart means anything.

Act as an operations consultant specialising in team clarity.

Process or function : [THE AREA YOU WANT TO MAP e.g. client onboarding, monthly reporting]

Team roles involved :

[LIST YOUR ROLES: e.g. CEO, Sales Lead, Account Manager, Marketing Manager, Operations Lead]

For each key task in this process, assign:

R = Responsible (does the actual work)

A = Accountable (one person - owns the outcome)

C = Consulted (gives input before action is taken)

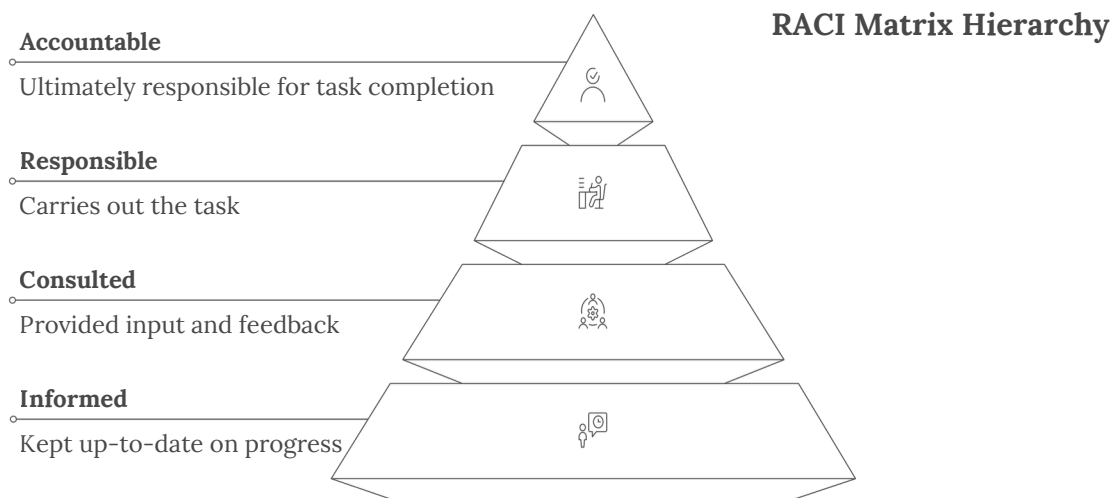
I = Informed (told after action is complete)

Format as a clear table.

Flag any task with more than one A, explain the risk.

Flag any task with no clear R.

Recommend the 2 most urgent clarity fixes.



PRO TIP

If more than one person is marked Accountable for any task, the matrix is already broken. There must be exactly one A per row that single constraint removes more team friction than any team meeting ever will. When everyone knows who owns the outcome, everything else becomes easier to delegate.

Pairs well with: 6.2 OKRs · 6.7 Delegation Ladder · 6.8 Meeting Design

6.2 — OKRs – Goals That Drive Action

Set goals your team actually works toward, not ones they forget by week two

USE THIS WHEN

Your team sets goals at the start of the quarter that nobody looks at again. Or your goals are so vague that you can't tell at the end of the quarter whether you achieved them. Activity is high, progress is unclear.

THE FRAMEWORK

OKRs were developed by Andy Grove at Intel in the 1970s and popularised by John Doerr at Google. An Objective is a qualitative, inspiring statement of where you want to go. Key Results are 2–4 specific, measurable outcomes that prove you've arrived. The critical rule: Key Results measure outcomes, not activities. 'Launch the new feature' is a task. 'Achieve 40% feature adoption among active users within 60 days' is a Key Result. OKRs work because they separate what you want to achieve from how you'll know you've achieved it.

Origin: Andy Grove, Intel – MBO adapted to OKRs · John Doerr, Google, 1999

HOW TO USE IT

1. Write the Objective as something that would genuinely excite the team, not a business metric.
2. Key Results must be measurable, if you can't put a number on it, it's not a Key Result.
3. Set 3–5 OKRs per quarter. More dilutes focus. Fewer creates over-dependence on one outcome.
4. Review OKRs in weekly team meetings, not just at quarter end.

Ambitious Targets Aren't the Point

Hitting 100% of your Key Results every quarter isn't success, it's a sign you set them too safe. OKRs work as a stretch tool, not a performance review. If your team is always green, you're measuring comfort, not progress.

Act as an OKR coach and strategist.

My business context : [COMPANY STAGE, TEAM SIZE, MAIN FOCUS]

This quarter's priority : [THE ONE THING THAT MATTERS MOST]

Current challenges : [WHAT IS HOLDING GROWTH BACK]

Write 3 OKRs for this quarter:

For each OKR:

OBJECTIVE : Inspiring, qualitative direction (1 sentence)

KEY RESULT 1 : Specific, measurable outcome with number

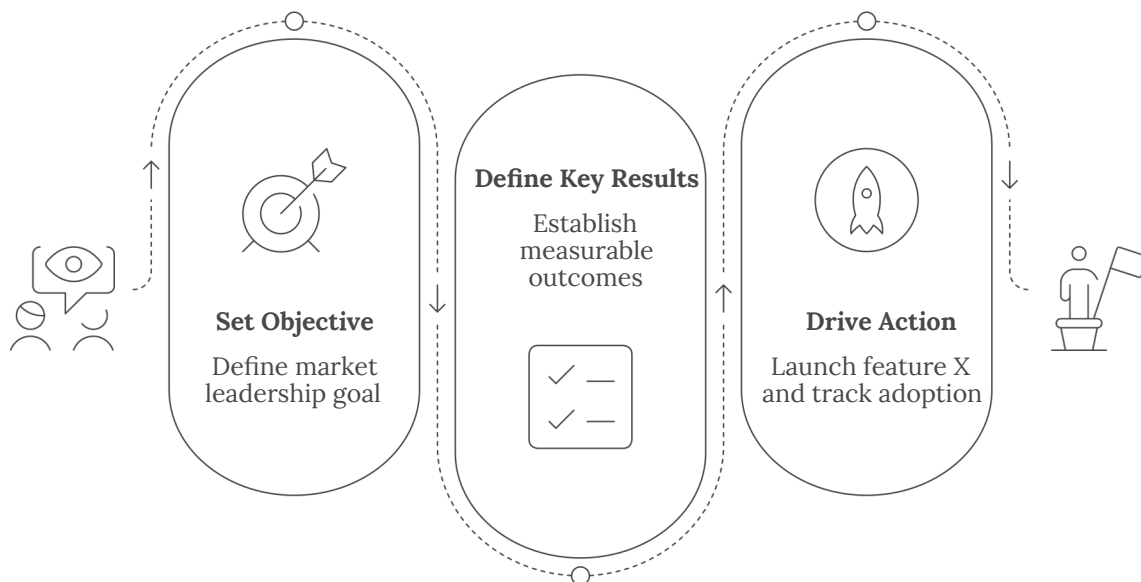
KEY RESULT 2 : Specific, measurable outcome with number

KEY RESULT 3 : Specific, measurable outcome with number

Then: flag any Key Result that is actually a task disguised as an outcome - and rewrite it.

Suggest a weekly check-in question for each OKR.

Achieving Market Leadership



PRO TIP

The most common OKR failure is writing Key Results that measure activity instead of outcome. 'Conduct 20 customer interviews' is activity. 'Identify 3 validated insights that change our roadmap' is outcome. Your team can tick off activity without moving the needle. Only outcomes tell you if you're actually winning.

6.3 — 1-on-1 Framework – GROW Model

Turn weekly check-ins into the most valuable 30 minutes of your team's week

USE THIS WHEN

Your 1-on-1s feel like status updates. You ask how things are going, they tell you, and you both move on. Nothing changes. The conversation is comfortable but not useful. Your best people are not growing and you don't know why.

THE FRAMEWORK

The GROW model was developed by Sir John Whitmore and popularised in his 1992 book *Coaching for Performance*. It is the most widely used coaching framework in the world for a reason: it works. **Goal** (what do you want to achieve in this conversation?), **Reality** (what is the current situation honestly?), **Options** (what are all the possible ways forward?), **Will** (what will you specifically commit to doing?). Applied to 1-on-1s, GROW transforms a status update into a structured coaching conversation that builds capability and accountability.

Origin: Sir John Whitmore, Coaching for Performance, 1992 – GROW model

HOW TO USE IT

1. Set the Goal at the start of every 1-on-1. What does the person want to resolve by the end?
2. In Reality, ask questions rather than giving assessments; the person's self-assessment is more valuable.
3. In Options, generate at least 3 paths before evaluating any of them.
4. Will must end with a specific action, a specific timeline, and a self-rated commitment score (1–10).

A Low Score Is the Real Data

A commitment score of 4 out of 10 is more useful than a 9; it tells you the plan won't survive the week. Don't coach the number up. Coach the plan until the number rises on its own.

AI PROMPT — COPY & PASTE READY

Act as an executive coaching facilitator using the GROW model.

Team member context : [ROLE, EXPERIENCE LEVEL, CURRENT PROJECT]

Presenting situation : [WHAT THEY HAVE BROUGHT TO THIS 1-ON-1]

Guide me through a GROW coaching conversation:

GOAL : What questions should I ask to help them define what they want to get from this conversation?

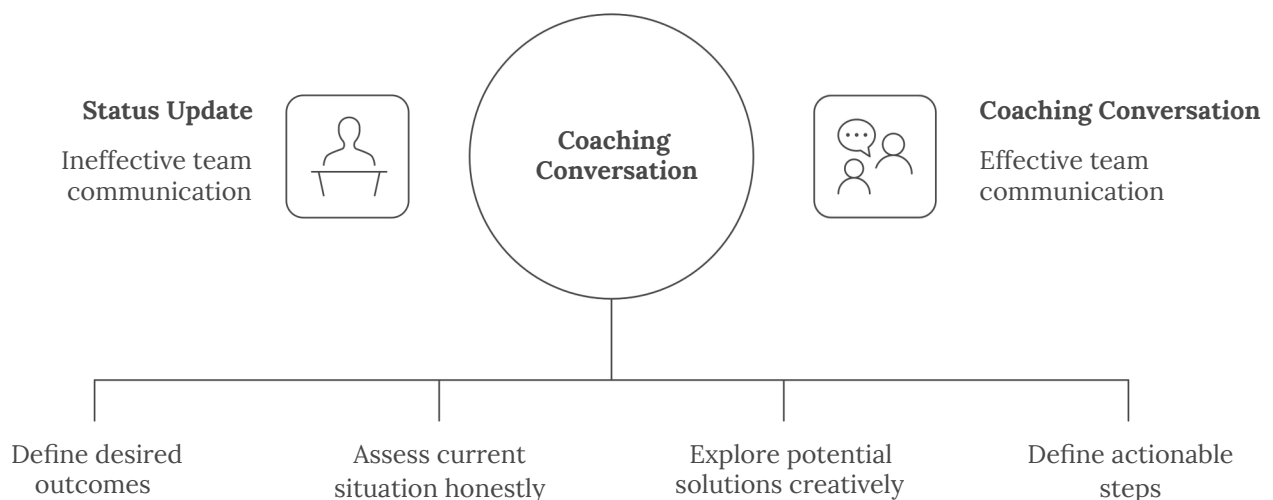
REALITY : What questions surface the honest current situation without my assumptions?

OPTIONS : What prompts generate multiple paths forward not just the obvious one?

WILL : How do I lock in a specific, committed action with a timeline and accountability?

Give me 2–3 actual questions for each stage.

GROW Model for Coaching



PRO TIP

End every GROW conversation by asking the person to rate their commitment to the agreed action on a scale of 1–10. Anything below 7 means the action is wrong, too big, wrong timing, or not genuinely chosen. Ask what would make it a 9. The answer is almost always a smaller first step or a removed obstacle.

Pairs well with: 6.5 SBI Feedback · 6.9 Radical Candor · 6.7 Delegation Ladder

6.4 — Hiring with AI –Talent Filter

Build the interview system that hire stheright person, not the best interviewer

USE THIS WHEN

You've made a hire that looked great on paper and in interviews, then didn't work out. Your hiring process relies too much on gut feel. Interviews feel like conversations but don't consistently predict performance.

THE FRAMEWORK

Structured interviewing asking all candidates the same pre-defined questions scored against consistent criteria has been shown in multiple studies to significantly outperform unstructured interviews in predicting job performance. The Talent Filter approach adds a layer: define the role's top 3–5 success criteria before writing a job description, build behavioural questions for each criterion (**STAR format: Situation, Task, Action, Result**), score each answer against a rubric, and use AI to help build both the questions and the scoring guide. The goal is to reduce bias and increase the signal-to-noise ratio of every interview.

Origin: Structured interviewing research — Schmidt & Hunter, *Journal of Applied Psychology*, 1998

HOW TO USE IT

1. Define the 3–5 success criteria for the role before writing the job description.
2. Write at least 2 STAR-format behavioural questions per criterion.
3. Score every candidate on the same rubric not your overall impression.
4. Use the prompt below to generate role-specific questions and scoring guides instantly.

Structure Doesn't Kill the Feel

"They didn't feel like a fit" is not a score, it's the bias you built this framework to remove sneaking back in through the back door. If the rubric can't explain the rejection, the rubric didn't make the decision.



Act as a structured hiring consultant.

Role I am hiring for : [JOB TITLE AND KEY RESPONSIBILITIES]

Team context : [STAGE, CULTURE, WHO THEY WILL WORK WITH]

Non-negotiables : [MUST-HAVE SKILLS OR EXPERIENCE]

Step 1 : Define the top 4 success criteria for this role

what does excellent performance look like in year one?

Step 2 : For each criterion, write 2 STAR-format behavioural interview questions.

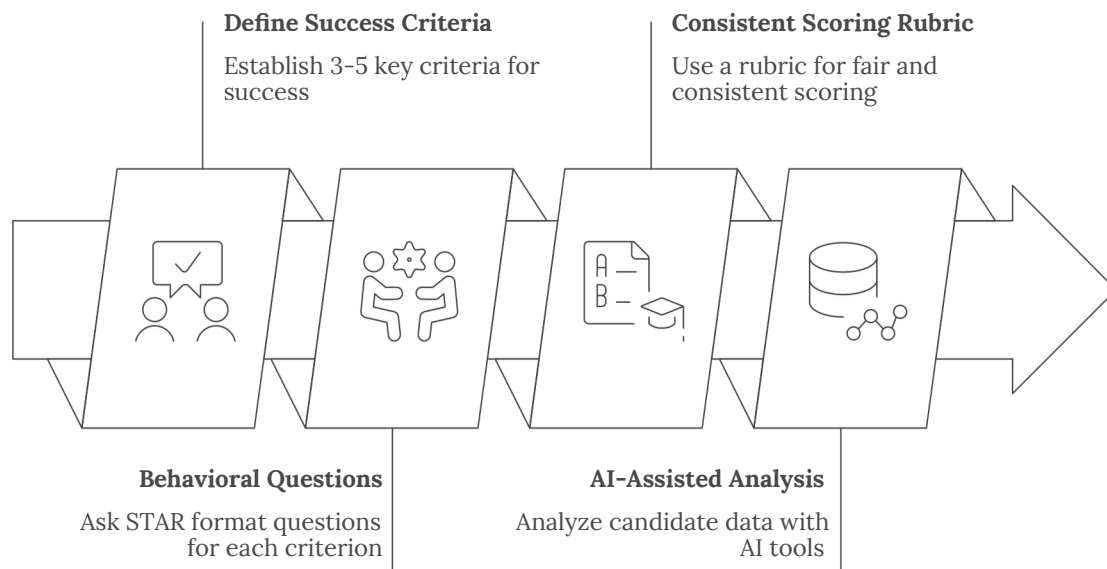
(Tell me about a time when...)

Step 3 : For each question, define what a strong answer looks like vs a weak answer
2 lines each.

Step 4 : Write one work sample task I could give candidates to test the most critical skill directly.

Step 5 : Write 3 red-flag signals to watch for in interviews.

Talent Filter Hiring Process



PRO TIP

The work sample task (Step 4) is the single highest-signal hiring tool available. A 2-hour task relevant to the actual job outpredicts any amount of interviewing. Candidates who decline the task often self-select out for good reason. Candidates who complete it brilliantly and explain their thinking are almost always the right hire.

Pairs well with: 6.2 OKRs · 6.5 SBI Feedback · 6.6 Culture Code · 6.11 Situational Leadership

6.5 — SBI Feedback Model

Give feedback that actually changes behaviour, not just makes you feel like you said it

USE THIS WHEN

You avoid giving difficult feedback because it always turns into a difficult conversation. Or you give feedback that the person defends against instead of hears. The problem stays the same, the conversation gets harder each time.

THE FRAMEWORK

Developed by the Center for Creative Leadership, the SBI model structures feedback across three elements: **Situation** (the specific context, when and where), **Behaviour** (the observable action, what you saw or heard, not your interpretation), and **Impact** (the effect the behaviour had on you, the team, or the outcome). SBI removes the most common feedback failure modes: vague generalisations ('you're not a team player'), character judgements ('you're disorganised'), and assumed intent ('you clearly don't care'). AI can help you convert a difficult feedback situation into a clean SBI statement.

Origin: Center for Creative Leadership — SBI Feedback Model

HOW TO USE IT

1. Write the Behaviour in observable terms only what you could have filmed, not what you interpreted.
2. State the Impact from your perspective, 'I felt' or 'the team experienced' - not 'you caused.'
3. Deliver the SBI statement and then pause, ask the person what they think, before adding anything.
4. Use SBI for positive feedback too specific positive feedback is far more memorable than general praise



SBI removes judgment from your language, but the pause after delivering it is where the real change happens. Skip the pause and rush to solutions, and it's still a lecture, just a well-structured one.

Act as a leadership development coach.

Situation I need to give feedback on:

[DESCRIBE WHAT HAPPENED - THE CONTEXT AND BEHAVIOUR]

Format this as a clean SBI feedback statement:

SITUATION : When and where exactly did this happen? Be specific - meeting, call, report, date.

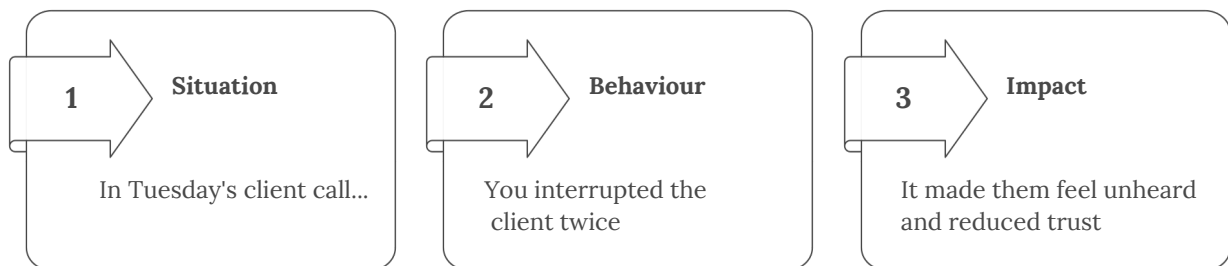
BEHAVIOUR : What specifically did I observe? Observable actions only, no interpretation.

IMPACT : What effect did this have? On me, on the team, on the outcome.

Then write 2 follow-up questions I should ask after delivering the SBI to open a dialogue.

Finally : rewrite the same feedback as it would typically be delivered badly, so I can see the difference.

SBI Feedback Model



PRO TIP

The most powerful part of SBI is what comes after the pause. Deliver the Impact statement and stop talking. Most leaders fill the silence with justifications or softening language that undoes the feedback. Let the person respond to what they heard. Their response tells you everything about whether the feedback landed.

Pairs well with: 6.9 Radical Candor · 6.3 GROW Model · 6.8 Meeting Design

6.6 — Culture Code Canvas

Define your culture before your culture defines itself without you

USE THIS WHEN

Your team is growing and people are joining who haven't been shaped by your founding culture. Or different parts of the team have different norms and it's causing friction. Culture is happening but not the one you intended.

THE FRAMEWORK

Daniel Coyle's research in *The Culture Code* identified three core elements of high-performing team cultures: **Safety** (people feel they can speak up without risk), **Vulnerability** (leaders show imperfection, creating permission for others to do the same), and **Purpose** (a shared sense of why the work matters). The Culture Code Canvas operationalises these into a practical document that defines your team's values, behaviours, decision-making norms, and cultural boundaries, the things you hire for, reward, and fire for.

Origin: Daniel Coyle, The Culture Code, 2018

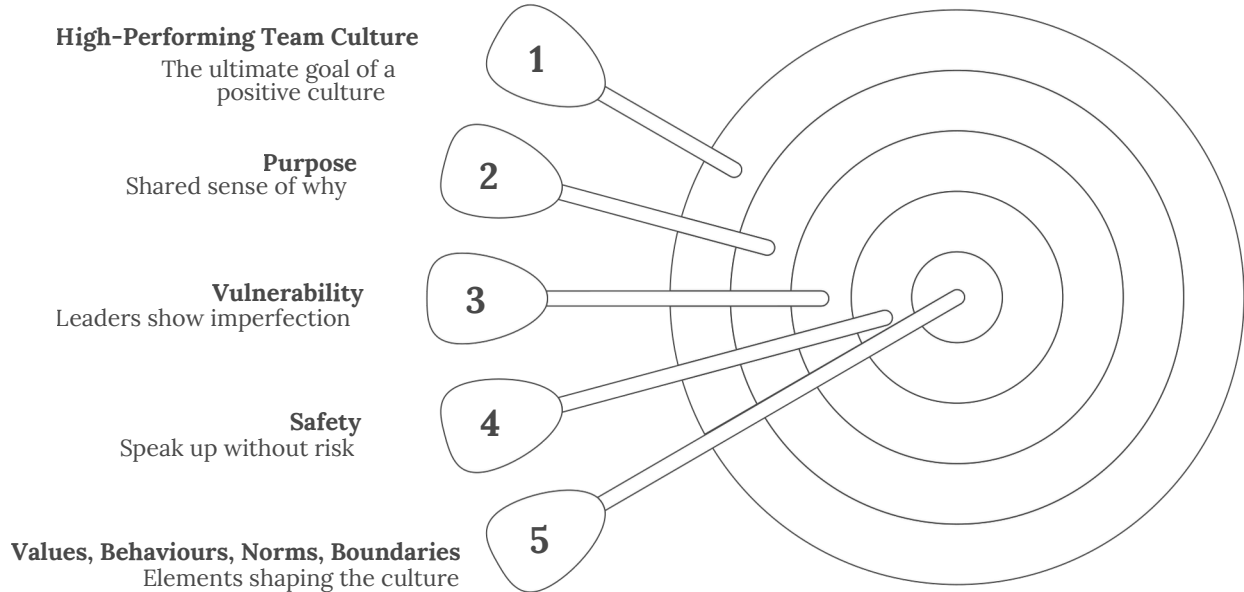
HOW TO USE IT

1. Write your culture code based on how you actually behave, not how you aspire to behave.
2. For each value, write a behaviour that demonstrates it and a behaviour that violates it.
3. Share the culture code with every new hire in their first week before their first project.
4. Review and update annually cultures drift, and drift is invisible until it's damage.

PRO TIP

The 'what we don't tolerate' section is the most important and the most avoided. Every culture has things it informally tolerates that it publicly says it doesn't. Write the real list, not the aspirational one. The gap between what you say you won't tolerate and what you actually do tolerate is exactly where culture breaks down.

Culture Code Canvas



AI PROMPT – COPY & PASTE READY

Act as a leadership development advisor using the Delegation Ladder.

My role : [YOUR TITLE AND KEY RESPONSIBILITIES]

Team : [TEAM SIZE, EXPERIENCE LEVELS, KEY ROLES]

I will list my current recurring decisions.

For each : assess the current delegation level I operate at, recommend the target level, and explain what needs to be true to move there safely.

Delegation levels:

- 1 – Tell: I decide, inform
- 2 – Sell: I decide, explain why
- 3 – Consult: I ask for input before deciding
- 4 – Agree: We decide together
- 5 – Advise: They decide, I give input
- 6 – Inquire: They decide, tell me after
- 7 – Delegate: Fully theirs

My decisions to assess:

[LIST YOUR 8-10 KEY RECURRING DECISIONS]

Flag the 3 decisions I should delegate first
and what support each person needs to own them.

Pairs well with: 6.4 Hiring · 6.9 Radical Candor · 6.5 SBI Feedback · 6.11 Situational Leadership

6.7 — Delegation Ladder

Stop doing everything yourself, systematically handover what doesn't need you

USE THIS WHEN

You're the bottleneck in your own business. Everything flows through you. Your team is capable but waits for your approval on decisions you shouldn't be making. You work longer than anyone and still feel behind.

THE FRAMEWORK

The Delegation Ladder, developed within the Management 3.0 framework by Jurgen Appelo, defines seven levels of delegation: **Tell** (I decide, inform you), **Sell** (I decide, explain why), **Consult** (I ask your input before deciding), **Agree** (we decide together), **Advise** (you decide with my input), **Inquire** (you decide, tell me after), **Delegate** (you decide, no need to tell me). Most founders operate at level 1–2 when their team is ready for levels 4–6. The mismatch creates bottlenecks, kills team motivation, and limits growth.

Origin: Jurgen Appelo, Management 3.0 — Delegation Poker / Delegation Ladder

HOW TO USE IT

1. Map your top 10 recurring decisions against the 7 levels — honestly.
2. Identify every decision currently at level 1–2 that could safely move to level 4–5.
3. Have an explicit conversation with each team member about their current and target delegation level.
4. Move delegation levels up gradually one level at a time, with clear checkpoints.

The Mismatch Is Yours, Not Theirs

If you jump a decision from level 2 straight to level 6, you're not delegating, you're abandoning. The ladder works because it moves one rung at a time, giving the person a chance to prove readiness before the stakes get real. Skipping rungs isn't trust, it's a shortcut that backfires.

AI PROMPT — COPY & PASTE READY

Act as a leadership development advisor using the Delegation Ladder.

My role : [YOUR TITLE AND KEY RESPONSIBILITIES]

Team : [TEAM SIZE, EXPERIENCE LEVELS, KEY ROLES]

I will list my current recurring decisions.

For each : assess the current delegation level I operate at, recommend the target level, and explain what needs to be true to move there safely.

Delegation levels:

1 — Tell: I decide, inform

2 — Sell: I decide, explain why

3 — Consult: I ask for input before deciding

4 — Agree: We decide together

5 — Advise: They decide, I give input

6 — Inquire: They decide, tell me after

7 — Delegate: Fully theirs

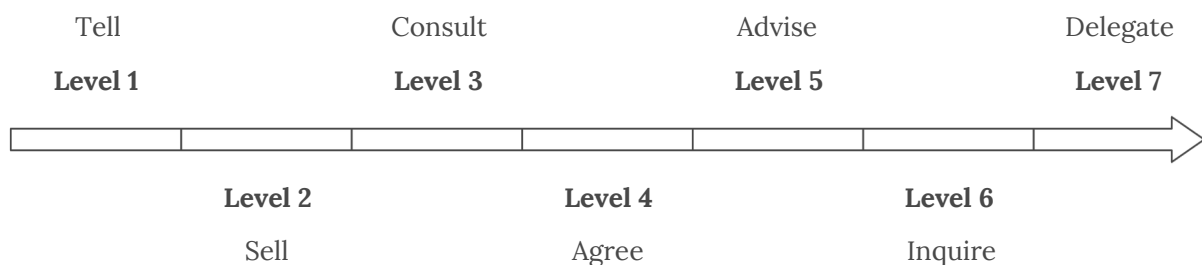
My decisions to assess:

[LIST YOUR 8–10 KEY RECURRING DECISIONS]

Flag the 3 decisions I should delegate first

and what support each person needs to own them.

Delegation Ladder 7 Levels of Letting Go



PRO TIP

The hardest delegation move is not from level 2 to level 5 it is from level 3 to level 4. Asking for input (3) still feels like control. Deciding together (4) requires genuine trust that the person's judgment is sound. That trust is built through smaller delegations done well. Start with level 4 on low-stakes decisions and build from there.

Pairs well with: 6.1 RACI Matrix · 6.3 GROW Model · 6.2 OKRs · 6.11 Situational Leadership

6.8 — Meeting Design – Meeting OS

Make every meeting earn its time or cancel it

USE THIS WHEN

Your team spends too much time in meetings that end without clear decisions or actions. People leave unclear on what was agreed, who will do what, or why the meeting needed to happen at all.

THE FRAMEWORK

Drawing from Patrick Lencioni's work on organisational health and broader meeting efficiency research, the Meeting OS is a set of design principles for every recurring and ad hoc meeting: **define the meeting type** (decision, discussion, update, or brainstorm), **set the agenda** 24 hours in advance, **start with the most important** item first, **assign** one facilitator, end with **explicit decisions and owners recorded**, and send a **summary** within an hour. AI can design a complete meeting operating system for any team structure.

Origin: Patrick Lencioni, Death by Meeting, 2004 • Meeting efficiency research

HOW TO USE IT

1. Define the type of every standing meeting most teams mix types and get the worst of each.
2. Put the hardest agenda item first energy and attention decline through a meeting, not increase.
3. End every meeting with the read-out: what was decided, who owns it, by when.
4. Audit all standing meetings quarterly, cancel any that have become status updates disguised as collaboration.

A Read-Out Isn't a Decision

Sending a summary within an hour doesn't mean the meeting worked. If the read-out says "we discussed X" instead of "we decided X, owner Y, by Z," the meeting still didn't earn its time.

AI PROMPT — COPY & PASTE READY

Act as an organisational design consultant specialising in meeting efficiency.

My team : [SIZE, ROLES, WORKING STYLE REMOTE / IN-PERSON / HYBRID]

Current meetings: [LIST YOUR STANDING MEETINGS AND THEIR FREQUENCY]

Main frustrations: [WHAT IS BROKEN ABOUT MEETINGS RIGHT NOW]

Design a complete Meeting OS for my team:

MEETING TYPES: Define 4 meeting types and when each is used

STANDING MEETINGS: For each existing meeting

- Type (decision / discussion / update / brainstorm)
- Correct frequency and duration
- Required attendees vs optional
- Agenda format

MEETING RULES : 5 non-negotiable norms for all meetings

DECISION LOG : How we capture and share what was decided

MEETING AUDIT : Which of my current meetings should be cancelled, merged, or reformatted?

Meeting Design Checklist



PRO TIP

The most productive meeting reform any team can make is adding a mandatory read-out at the end of every meeting: 'What did we decide? Who owns each action? By when?' This 3-minute habit prevents the most common meeting failure, leaving with different understandings of what was agreed.

Pairs well with: 6.1 RACI Matrix · 6.2 OKRs · 6.5 SBI Feedback

6.9 — Radical Candor

Care personally. Challenge directly. Do both at the same time.

USE THIS WHEN

You avoid giving direct feedback because you don't want to hurt people. Or you give feedback so bluntly that people feel attacked rather than helped. You're either too nice or too hard and neither works.

THE FRAMEWORK

Kim Scott developed Radical Candor at Google and Apple as a two-axis model of leadership communication. The axes are **Care Personally** (do you genuinely care about the person as a human being?) and **Challenge Directly** (do you say what you think clearly and specifically?). High on both = **Radical Candor** (the goal). High challenge, low care = **Obnoxious Aggression**. High care, low challenge = **Ruinous Empathy** (the most common failure). Low on both = **Manipulative Insincerity**. Most founders default to Ruinous Empathy - they avoid the hard conversation because they care about the person, but the kindest thing they could do is have it.

Origin: Kim Scott, *Radical Candor*, 2017

HOW TO USE IT

1. Before any difficult feedback, check: is this coming from genuine care, or is it about you?
2. Challenge directly means saying the specific thing, not softening it to the point of unrecognisability.
3. Start by soliciting candid feedback about yourself before expecting it from others it earns trust.
4. Use the SBI model (6.5) to structure the content of Radical Candor conversations.



Calling yourself "direct" doesn't excuse Obnoxious Aggression, care personally comes first for a reason. If the person can't feel you're on their side, the challenge lands as an attack, no matter how honest it was.

Act as a leadership communication coach using Kim Scott's Radical Candor framework.

Situation : [DESCRIBE THE PERSON, THE PERFORMANCE ISSUE, AND WHAT YOU HAVE SAID OR AVOIDED SO FAR]

Step 1: Diagnose which quadrant I am currently in:

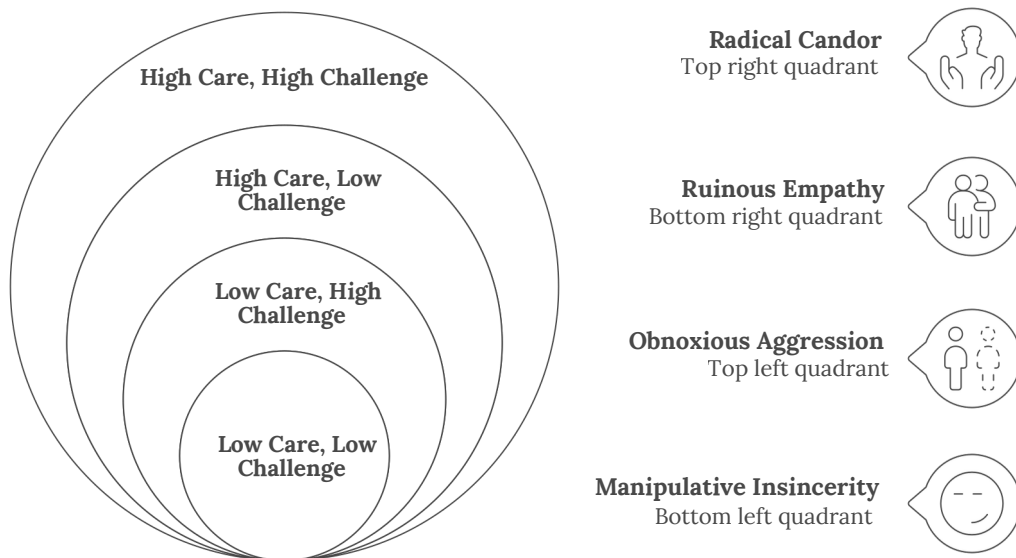
- Radical Candor (high care + high challenge)
- Ruinous Empathy (high care + low challenge)
- Obnoxious Aggression (low care + high challenge)
- Manipulative Insincerity (low on both)

Step 2: Write the Radical Candor version of this conversation what I should actually say.

Step 3: Write the Ruinous Empathy version the version I am probably tempted to give.

Step 4: Give me 2 opening lines that demonstrate both care and directness simultaneously.

Radical Candor Matrix



PRO TIP

Ruinous Empathy is the most harmful leadership style precisely because it feels kind. When you protect someone from honest feedback, you protect yourself from an uncomfortable conversation and deny them the information they need to grow. The person who needs the feedback most is the one whose manager feels worst about giving it.

Pairs well with: 6.5 SBI Feedback · 6.3 GROW Model · 6.5 Culture Code

6.10 — Hoshin Kanri

Connect your company vision to daily team action without losing anything in translation

USE THIS WHEN

Your company has a clear vision and your team works hard but there is a gap between the strategic direction and what people are actually working on day to day. The vision stays at the top and doesn't reach the ground.

THE FRAMEWORK

Hoshin Kanri (Japanese: direction management) is a **strategic planning and execution** framework developed in Japan in the 1950s, refined at Toyota and Bridgestone, and adopted by many Fortune 500 companies. It cascades organisational objectives through every level of the company using a **'catchball' process goals are thrown back and forth between leadership and teams until both sides agree** on what is achievable and how it connects. The result is a company where every person's daily work is visibly connected to the company's annual and long-term goals.

Origin: Yoji Akao, Toyota / Bridgestone — Hoshin Kanri, Japan, 1950s–1960s

HOW TO USE IT

1. Start with your True North, your 3–5 year vision before setting annual objectives.
2. Use the catchball process: share objectives with teams, ask them to set their own targets, adjust together.
3. Limit to 3–5 annual breakthrough objectives, Hoshin Kanri is about focus, not comprehensiveness.
4. Review monthly: are the team-level actions actually moving the company-level metrics?



Catchball only works if leadership actually adjusts the target when a team pushes back, if it's just a one-way announcement dressed up as dialogue, the process is theater, and your team will spot it fast.

AI PROMPT — COPY & PASTE READY

Act as a Hoshin Kanri strategy consultant.

Company vision (3–5 years) : [WHERE YOU ARE HEADING]

This year's priority : [THE ONE BREAKTHROUGH OBJECTIVE FOR THIS YEAR]

Team structure : [LIST YOUR TEAMS OR FUNCTIONAL AREAS]

Build a Hoshin Kanri cascade:

TRUE NORTH : The 3–5 year vision in one clear sentence

ANNUAL OBJECTIVE : The single most important thing to achieve this year

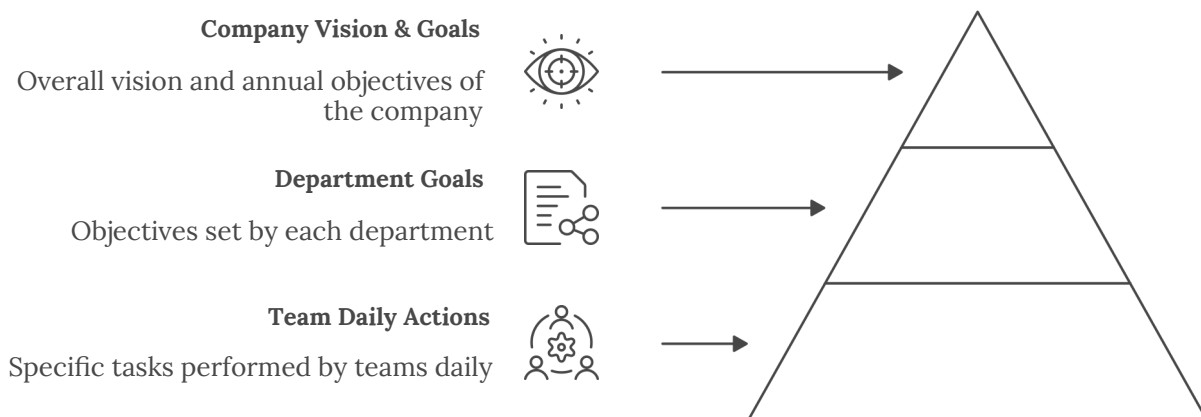
TEAM OBJECTIVES : For each team what they must deliver to support the annual objective

MONTHLY MILESTONES : Key proof points for each quarter

CATCHBALL QUESTIONS : 3 questions I should ask each team lead to align their objectives

WARNING SIGNALS : What would tell me the cascade has broken down?

Hoshin Kanri Hierarchy



PRO TIP

The most common Hoshin failure is confusing activity alignment with outcome alignment. Every team can be busy doing things that connect to the objective on paper but don't move the metric. Build the cascade around outcomes at every level not initiatives. If you can't draw a straight line from a team member's daily work to a company metric, the cascade has a gap.

Pairs well with: 6.2 OKRs · 6.1 RACI Matrix · 9.7 Balanced Scorecard · 10.5 3 Horizons

6.11 — Situational Leadership

Lead each person the way they need to be led, not the way you prefer to lead

USE THIS WHEN

You lead everyone the same way. Some team members thrive under your style. Others seem disengaged, over-dependent, or frustrated. You're not sure whether to give more direction or more autonomy and you default to one regardless of the person.

THE FRAMEWORK

Developed by Paul Hersey and Ken Blanchard in 1969, Situational Leadership proposes that no single leadership style works for all people in all situations. Effective leadership adapts to two variables: the **team member's Competence** (knowledge and skill for the specific task) and **Commitment** (motivation and confidence). The four resulting styles are: **Directing** (high task, low support for low competence, high commitment), **Coaching** (high task, high support for some competence, variable commitment), **Supporting** (low task, high support for high competence, low confidence), and **Delegating** (low task, low support for high competence, high commitment).

Origin: Paul Hersey & Ken Blanchard, *Management of Organizational Behavior*, 1969

HOW TO USE IT

1. Assess each team member on each task not overall. Someone can be 'Delegate' in one area and 'Direct' in another.
2. The most common mismatch: over-delegating to someone still in the Coaching stage.
3. Move people through the stages deliberately each stage requires a different conversation.
4. Use AI to prepare adjustments for a specific person on a specific task.



Someone at "Delegate" on their core skill can still be at "Directing" on a brand-new task, reassess per task, not per person, or you'll either smother a strong performer or set up a beginner to fail.

AI PROMPT — COPY & PASTE READY

Act as a situational leadership coach.

Team member : [ROLE, EXPERIENCE LEVEL, PERSONALITY]

Specific task or project : [WHAT YOU NEED THEM TO DO]

Step 1 : Assess their Development Level for this task:

- **D1** — Low competence, high commitment (enthusiastic beginner)
- **D2** — Some competence, low commitment (disillusioned learner)
- **D3** — High competence, variable commitment (capable but cautious)
- **D4** — High competence, high commitment (self-reliant achiever)

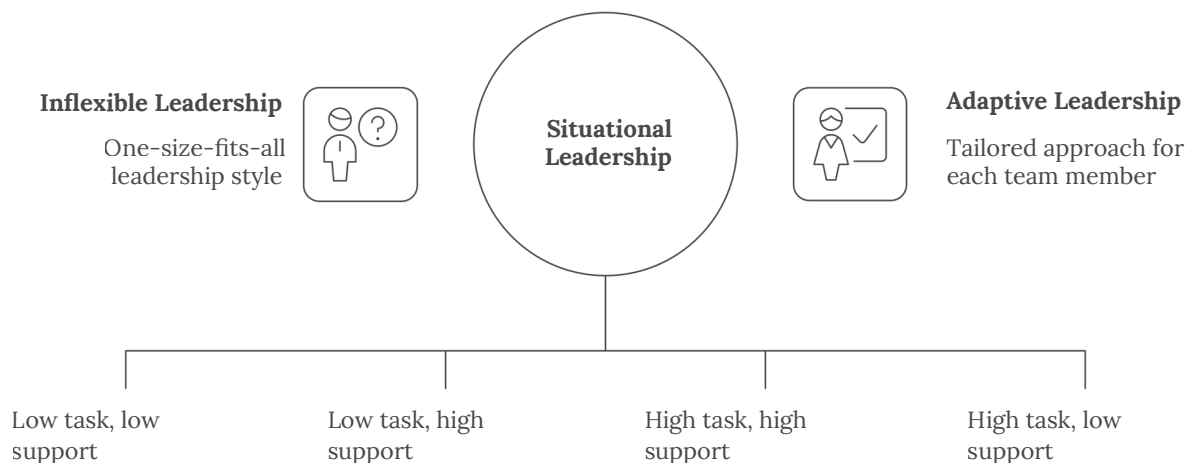
Step 2 : Recommend the matching leadership style:

- S1 — Directing S2 — Coaching
- S3 — Supporting S4 — Delegating

Step 3 : Write the specific conversation I should have with them this week using that style.

Step 4 : What would move them to the next development level and how long should that take?

Adapt Leadership to Team Competence



PRO TIP

The hardest Situational Leadership move is stepping back to Directing with someone you've been Delegating to when they've taken on a new challenge they're not yet ready for. Leaders resist this because it feels like demotion. Frame it as 'this is a new area let's work through it together' rather than a reversal of trust.

Pairs well with: 6.3 GROW Model · 6.7 Delegation Ladder · 6.4 Hiring · 6.9 Radical Candor

6.12 — McKinsey 7S Framework

Diagnose why change isn't sticking and what to fix first

USE THIS WHEN

You've made a strategic shift new direction, new structure, new hires but results aren't following. Something is misaligned but you can't identify what. The strategy is clear but the execution keeps resisting it.

THE FRAMEWORK

Developed by McKinsey consultants Tom Peters and Robert Waterman in 1980, the 7S Framework maps seven interdependent elements of an organisation that must all be aligned for strategy to work. The **Hard Ss** - **Strategy** (plan), **Structure** (org chart), **Systems** (processes and IT) are the visible elements. The **Soft Ss** - **Shared Values** (culture and beliefs), **Skills** (capabilities), **Style** (leadership approach), **Staff** (people) - are invisible but often more powerful. When any element is misaligned with the others, change stalls. AI can run a 7S diagnostic on your business and identify where the friction lives.

Origin: Tom Peters & Robert Waterman, McKinsey & Company — 7S Framework, 1980

HOW TO USE IT

1. Run a 7S audit whenever a strategy, restructure, or major change is not producing expected results.
2. Shared Values sits at the centre of the model, it is the element that all others must align to.
3. Changing one S always affects others, map the cascade before acting.
4. Use the output to prioritise: fix the most misaligned S before addressing the others.

The Soft Ss Take Longer

Fixing Structure or Systems can happen in a quarter. Shifting Shared Values or Style takes years, not months. If your 7S audit says culture is the misalignment, don't expect the same timeline you'd use for an org chart change.

AI PROMPT — COPY & PASTE READY

Act as a McKinsey organisational consultant using the 7S Framework.

My company : [DESCRIBE YOUR BUSINESS, STAGE, RECENT CHANGES]

The strategy I am trying to execute: [WHAT YOU WANT TO ACHIEVE]

What is not working : [WHERE EXECUTION IS STALLING]

Diagnose all 7 elements for my organisation:

STRATEGY : The plan, is it clear and understood?

STRUCTURE : How are we organised, does it serve the strategy?

SYSTEMS : Processes, tools do they enable or block?

SHARED VALUES : Culture - does it support or resist the change?

SKILLS : Do we have the capability we need?

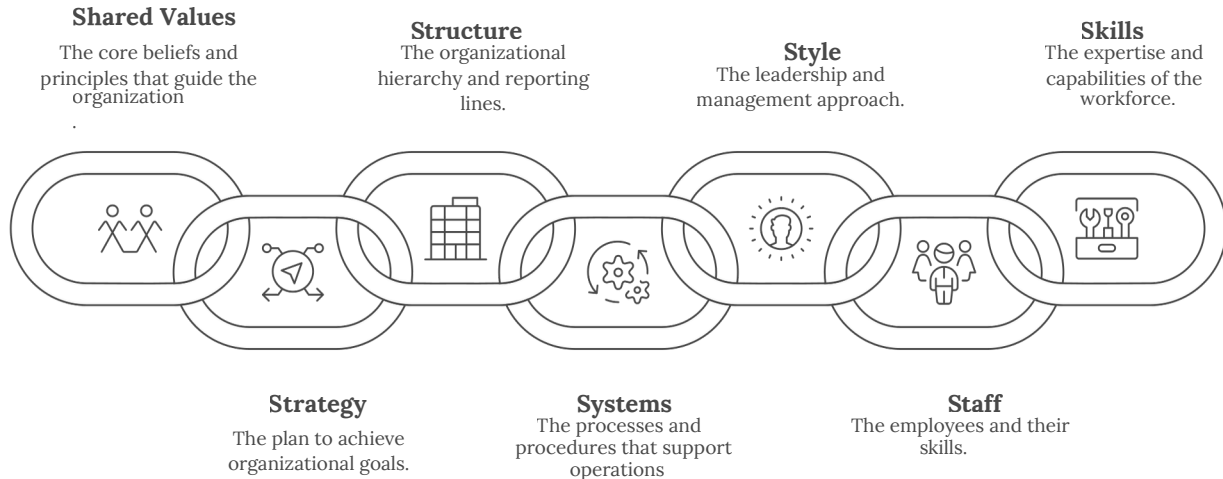
STYLE : Does leadership behaviour match the strategy?

STAFF : Do we have the right people in the right roles?

Identify the 2 most misaligned Ss.

Recommend the sequence to address them with a suggested timeframe for each step.

McKinsey 7S Framework



PRO TIP

The most common 7S misalignment is between Strategy and Shared Values. Leadership changes direction but the culture hasn't moved and culture always wins. If your strategy requires behaviours that your current culture punishes or ignores, fix the culture alignment before investing more in the strategy.

Pairs well with: 6.6 Culture Code · 6.10 Hoshin Kanri · 6.2 OKRs · 8.5 Scenario Planning

MODULE 7

Operate with Precision

Build systems that run without you and improve without being told.

WHAT THIS MODULE DOES

A business that depends on heroic effort every day is not a business, it is a job you cannot quit. This module gives you the operational frameworks to document, automate, prioritise, and improve your processes including three Japanese methodologies from Toyota's production system that have shaped modern operations management worldwide. When your operations run on systems, your team's energy goes to growth, not firefighting.

IN THIS MODULE

- 7.1 SOP Generation — SIPOC
- 7.2 Workflow Mapping — Swimlane Diagram
- 7.3 Theory of Constraints
- 7.4 ICE Scoring
- 7.5 RICE Scoring
- 7.6 PDCA Cycle
- 7.7 Working Backwards
- 7.8 Agile Sprint Canvas
- 7.9 Kaizen — Continuous Improvement
- 7.10 5S Framework
- 7.11 Poka-Yoke — Error Proofing
- 7.12 5 Whys — Root Cause Analysis

Start here if you are new to AI, or your prompts feel hit-or-miss.

7.1 — SOP Generation – SIPOC

Turn the process in your head into a document anyone can follow

USE THIS WHEN

Your business relies on people remembering how to do things. When someone leaves or is absent, quality drops. You spend time explaining the same process repeatedly instead of running the business.

THE FRAMEWORK

SIPOC is a Six Sigma process mapping tool that defines a process across five elements: **Suppliers** (who provides inputs), **Inputs** (what is needed to start), **Process** (the steps in sequence), **Outputs** (what is produced), **Customers** (who receives the output). Used as the structure for a Standard Operating Procedure (SOP), it ensures every process is fully documented not just the steps, but the context, the handoffs, and the success criteria. AI can generate a first-draft SOP for any process you describe in plain language.

Origin: Six Sigma methodology – SIPOC tool, widely used since 1980s

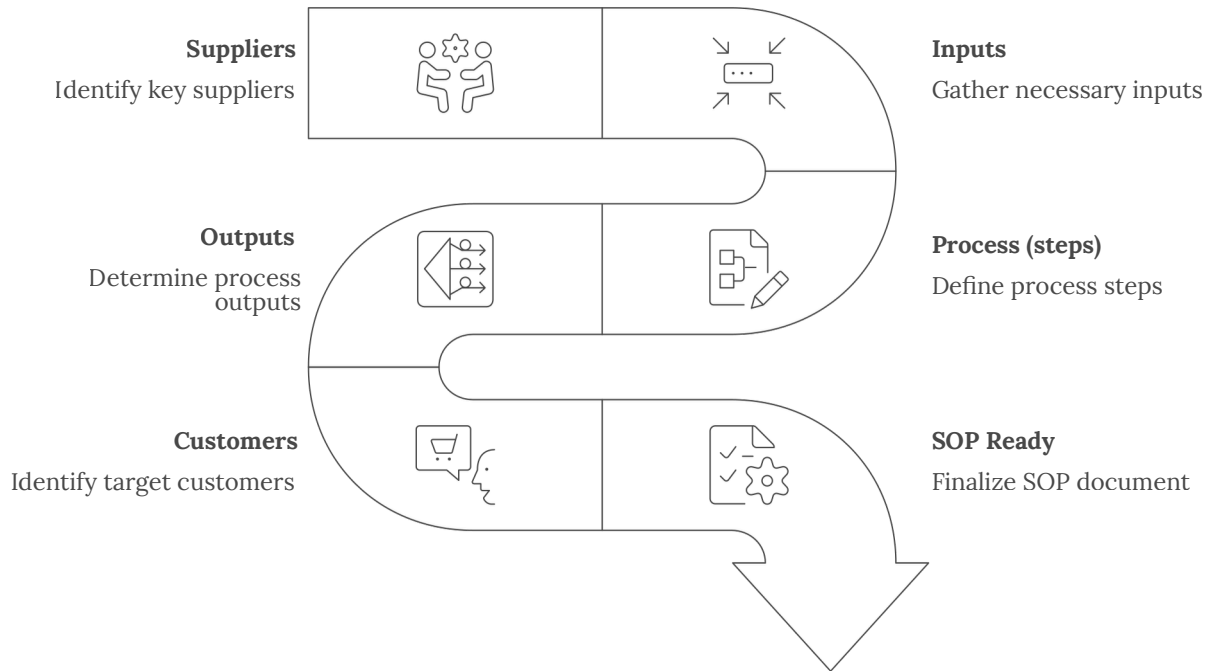
HOW TO USE IT

1. Describe the process in plain language first don't try to structure it as you describe it.
2. After AI generates the SOP, walk through it physically and correct any gaps.
3. Assign a process owner, one person responsible for keeping the SOP current.
4. Review all SOPs every six months or after any significant process change.

PRO TIP

The most valuable line in any SOP is the Quality Check column how do you know each step was done correctly? Most SOPs document what to do but not how to verify it was done right. Adding one quality signal per step is the difference between a document that is followed and one that is ignored.

SIPOC – Turn the Process in Your Head Into a Document Anyone Can Follow



AI PROMPT – COPY & PASTE READY

Act as an operations consultant specialising in SOP documentation.

Process to document : [NAME AND DESCRIBE THE PROCESS]

Who performs it : [ROLE AND EXPERIENCE LEVEL]

Tools and systems used : [SOFTWARE, PLATFORMS, RESOURCES]

How often it runs : [DAILY / WEEKLY / PER PROJECT]

Generate a complete SOP using the SIPOC structure:

SIPOC OVERVIEW:

Suppliers → Inputs → Process Steps → Outputs → Customers

FULL SOP:

Purpose : Why this process exists

Scope : What is and is not included

Owner : Who is responsible for this process

Steps : Numbered steps with decision points noted

Quality : How to know each step was done correctly

Errors : Common mistakes and how to avoid them

Review : When and how this SOP should be updated

Pairs well with: 7.2 Swimlane Mapping · 7.11 Poka-Yoke · 6.1 RACI Matrix

7.2 — Workflow Mapping – Swimlane Diagram

See exactly where handoffs break before they break again

USE THIS WHEN

Work keeps falling through the cracks at the same points. Two people think someone else owns the handoff. Processes that should be smooth have invisible gaps that only become visible when something goes wrong.

THE FRAMEWORK

A Swimlane diagram maps a process across multiple roles or departments, with each role occupying its own horizontal lane. Every action in the process is placed in the lane of the person responsible. Handoffs where work moves from one lane to another, become immediately visible. The diagram reveals where **delays, duplications, and accountability gaps cluster**. For complex multi-team processes, it is the clearest way to see the whole picture at once. AI can generate swimlane descriptions and identify the highest-risk handoffs when given process context.

Origin: Process improvement methodology — swimlane diagrams formalised 1940s onwards

HOW TO USE IT

1. Map each role involved in the process as a separate lane. 2. Mark every handoff explicitly, the arrows between lanes are where most failures happen.
2. Look for lanes with the most incoming arrows, that person is your bottleneck.
3. After mapping, identify the one handoff that fails most often and redesign it first.



A swimlane diagram shows you where the handoff breaks, not why. If a lane has too many incoming arrows, the fix is rarely "work harder", it's usually a workload or ownership problem the diagram alone won't solve.

AI PROMPT — COPY & PASTE READY

Act as a process improvement consultant specialising in workflow mapping.

Process to map : [NAME AND DESCRIBE THE PROCESS END TO END]

Roles involved : [LIST ALL PEOPLE OR TEAMS WHO TOUCH THIS PROCESS]

Known pain points : [WHERE THINGS GO WRONG OR SLOW DOWN]

Map this process as a text-based Swimlane diagram:

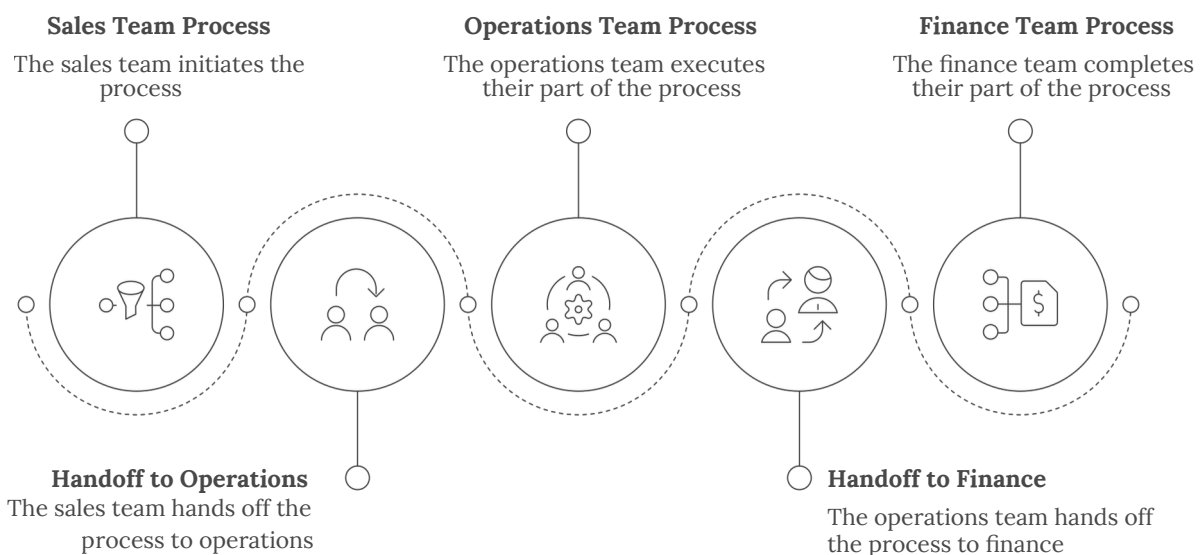
Format : ROLE | Step description | Output / Handoff to

After the map:

1. Identify the 3 highest-risk handoff points
2. Name the role that is the biggest bottleneck
3. Identify any steps that add no value and could be removed
4. Suggest one redesign that would most improve flow

Flag any step where accountability is shared between two lanes, those are your highest failure risk points.

Swimlane Diagram - See Where Handoffs Break



PRO TIP

Shared accountability between lanes is the number one predictor of process failure. When two roles both touch a step, both assume the other is checking it. The fix is always the same: assign one person as Accountable (using RACI) and make the handoff explicit with a defined output format and a confirmation step.

Pairs well with: 7.1 SOP — SIPOC · 6.1 RACI Matrix · 7.11 Poka-Yoke · 7.3 Theory of Constraints

7.3 — Theory of Constraints

Find the one thing slowing everything else down and fix that first

USE THIS WHEN

You are optimising multiple parts of your business simultaneously but overall performance is not improving proportionally. You're busy improving things that don't move the needle because the real bottleneck is somewhere else.

THE FRAMEWORK

Eliyahu Goldratt introduced the Theory of Constraints in his 1984 novel *The Goal*. The core insight is that every system has exactly one constraint at any given time the bottleneck that limits overall throughput. Improving anything that is not the constraint does not improve the system. The Five Focusing Steps are: **Identify the constraint**, **Exploit it** (get maximum output from it without major investment), **Subordinate everything else** (optimise the system to support the constraint), **Elevate it** (invest to increase its capacity), and **Repeat** (once solved, find the next constraint).

*Origin: Eliyahu Goldratt, *The Goal*, 1984 — Theory of Constraints*

HOW TO USE IT

1. Map your entire delivery process and find where work piles up that is your constraint.
2. The constraint is almost never where you think it is - it is where queue builds up, not where people are busiest.
3. Before investing in fixing the constraint, exploit it first, squeeze maximum output from what you have.
4. Once one constraint is resolved, immediately identify the next, constraints shift as systems improve.



Solving the constraint isn't the finish line it's the start of finding the next one. Founders who fix one bottleneck and stop optimizing are surprised when a new one appears; it was always there, just hidden behind the first.

AI PROMPT — COPY & PASTE READY

Act as a Theory of Constraints advisor.

My business process : [DESCRIBE YOUR END-TO-END DELIVERY OR OPERATIONAL PROCESS]

Current symptoms : [WHERE DELAYS, BACKLOGS, OR ERRORS OCCUR]

Team structure : [WHO IS INVOLVED IN EACH STAGE]

Apply the Five Focusing Steps:

IDENTIFY : Where is the constraint where does work pile up or slow down most?

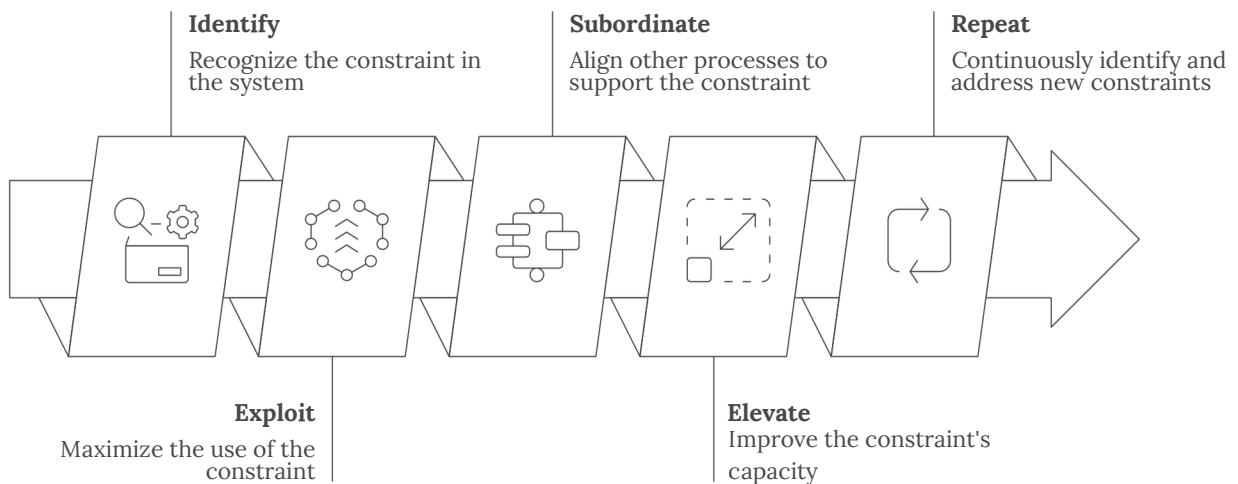
EXPLOIT : How do we get maximum output from the constraint without major investment?

SUBORDINATE : What should every other part of the system do differently to support the constraint?

ELEVATE : If exploitation is not enough, what is the minimum investment to expand capacity?

REPEAT : What will likely become the next constraint once this one is resolved?

Theory of Constraints — The Bottleneck Limits Everything Else



PRO TIP

The most counterintuitive TOC insight is that making a non-constraint more efficient makes the constraint worse. If your constraint is sales and you invest in a faster delivery team, you now have an even more frustrated delivery team waiting for work. Fix the constraint first. Everything else is noise until you do.

Pairs well with: 7.2 Swimlane · 7.4 ICE Scoring · 7.6 PDCA Cycle · 7.9 Kaizen

7.4 — ICE Scoring

Prioritise your next move in three numbers

USE THIS WHEN

Your team has a long list of ideas, experiments, and features. Everyone has an opinion about what to do next. You're choosing based on loudest voice or gut feel and the results are inconsistent.

THE FRAMEWORK

ICE Scoring was popularised by Sean Ellis, the growth hacker who coined the term 'growth hacking.' It scores every idea across three dimensions: **Impact** (how much will this move the key metric if it works?), **Confidence** (how sure are we that it will work, based on evidence?), **Ease** (how quickly and cheaply can we execute it?). Each is scored 1–10. The **ICE Score** = **Impact** × **Confidence** × **Ease**. The highest-scoring ideas rise to the top. It is deliberately simple - a tool for fast, defensible prioritisation, not academic analysis.

Origin: Sean Ellis — ICE Scoring framework, growth hacking methodology

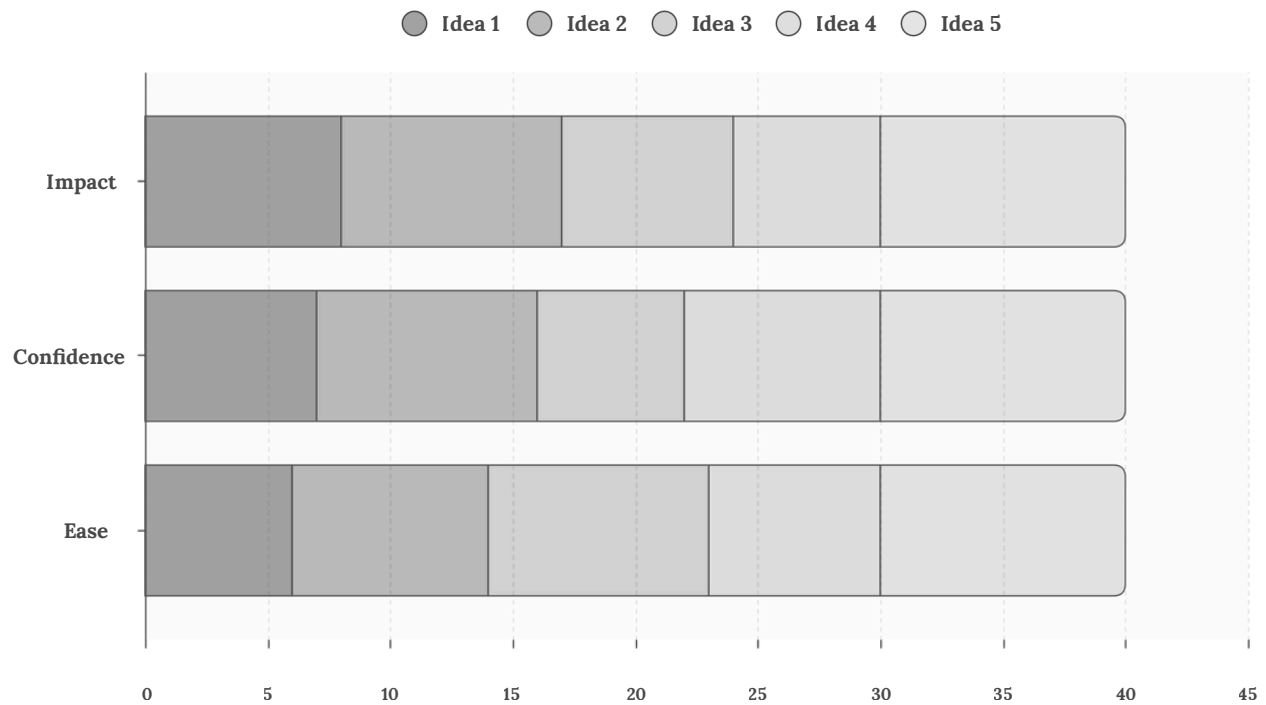
HOW TO USE IT

1. Score ideas as a team, not individually averaging scores removes individual bias.
2. Revisit Confidence scores after each experiment update them with real data.
3. Use ICE for prioritising experiments and quick decisions use RICE (7.5) for larger product decisions.
4. Cap your active list at the top 5 ICE scores - focus beats volume every time.

PRO TIP

A high ICE score is not a mandate it is a starting point. Always ask: 'If this idea scores highest but fails, what do we learn?' Ideas that teach you something even in failure are more valuable than safe wins that teach nothing. Build your experiments to generate insight, not just results.

ICE Scoring — Prioritise in Three Numbers



AI PROMPT — COPY & PASTE READY

Act as a growth prioritisation advisor using ICE Scoring.

Our goal / key metric : [WHAT WE ARE TRYING TO IMPROVE]

Time horizon : [SPRINT / MONTH / QUARTER]

Score each idea on three dimensions (1-10 each):

IMPACT : How much will this move our key metric?

CONFIDENCE : How sure are we it will work? (data > gut)

EASE : How fast and cheap is execution?

ICE SCORE = Impact × Confidence × Ease

Ideas to score :

[LIST YOUR 6-10 IDEAS OR INITIATIVES]

After scoring :

1. Rank all ideas by ICE Score
2. Flag any high-Impact, low-Confidence ideas these need a small test before full investment
3. Recommend the top 3 to execute this period
4. Recommend 1 idea to kill lowest score or highest opportunity cost

Pairs well with: 7.5 RICE Scoring · 6.2 OKRs · 7.3 Theory of Constraints · 9.3 North Star

7.5 — RICE Scoring

Prioritise your product roadmap with four numbers that matter

USE THIS WHEN

Your product roadmap is driven by whoever has the most compelling story in the room. Engineering estimates don't account for how many customers will actually be affected. You're building things that feel important but don't move the metrics.

THE FRAMEWORK

RICE was developed by the Intercom product team as a more rigorous alternative to ICE for product decisions. It scores across four dimensions: **Reach** (how many people will this affect in a given time period?), **Impact** (how much will it move the metric per person scored 0.25 to 3x), **Confidence** (how sure are we, as a percentage?), and **Effort** (how many person-months to build?). **RICE Score = (Reach × Impact × Confidence) : Effort**. Dividing by Effort is the key difference from ICE it ensures that a small, high-impact feature beats a large, medium-impact one if the effort difference is significant.

Origin: Intercom product team — RICE Scoring framework, 2016

HOW TO USE IT

1. Use real data for Reach, not projections. If you don't know, use Confidence to discount it.
2. Impact uses a fixed scale: 3 = massive, 2 = high, 1 = medium, 0.5 = low, 0.25 = minimal.
3. Effort should be in person-months, not story points it forces cross-team thinking.
4. Run RICE in a 30-minute team session group scoring removes individual advocacy bias.

A Score Feels More Objective Than It Is

RICE looks like math, but Confidence and Impact are opinions with decimal points. Group scoring reduces bias, it doesn't remove it. Don't let the formula outrank your judgment on what the customer actually needs.

Act as a product prioritisation consultant using the RICE framework.

Product context : [WHAT THE PRODUCT DOES, STAGE, KEY METRIC]

Time period for scoring : [MONTH / QUARTER]

Score each feature / initiative using RICE:

REACH : Users affected in the time period (real number)

IMPACT : 3=massive / 2=high / 1=med / 0.5=low / 0.25=min

CONFIDENCE : % certain this impact will happen (100/80/50%)

EFFORT : Person-months to build and ship

$RICE = (Reach \times Impact \times Confidence) : Effort$

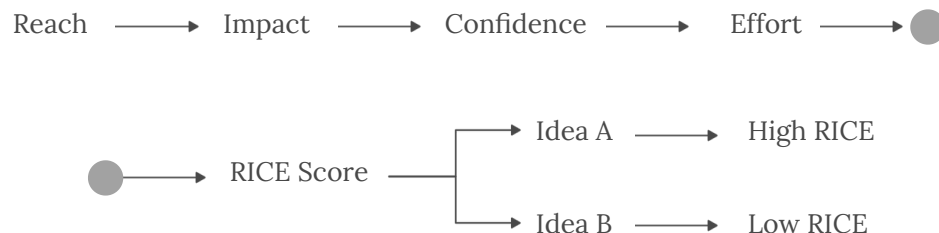
Initiatives to score:

[LIST YOUR 5–8 FEATURES OR INITIATIVES]

After scoring:

1. Rank by RICE Score
2. Flag any item where Effort is the swing factor, would a smaller version change the ranking?
3. Identify the highest-RICE item that is being deprioritised for non-RICE reasons

RICE Scoring — Effort Divides, Not Just Adds



PRO TIP

The most important RICE output is the item that is being deprioritised for non-RICE reasons. Politics, founder preference, and squeaky wheels all suppress high-RICE items. When you see a high-scoring item consistently skipped, that is where organisational dysfunction is most visible and most expensive.

Pairs well with: 7.4 ICE Scoring · 6.2 OKRs · 9.3 North Star Metric · 2.6 MVP Design

7.6 — PDCA Cycle

Turn every experiment into a learning that compounds

USE THIS WHEN

Your team tries things, some work and some don't, but the learning doesn't carry forward. The same mistakes reappear. Successful experiments don't get systematised. You're improving through trial and error instead of through a repeatable process.

THE FRAMEWORK

The PDCA (Plan-Do-Check-Act) cycle was developed by W. Edwards Deming in the 1950s and became the foundation of continuous improvement philosophy in Japan and beyond. **Plan** (define the problem, form a hypothesis, design the experiment), **Do** (run the experiment on a small scale), **Check** (analyse the results against the hypothesis), **Act** (standardise what worked, abandon what didn't, run the next cycle). The cycle is designed to be continuous every Act step feeds the next Plan. When PDCA is embedded in a team's operating rhythm, the team improves structurally, not randomly.

Origin: W. Edwards Deming — PDCA / Shewhart Cycle, adapted from Walter Shewhart, 1950s

HOW TO USE IT

1. Run PDCA on one small improvement per week — short cycles beat large infrequent ones.
2. Write the hypothesis before starting 'if we do X, we expect Y because Z.'
3. In the Check step, compare results to the hypothesis, not just whether results were good.
4. The Act step must result in either a new SOP or a killed idea, no undecided outcomes.



"We'll decide later" is the failure mode PDCA is built to kill. An Act step that ends in maybe isn't an Act step, it's an unfinished cycle, and the learning it should have produced never gets locked in

Act as a continuous improvement facilitator using the PDCA cycle.

Problem or opportunity : [WHAT YOU WANT TO IMPROVE]

Current baseline : [THE METRIC OR SITUATION AS IT IS NOW]

Hypothesis : [WHAT YOU THINK WILL IMPROVE IT AND WHY]

Guide me through a full PDCA cycle:

PLAN : Define the problem precisely.

State the hypothesis : If [ACTION] then [RESULT] because [REASON].

Define success criteria. Design the smallest useful experiment.

DO : What exactly should be done, by whom, by when?

What data needs to be collected during the test?

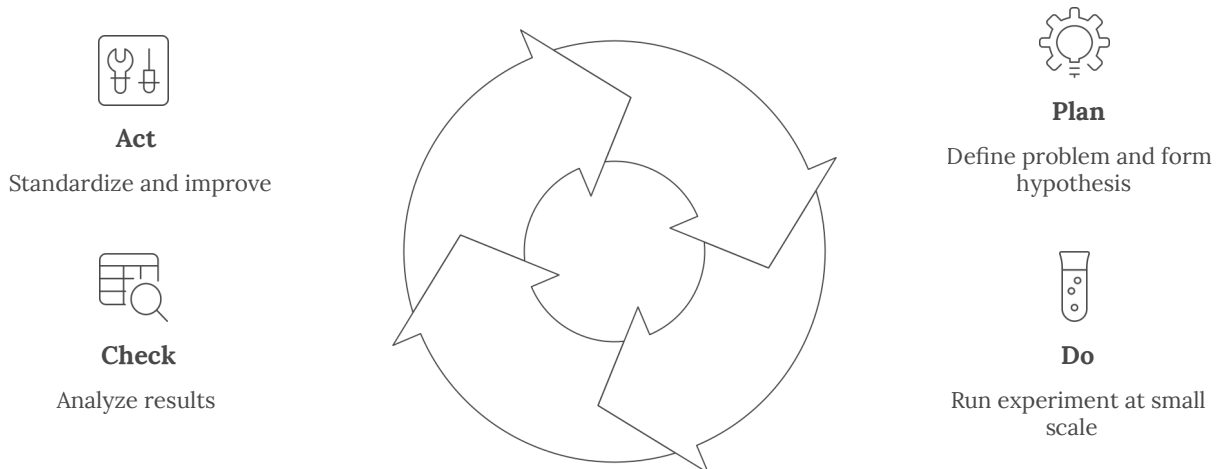
CHECK : How will we compare results to the hypothesis?

What would confirm it? What would disprove it?

ACT : If confirmed - how to standardise and scale?

If disproved - what does this tell us for the next PDCA cycle?

PDCA Cycle for Learning



PRO TIP

The Check step is where most PDCA cycles fail. Teams see a positive result and immediately scale without asking whether the result matched the hypothesis. A result can be positive but the hypothesis still wrong meaning you got lucky, not right. Always check against the hypothesis, not just the outcome number.

Pairs well with: 7.9 Kaizen · 7.1 SOP · 7.3 Theory of Constraints · 8.3 Post-Mortem

7.7 — Working Backwards

Build from the customer. Not from what is easy to build.

USE THIS WHEN

Your team is building something a product, a feature, a process, a service and the conversation keeps starting with what you have, what you can build, or what technology allows. You need to reverse the direction of thinking before a single hour of work is spent. your team spends hours every week on tasks that are repetitive, rule-based, and predictable.

THE FRAMEWORK

Developed by Jeff Bezos and embedded into Amazon's culture, Working Backwards begins at the end: the customer experience. *Before any project starts, the team writes a mock Press Release announcing the finished product from the customer's point of view. It must answer: **Who is the customer? What is their problem? Why is this meaningfully better than before?*** If the press release cannot be written clearly, the project is not ready to start. Amazon used this to build Prime, Alexa, AWS, and the Kindle each beginning with a customer document, not a technology roadmap. What looks like a writing exercise is a decision filter. Projects that cannot survive it should not be started.

Jeff Bezos, Amazon — documented in Working Backwards by Colin Bryar & Bill Carr, 2021

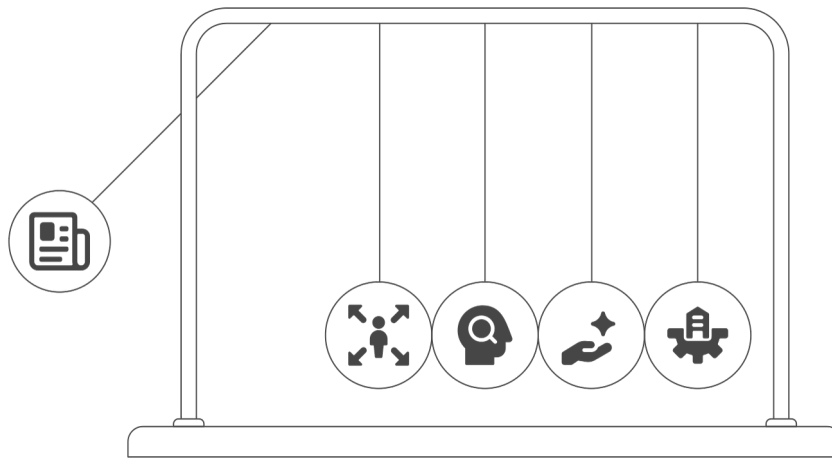
HOW TO USE IT

1. Start with the highest-frequency tasks daily tasks with 10 minutes of work are worth more to automate than monthly tasks with 2 hours.
2. Never automate a broken process, fix the process first, then automate it.
3. Prioritise automation by: frequency × time per occurrence × cost of error.
4. Track time saved per automation, it builds the business case for the next one.

PRO TIP

The hardest part is the customer quote. If it sounds like marketing copy, your benefit is still abstract. Rewrite until a real person would actually say it to a friend.

Working Backwards Drives Product Success



Press Release
Customer-centric
product launch

Customer Focus
Understanding
target audience

Problem Solving
Addressing
customer needs

Value Proposition
Highlighting product
benefits

Efficient Building
Streamlined
development process

AI PROMPT — COPY & PASTE READY

Act as an Amazon-style product consultant using Working Backwards.

I am building : [PRODUCT, FEATURE, OR INITIATIVE]

Target customer : [WHO role, situation, problem they have]

Step 1 — Press Release:

Headline : [What is live and why it matters to the customer]

Problem : [What were they struggling with before?]

Solution : [How does it solve it specifically?]

Better because : [Compared to what existed before]

Customer quote : [What a real customer would tell a friend]

Step 2 — FAQ:

List the 5 hardest questions a sceptic would ask. Answer each honestly.

Step 3 — Scope filter:

List 3 things currently planned that do NOT serve the customer promise and should be cut.

Pairs well with: 7.1 SOP — SIPOC · 7.6 PDCA · 2.1 Value Proposition Canvas · 2.5 Jobs To Be Done

7.8 — Agile Sprint Canvas

Run focused two-week cycles that ship not just plan

USE THIS WHEN

Your team plans a lot but ships inconsistently. Sprints fill up with tasks that don't connect to a clear goal. By the end of two weeks, the sprint goal has shifted or was never clear in the first place.

THE FRAMEWORK

Developed from Jeff Sutherland and Ken Schwaber's Scrum framework, the Sprint Canvas is a one-page planning tool for a two-week sprint. It maps: **Sprint Goal** (the one thing that defines success for this sprint), **Backlog Items** (tasks selected to achieve the goal), **Dependencies** (what needs to happen before these tasks can start), **Risks** (what could prevent completion), **Definition of Done** (how we know each item is complete), and **Daily Standup Questions** (what keeps the team aligned). AI can help design a sprint that is internally coherent, where every backlog item connects to the sprint goal.

Origin: Jeff Sutherland & Ken Schwaber — Scrum framework, 1990s · Agile Manifesto, 2001

HOW TO USE IT

1. Define the Sprint Goal before selecting backlog items, items must serve the goal, not the other way around.
2. Limit work in progress, it is better to finish 5 items completely than to start 10.
3. The Definition of Done must be agreed before the sprint starts, not interpreted at the end.
4. Run a 30-minute sprint retrospective after every sprint: what to start, stop, and continue.

Backlog Items Aren't the Goal

If you can delete an item from the backlog and the Sprint Goal is still achievable, that item shouldn't have been in the sprint. Every task earns its place by serving the goal, not by being useful, urgent, or already half-started.

Act as an Agile coach helping design a focused sprint.

Team : [SIZE, ROLES, WHAT YOU ARE BUILDING]

Sprint duration : [1 OR 2 WEEKS]

Priorities this sprint. : [WHAT YOU MOST NEED TO ACCOMPLISH]

Capacity : [AVAILABLE PERSON-DAYS THIS SPRINT]

Design a complete Sprint Canvas:

SPRINT GOAL : One sentence what defines success

BACKLOG ITEMS : 5–8 tasks that directly serve the goal. Each with: owner, estimate, priority

DEPENDENCIES : What must happen before sprint starts

RISKS : What could prevent completion

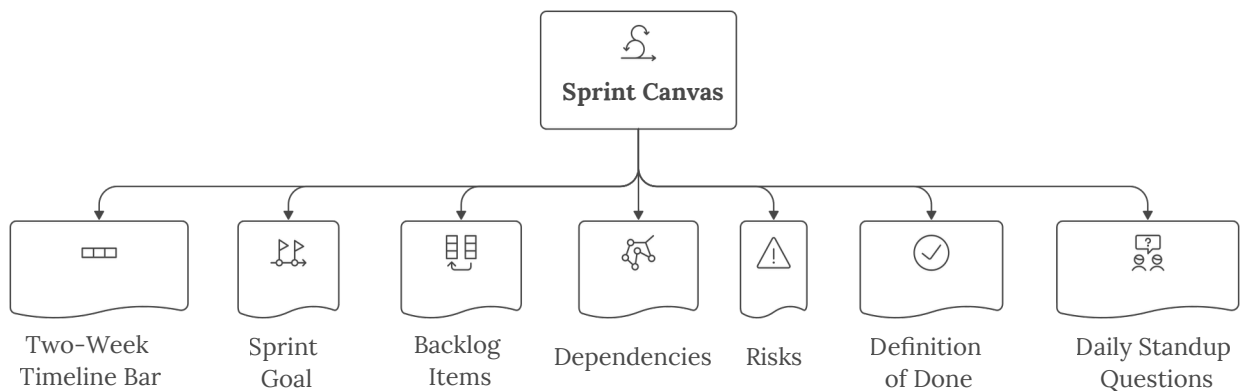
DEFINITION OF DONE : How we know each item is complete

STANDUP FORMAT : 3 daily questions for team alignment

RETROSPECTIVE : 3 questions for end-of-sprint review

Flag any backlog item that does not directly serve the sprint goal, those should be deferred.

Sprint Canvas - Two Weeks That Ship, Not Just Plan



PRO TIP

The most valuable sprint ritual is not the standup, it is the retrospective. Teams that run honest retrospectives improve sprint-over-sprint. Teams that skip them repeat the same problems. Block the time before the sprint starts, not at the end when everyone is rushing to the next thing.

Pairs well with: 7.4 ICE Scoring · 7.5 RICE Scoring · 7.6 PDCA · 6.2 OKRs

Japanese Framework · Toyota Production System / Japanese Philosophy

7.9 — Kaizen Continuous Improvement

Small improvements, everyday, forever. The philosophy that built Toyota.

USE THIS WHEN

Your team fixes problems reactively something breaks, you fix it, you move on. There is no systematic habit of looking for small improvements. Progress happens in large infrequent jumps instead of steady daily gains.

THE FRAMEWORK

Kaizen (Japanese: kai = change, zen = good) is the philosophy and practice of continuous, incremental improvement developed as a core principle of the Toyota Production System in postwar Japan. It is not a project **it is a culture**. The central idea is that **every person at every level, every day, is looking for one small thing to improve**. No improvement is too small. The compound effect of thousands of small improvements creates transformation that no single large project can match. Masaaki Imai brought Kaizen to Western management through his 1986 book of the same name.

Origin: Toyota Production System, Japan, 1950s · Masaaki Imai, Kaizen, 1986

HOW TO USE IT

1. Start a Kaizen log a shared document where any team member can record one improvement suggestion per day.
2. Run a 15-minute weekly Kaizen review what small improvement did we make this week?
3. Focus on process, not people, Kaizen looks for system failures, not human failures.
4. Celebrate small wins explicitly, culture of improvement requires reward of improvement.

AI PROMPT — COPY & PASTE READY

Act as a Kaizen facilitator.

My business / team : [DESCRIBE YOUR OPERATION AND TEAM SIZE]

Area to improve : [SPECIFIC PROCESS, FUNCTION, OR BEHAVIOUR]

Current state : [HOW THIS AREA WORKS TODAY - SPECIFICALLY]

Run a Kaizen session on this area:

OBSERVE : What waste exists in this process?

(Waste = time, effort, rework, waiting, errors)

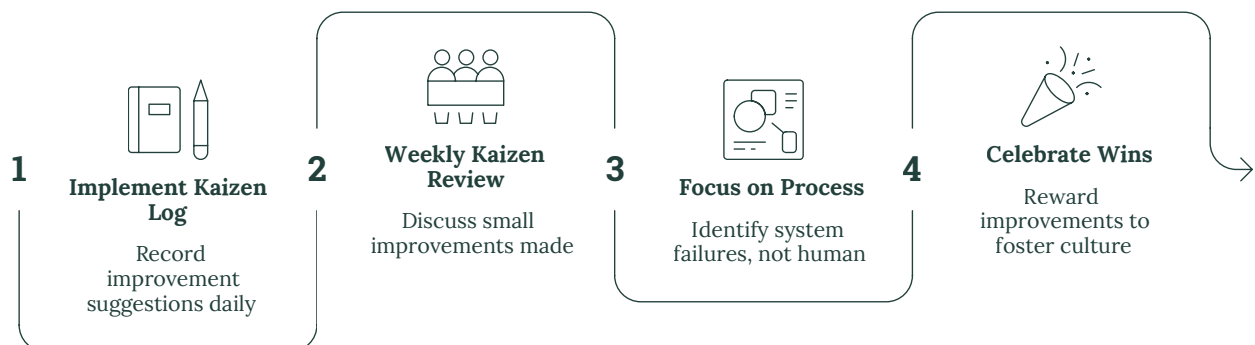
ANALYSE : What is the root cause of the biggest waste? Use the 5 Whys ask why 5 times.

IMPROVE : What is the smallest change that would meaningfully reduce this waste?
Define the change in one sentence.

MEASURE : How will we know the improvement worked? Name the metric and the target.

SUSTAIN : How do we make this improvement permanent? What system or habit locks it in?

Achieving Continuous Improvement



PRO TIP

Kaizen's power is not in the size of any single improvement it is in the compound effect and the culture it creates. A team that makes one small improvement per week makes 50 per year. After three years, the cumulative effect of 150 deliberate improvements makes the business unrecognisable from where it started. The math is simple. The discipline is the hard part.

Pairs well with: 7.6 PDCA Cycle · 7.3 Theory of Constraints · 7.12 5 Whys · 7.10 5S

Japanese Framework · Toyota Production System / Japanese Philosophy

7.10 — 5S Framework

Sort, Set, Shine, Standardise, Sustain. Order is a performance strategy.

USE THIS WHEN

Your workspace physical or digital is cluttered with things that are no longer needed, hard to find, and inconsistently organised. Your team wastes time searching for information, files, tools, or processes. Small inefficiencies compound into significant drag.

THE FRAMEWORK

5S is a workplace organisation methodology from the Toyota Production System: **Seiri** (**Sort** - remove what is not needed), **Seiton** (**Set in Order** - arrange what remains for maximum efficiency), **Seiso** (**Shine** - clean and maintain), **Seiketsu** (**Standardise** - make the standard visible and easy to follow), **Shitsuke** (**Sustain** - build the discipline to maintain the system). Originally designed for factory floors, 5S applies directly to digital environments file systems, CRM data, shared drives, Notion workspaces, and email inboxes. A clean environment reduces cognitive load and speeds execution.

Origin: Toyota Production System, Japan, 1950s · Hiroyuki Hirano, 5 Pillars of the Visual Workplace, 1990

HOW TO USE IT

1. Apply 5S to one area at a time starting with the highest-friction environment.
2. Sort ruthlessly - if it hasn't been used in 90 days and is not a record, it is clutter.
3. Set in Order means designing for the most common use case the thing used most is most accessible.
4. Sustain requires a scheduled audit 5S without a maintenance habit degrades within weeks.



Sort, Set, and Shine feel like progress because they're visible, one-time wins. Sustain is invisible maintenance with no finish line skip it, and the clean system decays back to clutter within weeks, unnoticed until it's bad again.

Act as a 5S operational consultant.

Environment to apply 5S:

DIGITAL : shared drive / CRM / Notion / email inbox

PHYSICAL : office / desk / storage / warehouse

Team size : [HOW MANY PEOPLE USE THIS ENVIRONMENT]

Current state : [DESCRIBE THE MAIN FRICTION POINTS]

Guide me through all five S steps:

SORT (Seiri) : What should be removed or archived? Decision rule for keeping vs. removing?

SET IN ORDER (Seiton) : How should items be organised?

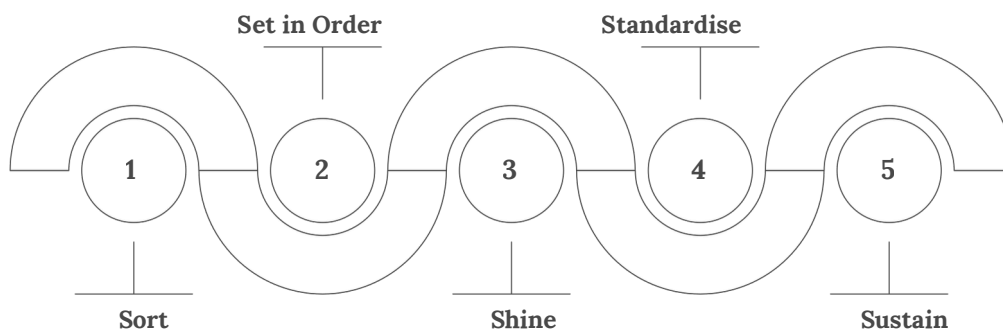
Naming convention, folder structure, or physical layout recommendation.

SHINE (Seiso) : What maintenance tasks keep it clean? Who is responsible?
How often?

STANDARDISE (Seiketsu) : What standards should everyone follow? Write 5 simple rules for this environment.

SUSTAIN (Shitsuke) : How do we audit compliance monthly? What is the minimum habit to maintain it?

5S — Order as a Performance Strategy



PRO TIP

The most neglected S is Sustain and without it, the other four degrade within a month. Build one maintenance habit: a 15-minute monthly '5S check' where one person audits one area against the standard. The audit does not need to be comprehensive. It needs to be consistent. Consistency is what makes 5S compound.

Pairs well with: 7.9 Kaizen · 7.1 SOP Generation · 7.11 Poka-Yoke · 7.2 Swimlane

Japanese Framework · Toyota Production System / Japanese Philosophy

7.11 — Poka-Yoke Error Proofing

Design your processes so mistakes become impossible

USE THIS WHEN

The same mistakes keep happening despite training, reminders, and process documentation. You fix an error, it reappears weeks later. You are managing human error instead of designing it out.

THE FRAMEWORK

Poka-Yoke (Japanese: poka = inadvertent mistake, yoke = prevent) was developed by Shigeo Shingo at Toyota in the 1960s. The principle is **to design processes, tools, and environments** so that errors either cannot occur or are immediately detected and corrected before they cause damage. There are two types: **Prevention Poka-Yoke** (makes the mistake physically or logically impossible) and **Detection Poka-Yoke** (catches the error immediately after it occurs, before it passes forward). Applied to business processes and digital workflows, Poka-Yoke reduces the reliance on human vigilance and builds quality into the system itself.

Origin: Shigeo Shingo, Toyota Production System, Japan, 1960s

HOW TO USE IT

1. Map your most common recurring errors before prompting the list is your starting point.
2. For each error, ask: is this a Prevention opportunity or a Detection opportunity?
3. Prevention is always preferable catching an error after it happens still has a cost.
4. The best Poka-Yoke solutions are invisible the user simply cannot make the mistake.



"Be more careful" is not a Poka-Yoke - it's the human vigilance this framework exists to remove. A reminder, checklist, or more training hasn't error-proofed anything. It's just one more thing to forget.

Act as a process error-proofing consultant using Poka-Yoke.

My process : [DESCRIBE THE PROCESS WHERE ERRORS OCCUR]

Common errors : [LIST THE MISTAKES THAT RECUR MOST OFTEN]

Impact of each error : [TIME LOST / COST / CUSTOMER IMPACT]

For each error, design a Poka-Yoke solution:

ERROR : [Name the error]

TYPE : Prevention (impossible to make) or Detection (caught immediately after)

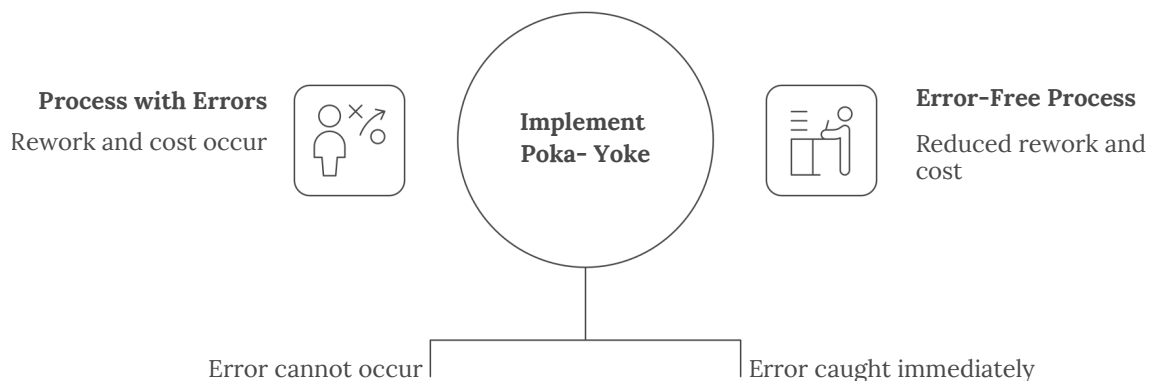
SOLUTION : The specific design change, checklist, automation, or constraint that eliminates it

IMPLEMENTATION : What needs to change - tool, process, template, or approval step?

After individual solutions :

Identify the one error with the highest cost that currently has no Poka-Yoke in place.
Design the simplest Prevention solution for it.

Poka-Yoke: Design Out the Mistake



PRO TIP

The most powerful Poka-Yoke in any knowledge business is a mandatory checklist at a process handoff. Before a piece of work moves from one person to the next, a checklist must be completed. This single habit catches more errors than any amount of training because it makes the standard visible at the exact moment it matters.

Pairs well with: 7.9 Kaizen · 7.1 SOP · 7.2 Swimlane · 7.12 5 Whys

Japanese Framework · Toyota Production System / Japanese Philosophy

7.12 — 5 Whys – Root Cause Analysis

Stop fixing symptoms. Find what is actually causing the problem.

USE THIS WHEN

A problem keeps coming back after you fix it. You treat the visible issue and it reappears in a different form. Your team is busy fixing the same category of problem repeatedly without eliminating it.

THE FRAMEWORK

The 5 Whys was developed by Sakichi Toyoda, the founder of Toyota Industries, as a simple but powerful root cause analysis technique. When a problem occurs, ask Why it happened. Take that answer and ask Why again. Repeat five times. By the fifth Why, you have typically arrived at the systemic root cause not the visible symptom. **The technique is deceptively simple: most people stop at the first or second Why, fix the symptom, and wonder why the problem returns.**

The chain only holds if each answer is something you can actually verify, not a guess dressed up as an explanation. A fifth Why built on four assumptions gives you a confident-sounding root cause that is still wrong.

Origin: Sakichi Toyoda, Toyota Industries, Japan, 1930s · Formalised in Toyota Production System

HOW TO USE IT

1. Ask Why from a process perspective not a people perspective. 'Why did the process allow this?' not 'Why did the person do this?'
2. Each answer must be a fact, not a presumption, if you don't know, find out before continuing.
3. When you reach a Why that points to a system or policy failure, you've found the root cause.
4. Implement a fix at the root cause level, not at the symptom level and use PDCA to verify it holds.

Act as a root cause analysis facilitator using the 5 Whys.

The problem : [DESCRIBE THE ISSUE SPECIFICALLY - WHAT HAPPENED, WHEN, HOW OFTEN]

Impact : [WHAT IT COSTS, TIME, MONEY, CUSTOMER IMPACT]

Context : [RELEVANT PROCESS, TEAM, OR SYSTEM INVOLVED]

Run a 5 Whys analysis:

PROBLEM : [State the problem clearly]

WHY 1 : Why did this happen?

WHY 2 : Why did [Why 1 answer] happen?

WHY 3 : Why did [Why 2 answer] happen?

WHY 4 : Why did [Why 3 answer] happen?

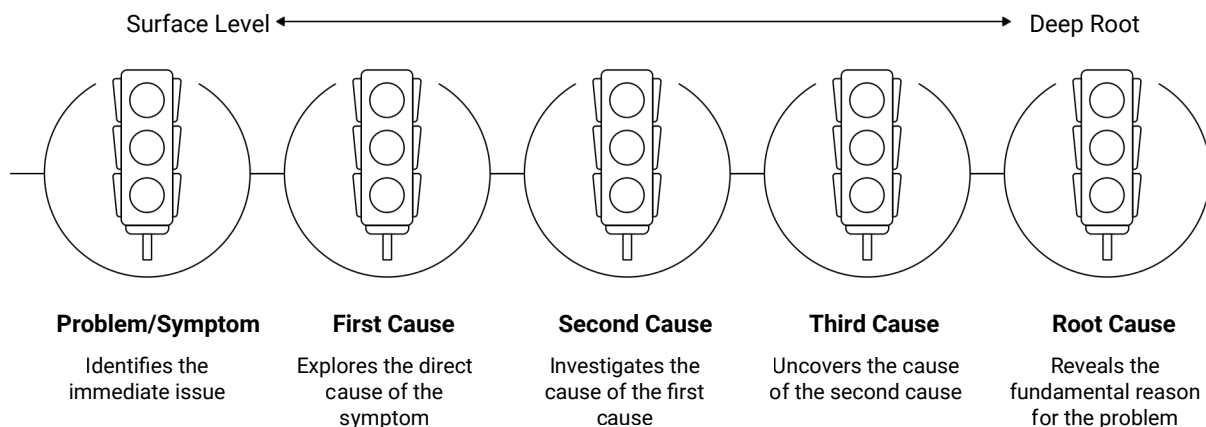
WHY 5 : Why did [Why 4 answer] happen?

ROOT CAUSE : State the systemic root cause.

SOLUTION : What change at the root cause level would prevent this problem from recurring?

VERIFICATION : How will we confirm the fix held after 30 days?

Understanding the root cause through iterative questioning.



PRO TIP

The most valuable discipline in 5 Whys is stopping yourself from jumping to solutions before you reach Why 5. Every Why is a potential solution, but only the final Why addresses the root cause. Solutions applied at Why 2 or Why 3 create the illusion of progress while leaving the root cause intact and ready to resurface.

Pairs well with: 7.6 PDCA · 7.9 Kaizen · 7.11 Poka-Yoke · 8.3 Post-Mortem

MODULE 8

Decide with Confidence

Make better decisions faster, with less regret.

WHAT THIS MODULE DOES

Most business failures are not failures of effort they are failures of decision. The wrong market entered. The wrong hire kept too long. The wrong pivot made too late. This module gives you ten frameworks for structured decision-making from rapid frameworks for daily decisions to deep analytical tools for irreversible ones. Combined with AI, these frameworks turn gut-feel decisions into evidence-based ones without slowing you down.

IN THIS MODULE

- 8.1 The DECIDE Framework
- 8.2 Pre-Mortem Analysis
- 8.3 Post-Mortem Review
- 8.4 Risk Matrix
- 8.5 Scenario Planning
- 8.6 Red Team Thinking
- 8.7 Eisenhower Matrix
- 8.8 Regret Minimization Framework
- 8.9 Decision Tree Analysis
- 8.10 Expected Value Framework

Start here if you are new to AI, or your prompts feel hit-or-miss.

8.1 — The DECIDE Framework

A structured six-step process for any decision that matters

USE THIS WHEN

You are going in circles on an important decision. You have information but can't reach clarity. The same arguments keep coming up. You need a process to move from deliberation to decision.

THE FRAMEWORK

The DECIDE framework, developed in decision science, is a six-step structured decision process: **Define the problem** (what exactly are you deciding?), **Establish criteria** (what does a good decision look like?), **Consider alternatives** (what are all the realistic options?), **Identify the best option** (evaluate alternatives against criteria), **Develop and implement** (commit and plan), **Evaluate the outcome** (review after the fact). Its value is in making implicit decision-making explicit — surfacing the criteria and alternatives that are often left unstated, which is where most poor decisions hide.

Origin: Decision science methodology — DECIDE framework, Kristina Guo and others

HOW TO USE IT

1. Define the decision in one sentence before doing anything else — ambiguous definition is the root of most decision paralysis.
2. Write your criteria before generating options — criteria set after options are considered are reverse-engineered rationalisations.
3. Generate at least three alternatives — binary choices limit thinking.
4. Set a decision date before starting the process. Open-ended decision timelines produce no decisions.



If you're writing criteria after you've already generated the options, you're not deciding — you're justifying a choice you already made. The order matters as much as the steps: criteria first, or the whole process becomes theater around a decision you'd already reached.

Act as a structured decision-making facilitator using the DECIDE framework.

Decision to make : [DESCRIBE THE DECISION IN ONE SENTENCE]

Deadline : [WHEN THIS MUST BE DECIDED]

Context : [RELEVANT BACKGROUND, CONSTRAINTS, STAKEHOLDERS]

Guide me through all six DECIDE steps:

DEFINE : Restate the decision clearly and precisely. What is the core question being answered?

ESTABLISH : What are the 4–5 criteria for a good decision? Weight each by importance (1–5).

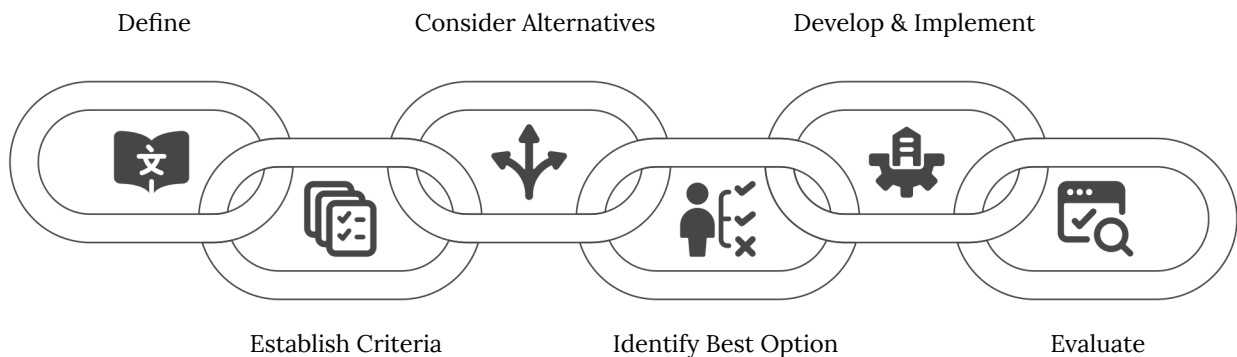
CONSIDER : Generate 3–4 realistic alternative options. Include one option I may be avoiding.

IDENTIFY : Score each option against each criterion. Which scores highest overall?

DEVELOP : What are the first 3 implementation steps?

EVALUATE : What metric or signal will tell me at 90 days whether this was the right decision?

The DECIDE Framework



PRO TIP

The step most people skip is Establish defining criteria before looking at options. When you evaluate options without stated criteria, you unconsciously build the criteria around your preferred option. Writing criteria first makes the evaluation honest. If your preferred option scores poorly against honest criteria, that is the most valuable output from this framework.

Pairs well with: 8.2 Pre-Mortem · 8.9 Decision Tree · 1.12 MECE · 1.6 First Principles

8.2 — Pre-Mortem Analysis

Imagine it already failed then figure out why

USE THIS WHEN

You are about to launch something, make a major hire, or commit significant resources and you want to stress-test it before you commit. But your team is optimistic and no one is raising the hard questions.

THE FRAMEWORK

The Pre-Mortem was developed by psychologist Gary Klein as an antidote to groupthink and planning optimism. **Before a project begins**, the team imagines it is one year in the future and the project has failed spectacularly. **Each person writes down every reason they can think of for why it failed.** The group then reviews all reasons and identifies the most likely and most serious failure modes. Unlike a risk register (which asks 'what could go wrong?'), the Pre-Mortem asks 'what did go wrong?' the past tense activates a different and more honest mode of thinking.

Origin: Gary Klein, psychologist — Pre-Mortem methodology

HOW TO USE IT

1. Run the Pre-Mortem in writing first, verbal Pre-Mortems are dominated by the loudest voice.
2. Separate generation from evaluation, collect all failure reasons before discussing any of them.
3. Focus on the top 3 most likely and most serious failure modes, you cannot mitigate everything.
4. For each top failure mode, assign a specific owner and a specific prevention action.



A pre-mortem that stays a discussion is wasted effort. If the top three failure modes don't end with a named owner and a specific prevention action, you've identified the risks and done nothing to stop them.

Act as a Pre-Mortem facilitator.

Project or decision : [DESCRIBE WHAT YOU ARE ABOUT TO DO]

Timeline : [HOW LONG THIS WILL TAKE]

Team involved : [ROLES RESPONSIBLE FOR EXECUTION]

Resources committed : [BUDGET, TIME, PEOPLE]

Run a Pre-Mortem:

SCENARIO: It is [DATE 12 MONTHS FROM NOW]. This project has failed. Not partially, completely. What happened?

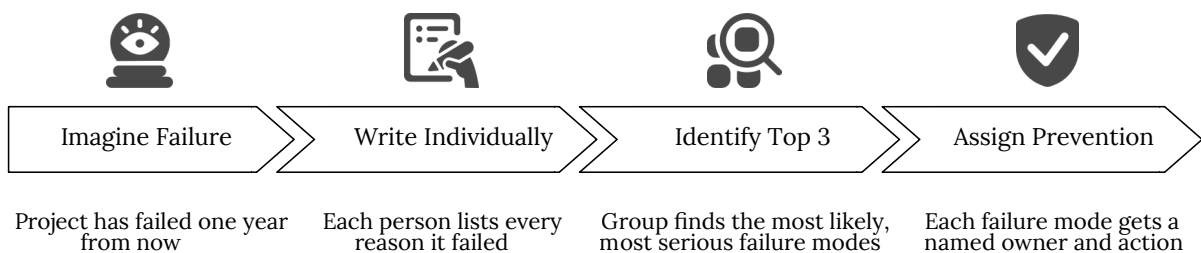
Generate 10 specific reasons it failed, across:

- Execution failures (team, timeline, quality)
- Market failures (wrong assumptions about customers)
- Resource failures (budget, capacity, dependencies)
- Strategic failures (wrong direction or timing)
- External failures (competition, regulation, market shift)

Then: rank the top 3 by likelihood × severity.

For each top failure: one prevention action and one owner.

Pre-Mortem Analysis



PRO TIP

The Pre-Mortem's greatest value is not the list of failure modes — it is the social permission it creates for people to raise concerns. In a team that is committed to a plan, raising doubts feels disloyal. The Pre-Mortem makes it the job. Run it before every significant commitment and watch concerns surface that would have stayed silent until they became problems.

Pairs well with: 8.3 Post-Mortem · 8.6 Red Team · 1.8 Inversion · 8.4 Risk Matrix

8.3 — Post-Mortem Review

Extract the full learning from every outcome - win or lose

USE THIS WHEN

Your team debriefs informally after projects finish. The same mistakes recur because learning is not systematically captured or applied. Wins are celebrated without understanding what caused them. You are not compounding your experience.

THE FRAMEWORK

A Post-Mortem is a structured review conducted after a project, campaign, launch, or significant event to extract learning and improve future performance. Unlike a blame session or a celebration, a well-run Post-Mortem is analytically neutral **it asks what happened, why it happened, and what will be done differently next time**. Amazon pioneered the blameless post-mortem culture in engineering; it applies equally to sales, marketing, product, and leadership decisions. AI can structure a complete Post-Mortem analysis when given the outcome data.

Origin: Amazon engineering culture — blameless post-mortem · Agile retrospective methodology

HOW TO USE IT

1. Run Post-Mortems on wins as well as failures - understanding what caused a win is equally valuable.
2. Schedule the Post-Mortem within 2 weeks of the outcome, memory degrades fast.
3. Focus on process, not people, a good Post-Mortem improves systems, not morale.
4. The output must include specific changes, a Post-Mortem without action items is a retrospective, not a review.



"Blameless" doesn't mean consequence-free, it means the analysis targets the system, not the person. If your Post-Mortem drifts into naming who messed up instead of what broke, you've turned a learning tool back into the blame session it was designed to replace.

AI PROMPT — COPY & PASTE READY

Act as a Post-Mortem facilitator.

Project or event : [DESCRIBE WHAT HAPPENED]

Outcome : [WHAT ACTUALLY RESULTED — METRIC, TIMELINE, QUALITY]

Target : [WHAT WAS PLANNED OR EXPECTED]

Team involved : [ROLES AND CONTRIBUTIONS]

Structure a complete Post-Mortem:

TIMELINE : Reconstruct the key events in sequence. When did things diverge from the plan?

WHAT WORKED : 3 things that went well and why. What can be systematised from these?

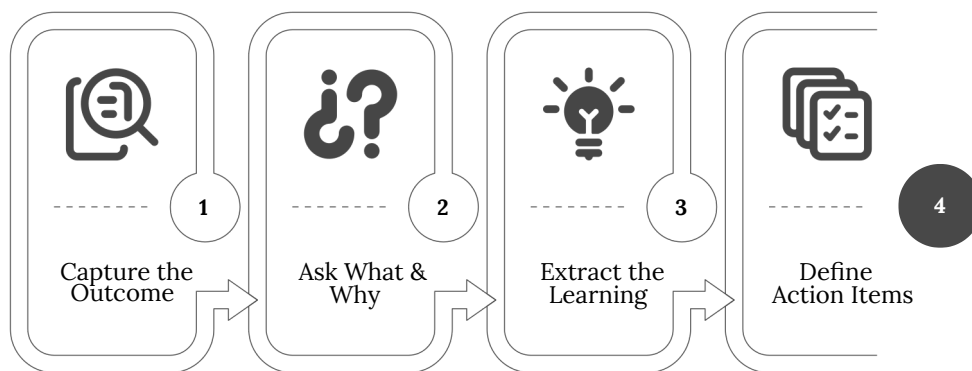
WHAT FAILED : 3 things that did not work and why. Use 5 Whys for the most critical failure.

ROOT CAUSES : The underlying systemic reasons, not the surface events.

ACTION ITEMS : 3 specific changes owner, deadline. For each: what process or system changes?

KNOWLEDGE CAPTURED: One paragraph to add to our playbook.

Post-Mortem Review



PRO TIP

The most valuable Post-Mortem output is the paragraph added to the playbook. Not the action items, those are often forgotten. A one-paragraph insight written while the memory is fresh and placed in a shared document creates institutional knowledge that survives team turnover. Build the habit of writing it before the meeting ends.

Pairs well with: 8.2 Pre-Mortem · 7.6 PDCA · 7.12 5 Whys · 6.8 Meeting Design

8.4 — Risk Matrix

See your risks clearly and know which ones actually deserve your attention

USE THIS WHEN

You have a vague sense that things could go wrong but no clear view of which risks matter most. You either worry about everything equally or dismiss risks until they become crises. Risk management feels either overwhelming or performative.

THE FRAMEWORK

The Risk Matrix is an ISO 31000-based tool that plots risks on two dimensions: **Likelihood** (how probable is this risk?) and **Impact** (how severe would the consequences be?). Each risk is scored and placed in a 3×3 or 5×5 grid. **High likelihood + high impact = immediate priority. Low likelihood + low impact = monitor or accept.** The matrix forces explicit ranking and prevents the two most common risk management failures: treating all risks equally, or ignoring low-probability, high-impact risks because they seem unlikely.

Origin: ISO 31000 Risk Management framework · Risk matrix methodology widely used

HOW TO USE IT

1. Generate a comprehensive risk list first before scoring. Scoring before listing creates anchoring bias.
2. Include strategic, operational, financial, people, and external risk categories.
3. For every high-priority risk, define a mitigation and an owner risks without owners are not managed.
4. Review the matrix quarterly risk profiles change as the business evolves.

Low-Likelihood Isn't Low-Stakes

A pandemic, a key-person departure, a lawsuit – all low likelihood, all capable of ending the business. The matrix exists precisely to stop you from dismissing these as unlikely and forgetting them. Low probability earns a lighter watch, never a blind spot.

Act as a risk management consultant using the Risk Matrix framework.

My business : [DESCRIBE YOUR COMPANY, STAGE, AND CURRENT PLANS]

Decision or initiative : [WHAT YOU ARE ABOUT TO DO OR COMMIT TO]

Step 1 : Generate 15 risks across five categories:

· Strategic · Operational · Financial · People · External

Step 2 : Score each risk:

LIKELIHOOD : 1 (unlikely) to 5 (almost certain)

IMPACT : 1 (minimal) to 5 (existential)

RISK SCORE = Likelihood × Impact

Step 3 : Group by priority:

RED (score 15–25) : Act immediately

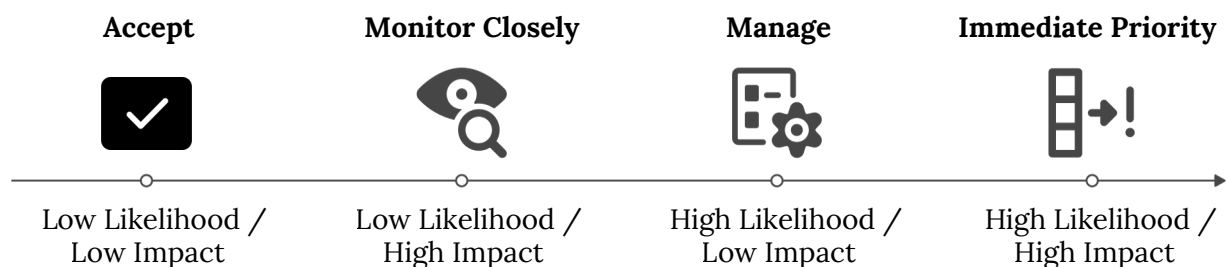
AMBER (score 8–14) : Monitor and prepare

GREEN (score 1–7) : Accept or note

Step 4 : For each RED risk: Mitigation action · Owner · Trigger signal

Step 5 : Identify the one risk I am most likely to be underestimating.

Risk Matrix Quadrant Actions



PRO TIP

The most dangerous risks are not the ones scored highest, they are the ones missing from the list entirely. After scoring, ask AI: 'What risk have I not considered that regularly kills businesses at my stage?' Black swan events, regulatory changes, and key person dependencies are consistently the most underestimated categories.

Pairs well with: 8.2 Pre-Mortem · 8.5 Scenario Planning · 8.6 Red Team · 1.7 Second Order

8.5 — Scenario Planning

Plan for the futures that haven't happened yet, including the ones you're not expecting

USE THIS WHEN

You plan for one future: the one you expect. When the market shifts, a competitor moves, or an external event disrupts your assumptions, you are caught without a contingency. You are not naive, you just haven't built the habit of planning for multiple futures.

THE FRAMEWORK

Scenario Planning was pioneered by Herman Kahn at the RAND Corporation and developed into a strategic tool by the Shell Oil planning team in the 1970s, most famously used to prepare for the 1973 oil crisis before it happened. **The method builds three to four internally consistent, plausible futures based on the key uncertainties in your environment. You then stress-test your strategy against each scenario.** The goal is not to predict which future will happen, it is to build a strategy that is robust across multiple futures and to identify the early signals that tell you which future is emerging.

Origin: Herman Kahn, RAND Corporation · Shell Oil planning team, 1970s

HOW TO USE IT

1. Identify your two most critical and most uncertain variables, these become the axes of your scenario matrix.
2. Build scenarios that are plausible, distinct, and internally consistent not best/worst/base.
3. Name each scenario memorably, it makes them easier to reference in team conversations.
4. Define the early warning signals for each scenario before you need them.



A named scenario is worth nothing without a defined trigger. If "Downturn" and "Boom" don't come with the specific early signals that tell you which one is arriving, you've built a story exercise, not a strategy tool.

Act as a scenario planning strategist.

My business : [DESCRIBE YOUR COMPANY AND CORE STRATEGY]

Planning horizon : [1 YEAR / 3 YEARS / 5 YEARS]

Key uncertainties : [WHAT 2-3 EXTERNAL FACTORS COULD MOST CHANGE YOUR BUSINESS ENVIRONMENT]

Build 3 distinct scenarios. For each scenario:

NAME : A memorable, descriptive title

DESCRIPTION : What this future looks like in 2-3 sentences

KEY DRIVERS : What causes this scenario to unfold

IMPACT : How does this affect my business specifically?

STRATEGY : What should I do differently in this scenario?

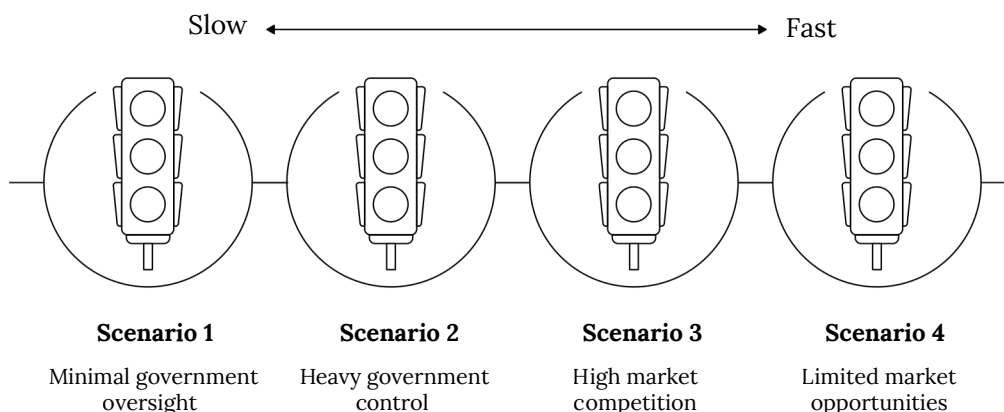
EARLY SIGNAL : What would I see in the next 90 days that tells me this scenario is emerging?

After the three scenarios:

Which elements of my current strategy work across all three?

Which are scenario-specific bets?

Scenario planning matrix based on market growth and regulation.



PRO TIP

The real value in scenario planning isn't the scenarios, it's the early warning signals. Once you know what each future looks like in its early stages, you know what to watch for. Build a simple 3-5 signal dashboard and review it quarterly. Founders who see change coming are the ones who defined what it would look like before it arrived.

Pairs well with: 8.4 Risk Matrix · 8.2 Pre-Mortem · 3.2 PESTLE · 1.7 Second Order Thinking

8.6 — Red Team Thinking

Attack your own plan before someone else does

USE THIS WHEN

Your team has reached consensus on a strategy or plan. Everyone is aligned and optimistic. But consensus is not the same as correctness and optimism is not the same as rigor. You need someone to try to break the plan before you execute it.

THE FRAMEWORK

Red Teaming originates from US military and CIA practice, a dedicated team whose sole job is to find weaknesses in friendly plans by thinking like the adversary. In business, **Red Team Thinking means assembling a small group (or prompting AI) to argue as hard as possible against your plan, assumption, or strategy.** Unlike a Pre-Mortem (which imagines failure after the fact), Red Team Thinking operates in real time, it is an adversarial stress test of your current thinking. The goal is not to be negative but to find the genuine weaknesses before they are exploited by reality.

Origin: US Military / CIA — Red Team methodology · Micah Zenko, Red Team, 2015

HOW TO USE IT

1. Brief the Red Team with the full plan, they cannot attack what they don't understand.
2. Prohibit defensive responses during the Red Team session, the goal is to hear, not rebut.
3. Ask for the single most dangerous attack on your plan, not a laundry list.
4. After the session, sort attacks by likelihood and severity, then address the top three.

Defensiveness Kills the Exercise

The moment you defend your plan instead of listening, the Red Team session is over, everyone in the room reads it, and the honest attacks stop coming. Rule 2 exists for a reason: a Red Team that gets argued with becomes a Red Team that goes quiet.

Act as a Red Team adversary. Your job is to find every weakness in the following plan and try to destroy it.

Be thorough, critical, and honest. Do not be polite.

The plan : [DESCRIBE YOUR STRATEGY, PRODUCT, OR DECISION]

Our key assumptions : [LIST THE THINGS THAT MUST BE TRUE FOR THIS PLAN TO WORK]

Attack this plan from four angles:

STRATEGIC ATTACK : Why is the direction fundamentally wrong? What are we misreading about the market?

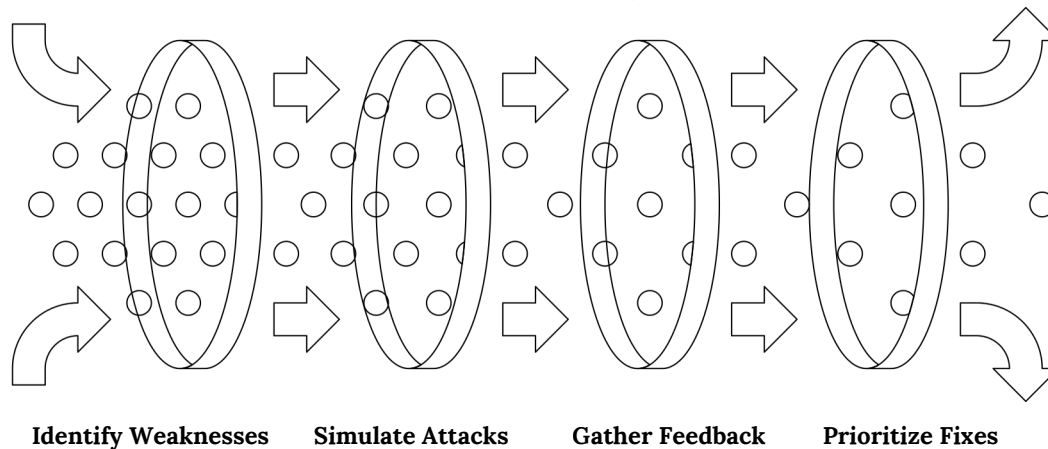
EXECUTION ATTACK : Why will we fail to implement this? Where is our team not capable enough?

COMPETITIVE ATTACK : How will competitors neutralise this? What move could make this irrelevant?

ASSUMPTION ATTACK : Which single assumption, if wrong, kills the entire plan?

End with: the one attack I should be most afraid of.

Red Team Thinking Process



PRO TIP

Ask AI to play devil's advocate on your most confident belief about your business. Not your uncertainties, your certainties. The assumptions you are most sure about are the ones least likely to be tested. That is exactly what makes them dangerous. Red Team your strongest convictions quarterly.

Pairs well with: 8.2 Pre-Mortem · 8.4 Risk Matrix · 1.8 Inversion · 1.5 Six Thinking Hats

8.7 — Eisenhower Matrix

Stop being busy. Start being effective.

USE THIS WHEN

You end every week feeling like you worked hard but didn't move the right things forward. Your calendar is full but your priorities aren't progressing. You are reactive, responding to what arrives rather than acting on what matters.

THE FRAMEWORK

Dwight D. Eisenhower, Supreme Allied Commander in World War II and 34th US President is credited with the observation that 'What is important is seldom urgent and what is urgent is seldom important.' Stephen Covey popularised this insight as a 2x2 matrix in *The 7 Habits of Highly Effective People*. The four quadrants are: **Q1 Urgent + Important** (do now - crises, deadlines), **Q2 Not Urgent + Important** (schedule - strategy, relationships, health, development), **Q3 Urgent + Not Important** (delegate - most interruptions, some meetings), **Q4 Not Urgent + Not Important** (eliminate - time wasters). The insight: **Q2 is where the highest-value work lives**, and it is the quadrant that gets sacrificed first when Q1 and Q3 crowd the calendar.

Origin: Dwight D. Eisenhower — adapted by Stephen Covey, *The 7 Habits*, 1989

HOW TO USE IT

1. Audit your last week's tasks against the four quadrants, the result is almost always sobering.
2. Q2 work must be scheduled in advance, or Q1 and Q3 will consume all available time.
3. Q3 items feel urgent because someone else made them urgent, they are delegation candidates.
4. Review your Q4 list quarterly, some items belong there, others are avoidance disguised as busyness.

Act as a personal effectiveness coach using the Eisenhower Matrix.

My role: [YOUR JOB TITLE AND KEY RESPONSIBILITIES]

This week's tasks: [LIST EVERYTHING ON YOUR PLATE]

Step 1: Classify each task into one of four quadrants:

Q1 URGENT + IMPORTANT : Do now

Q2 NOT URGENT + IMPORTANT : Schedule, protect this time

Q3 URGENT + NOT IMPORTANT : Delegate or batch

Q4 NOT URGENT + NOT IMPORTANT : Eliminate

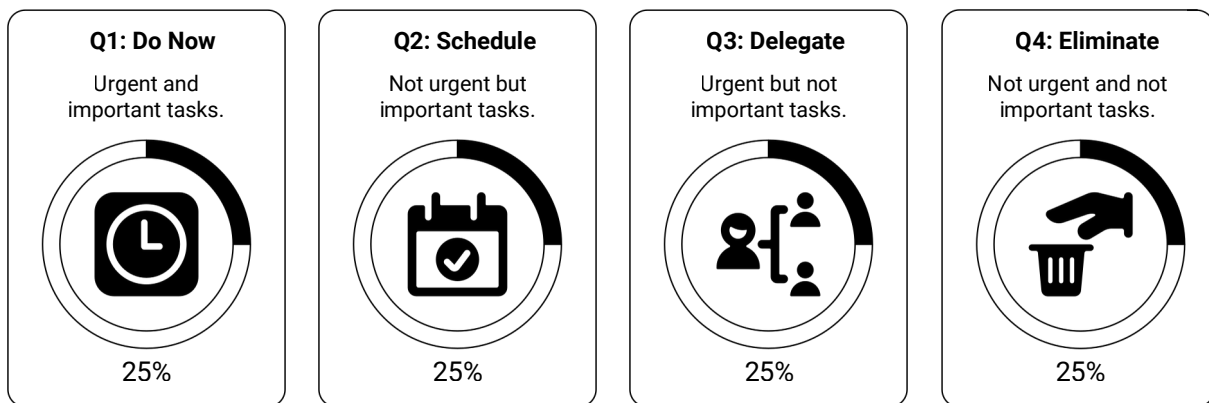
Step 2: Flag any Q2 item that has been on my list for more than 2 weeks, these are most at risk.

Step 3: Identify my top 3 Q2 priorities for this week and suggest when in my week to schedule them.

Step 4: For each Q3 item — who should own this instead?

Step 5: What is the Q4 item I should cut today?

Eisenhower Matrix: Task Prioritization



Prioritize important, non-urgent tasks to maximize effectiveness.

PRO TIP

Most founders' Q2 lists contain the same items week after week: exercise, strategy thinking, key relationships, learning. These are the things that matter most and keep getting deferred. The reason is always the same, they have no deadline and no consequence for deferral. The fix is equally simple: schedule them like meetings, put them in the calendar, and treat cancellation as a failure, not a choice.

Pairs well with: 8.1 DECIDE Framework · 7.4 ICE Scoring · 6.2 OKRs · 10.3 Weekly Review

8.8 — Regret Minimization Framework

Make the big decision from the perspective of your future self

USE THIS WHEN

You are facing a large, irreversible decision leaving a job, starting a company, making a major investment, ending a partnership and short-term fear or inertia is preventing you from thinking clearly about the long-term.

THE FRAMEWORK

Jeff Bezos developed the Regret Minimization Framework when deciding whether to leave his job at D.E. Shaw to start Amazon in 1994. The method is simple: **project yourself to age 80, looking back on your life. From that vantage point, ask which choice you would regret more doing it, or not doing it.** Bezos found that he would not regret trying and failing, but he would deeply regret never having tried. The framework shifts the decision from short-term risk calculus to long-term life alignment. AI can help you run this thought experiment with structured reflection prompts.

Origin: Jeff Bezos — Regret Minimization Framework, described publicly 1997

HOW TO USE IT

1. Use this framework for large, relatively irreversible decisions, not daily choices.
2. Be honest in the 80-year-old perspective romanticised or pessimistic projections both distort the output.
3. Consider both regrets: the regret of action (if it fails) and the regret of inaction (if you never try).
4. Combine with the DECIDE framework for decisions that need both long-term alignment and short-term rigor.

One Person's Regret Isn't Yours

Bezos regretted the road not taken, you might not. Be honest about your own relationship with risk, not the answer you think an entrepreneur is supposed to give.

Act as a reflective decision coach using Bezos's Regret Minimization Framework.

The decision I am facing : [DESCRIBE THE CHOICE - WHAT YOU ARE CONSIDERING DOING]

Current situation : [WHAT IS AT STAKE - WHAT YOU HAVE NOW]

Fear or hesitation : [WHAT IS STOPPING YOU]

Guide me through the Regret Minimization exercise:

STEP 1 — PROJECT FORWARD:

I am 80 years old, looking back at this moment.

Describe what my life looks like if I chose YES.

Describe what my life looks like if I chose NO.

STEP 2 — NAME THE REGRETS:

If I say YES and it fails - what do I regret?

If I say NO and never try - what do I regret?

Which regret is harder to live with?

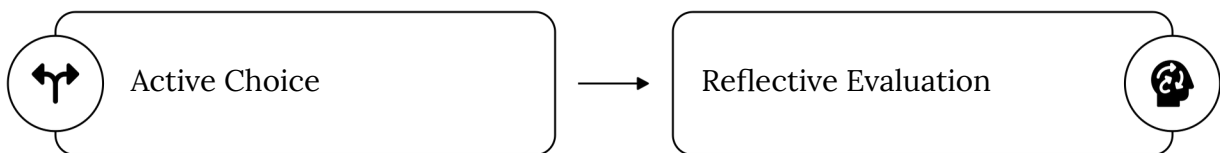
STEP 3 — CLARIFY:

What would the 80-year-old version of me tell the current version of me right now?

STEP 4 — NEXT STEP:

What is the smallest action that moves toward the less regretted path?

Regret Minimization Framework



PRO TIP

The Regret Minimization Framework is not a tool for avoiding hard decisions, it is a tool for making them from the right time horizon. Most people make large life decisions from a 1-3 year perspective and wonder why they feel unsatisfied with the outcome. The 80-year perspective doesn't remove risk, it removes the illusion that safety is risk-free.

Pairs well with: 8.1 DECIDE Framework · 8.9 Decision Tree · 10.5 Three Horizons · 10.9 Ikigai

8.9 — Decision Tree Analysis

Map every path your decision could take and the odds at each branch

USE THIS WHEN

You are facing a complex decision with multiple possible outcomes at each stage. The decision is not one choice but a sequence of choices, each dependent on what happens before it. You cannot see the whole picture clearly in your head.

THE FRAMEWORK

Decision Tree Analysis is an operations research methodology developed in the 1960s that maps decisions as branching trees. **Each node represents a decision point or chance event. Each branch represents an outcome with an associated probability and value.** Working through the tree, from branches back to the root - allows you to calculate the expected value of each initial choice and identify the path with the highest expected outcome. AI can build a decision tree description and calculate expected values when given decision options, probabilities, and outcome values.

Origin: Operations research methodology — Decision Tree Analysis formalised 1960s

HOW TO USE IT

1. Define your decision options and the key uncertainties before prompting.
2. Estimate probabilities honestly, if you don't know, use 50/50 and note the sensitivity.
3. Include the cost of making the decision itself (time, money, opportunity) in the tree.
4. After building the tree, test it: how much does the best path change if the key probability shifts by 20%?

Precision Isn't Certainty

A number on every branch feels rigorous, but a guessed 50/50 dressed up in a formal tree is still a guess. The tree organizes your thinking, it doesn't upgrade a bad probability estimate into a good one.

Act as a decision analysis consultant using Decision Tree Analysis.

Decision : [DESCRIBE THE MAIN CHOICE YOU ARE FACING]

Options : [LIST YOUR 2-4 ALTERNATIVE PATHS]

Key uncertainties : [WHAT OUTCOMES DEPEND ON CHANCE OR EXTERNAL FACTORS YOU CAN'T CONTROL]

Values: [WHAT EACH OUTCOME IS WORTH, REVENUE, COST, TIME, OR STRATEGIC VALUE]

Build a Decision Tree:

LEVEL 1: The initial decision - my options

LEVEL 2: For each option - the key chance events and their estimated probabilities

LEVEL 3: For each outcome - the value or consequence

CALCULATE:

Expected Value for each initial option = Sum of (probability × outcome value) per path

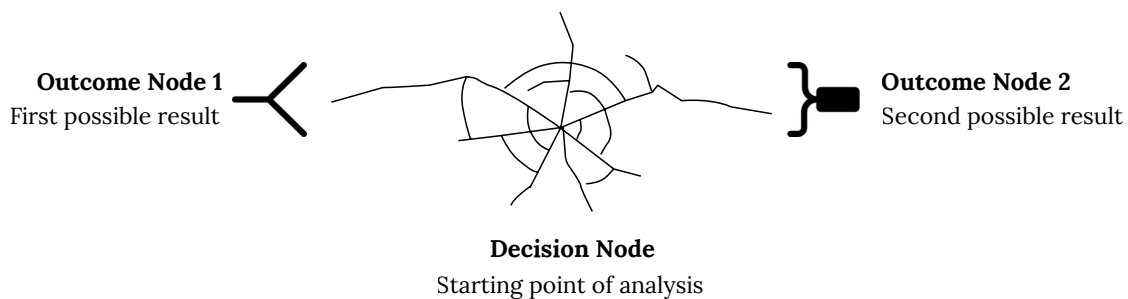
RECOMMEND:

Which option has the highest expected value?

Which has the best worst-case outcome?

What single probability estimate most changes the recommendation if it turns out to be wrong?

Decision Tree Analysis Impacts Outcomes



PRO TIP

The most valuable output from a Decision Tree is not the expected value calculation it is the sensitivity analysis. Find the probability estimate that, if wrong by 20%, changes which option is best. That is your most critical assumption. Validate it before committing to the path with the highest expected value.

Pairs well with: 8.10 Expected Value · 8.1 DECIDE · 8.5 Scenario Planning · 8.4 Risk Matrix

8.10 — Expected Value Framework

Make decisions with the math, not just the feeling

USE THIS WHEN

You are choosing between options that each have uncertain outcomes. Your gut says one thing, the numbers might say another. You want to make the call on evidence, not instinct alone but you're not sure how to quantify a decision that has multiple possible outcomes.

THE FRAMEWORK

Expected Value (EV) is a core concept from probability theory and decision science. **EV = the sum of (probability of each outcome × value of each outcome).** A decision with a 30% chance of gaining 1,000 and a 70% chance of gaining 100 has an EV of 370. The power of EV is that it forces you to explicitly state your probability estimates and outcome values making implicit assumptions explicit and comparable. Combined with Decision Trees (8.9), EV becomes the mathematical backbone of structured decision-making under uncertainty.

Origin: Probability theory — Expected Value applied to business decisions

HOW TO USE IT

1. List all possible outcomes for each option, not just the best and worst case.
2. Assign probabilities that sum to 100% across all outcomes for each option.
3. Include non-financial values by converting them to a common unit (time, reputation points, strategic value score).
4. EV is a long-run average, for one-time irreversible decisions, also consider the worst case explicitly.

EV Ignores Ruin

A high expected value means nothing if the downside bankrupts you. EV is a long-run average for a one-time irreversible bet, the worst case matters more than the math.

Act as a decision science consultant using Expected Value analysis.

Decision : [DESCRIBE THE CHOICE]

Options : [LIST YOUR 2-3 ALTERNATIVES]

For each option, define all possible outcomes:

OUTCOME : What could happen

PROBABILITY : Estimated likelihood (must sum to 100%)

VALUE: Financial, time, or strategic worth

Calculate Expected Value for each option:

EV = Sum of (Probability × Value) across all outcomes

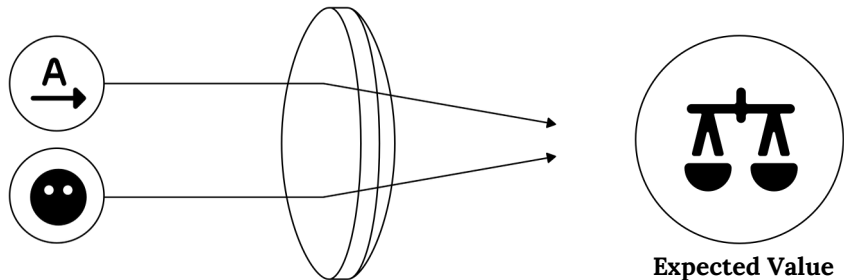
Then analyse:

1. Which option has the highest EV?
2. Which has the best downside protection?
3. What probability estimate am I most uncertain about?
4. How does the ranking change if that estimate shifts by +/- 20%?
5. If I could run this decision 100 times, which option wins most often?

Calculating Expected Value

Outcome A
Probability of Outcome A multiplied by its value.

Outcome B
Probability of Outcome B multiplied by its value.



PRO TIP

The '100 times' question at the end is the most clarifying. EV is a long-run average, it tells you which option wins if you could repeat the decision many times. For irreversible, once-in-a-career decisions, EV is necessary but not sufficient. Pair it with worst-case analysis: can you survive the worst outcome of the highest-EV option? If yes, take it. If no, reconsider.

Pairs well with: 8.9 Decision Tree · 8.4 Risk Matrix · 8.5 Scenario Planning · 9.2 Burn Rate

MODULE 9

Finance & Metrics

Know your numbers. Own your narrative.

WHAT THIS MODULE DOES

You do not need to be a CFO to run a financially healthy business. You need to understand nine numbers and one story. This module gives you the frameworks to know whether your unit economics work, how long your runway is, what metric defines your growth, and how to present your financial reality to investors in a way that builds confidence rather than questions. Finance is not accounting it is the language of business decisions.

IN THIS MODULE

- 9.1 Unit Economics — LTV:CAC
- 9.2 Burn Rate & Runway
- 9.3 North Star Metric & OMTM
- 9.4 AARRR Funnel Analysis — Deep Dive
- 9.5 Investor Narrative — Pitch Spine
- 9.6 3-Scenario Financial Model
- 9.7 Balanced Scorecard
- 9.8 Cash Conversion Cycle
- 9.9 Rule of 40

Start here if you are new to AI, or your prompts feel hit-or-miss.

9.1 — Unit Economics – LTV:CAC

The two numbers that tell you whether your business model actually works

USE THIS WHEN

You are acquiring customers and growing revenue but you're not sure whether each customer is genuinely profitable when you account for the full cost of acquiring and serving them. You might be scaling a model that loses money per customer.

THE FRAMEWORK

LTV:CAC is the foundational unit economics ratio for any customer-acquisition business. LTV (Lifetime Value) is the total revenue a customer generates over their relationship with you, minus the cost to serve them. CAC (Customer Acquisition Cost) is the total cost – marketing, sales, onboarding – to acquire one customer. **The ratio tells you how much value you get back per dollar spent acquiring a customer.** A ratio of 3:1 or higher is generally considered healthy – meaning every dollar spent on acquisition returns three dollars of lifetime value. Below 1:1 means you are paying more to acquire customers than they are worth.

The ratio alone does not tell you the full story without payback period. A business can show a healthy 4:1 ratio while taking three years to recoup each customer's acquisition cost, which is a cash flow problem the ratio hides.

Origin: SaaS & venture capital methodology – LTV:CAC framework widely standardised 2010s

HOW TO USE IT

1. Calculate LTV using actual retention data not assumed churn rates. Real churn is almost always higher than expected.
2. Calculate CAC by dividing total sales and marketing spend by new customers acquired in the same period.
3. Segment LTV and CAC by customer type averages hide the fact that some segments are highly profitable and others destroy value.
4. Track the LTV:CAC ratio monthly improvement signals a healthier model, decline signals a problem before it becomes a crisis.

Act as a startup finance advisor specialising in unit economics.

My business model : [DESCRIBE HOW YOU ACQUIRE AND RETAIN CUSTOMERS]

Revenue model : [SUBSCRIPTION / TRANSACTION / USAGE-BASED]

Help me calculate and analyse my LTV:CAC:

LTV CALCULATION:

Average Revenue Per Customer (monthly or annual): [X]

Gross Margin %: [X]

Average Customer Lifespan or Churn Rate: [X]

$LTV = (ARPC \times \text{Gross Margin}) / \text{Churn Rate}$

CAC CALCULATION:

Total Sales & Marketing Spend (last period): [X]

New Customers Acquired (same period): [X]

$CAC = \text{Total Spend} / \text{New Customers}$

ANALYSIS:

1. What is my LTV:CAC ratio?
2. How does it compare to healthy benchmarks for my model?
3. What is the payback period (months to recover CAC)?
4. What one change would most improve this ratio?

Factors Influencing LTV : CAC Ratio



PRO TIP

Payback period is often more important than the LTV:CAC ratio for early-stage companies. A 5:1 LTV:CAC sounds excellent, until you realise the payback period is 36 months and you're burning cash for three years before each customer turns profitable. A 2.5:1 ratio with a 9-month payback is often a healthier business than a 5:1 with a 30-month payback.

Pairs well with: 9.2 Burn Rate · 5.9 AARRR · 9.3 North Star Metric · 9.6 Financial Model

9.2 — Burn Rate & Runway

Know exactly how much time you have and what you're spending it on

USE THIS WHEN

You are running a funded startup or a business with variable revenue and you do not have a clear, current view of how many months of operating capital you have left. Financial decisions are being made without a clear runway calculation.

THE FRAMEWORK

Burn Rate is the rate at which a company is spending its cash reserves above revenue, either Gross Burn (total monthly expenditure) or Net Burn (monthly cash lost after revenue). **Runway is the number of months until cash reaches zero at the current net burn rate.** These two numbers are the most fundamental financial metrics for any pre-profitability business. Every strategic decision, hiring, marketing investment, product bets, changes the runway. AI can help model the impact of decisions on runway and identify the break-even scenarios.

Origin: Startup finance fundamentals — burn rate and runway widely standardised in VC lexicon

HOW TO USE IT

1. Calculate net burn monthly, not quarterly, cash positions change faster than quarterly reviews reveal.
2. Build your runway calculation from the bottom up, know exactly what each expense line contributes to burn.
3. Model three burn scenarios: current trajectory, growth scenario (higher spend + revenue), and conservation scenario.
4. Set a runway alert threshold, when you hit 9 months of runway, fundraising or cost review must begin immediately.



Waiting until you hit 9 months to start fundraising is already too late, fundraising itself takes months, and a shrinking runway makes you negotiate from weakness. The threshold triggers action, it doesn't wait for it.

Act as a startup CFO advisor.

My financials:

Current cash / reserves: [AMOUNT]

Monthly revenue : [CURRENT MRR OR ARR / 12]

Monthly expenses (total) : [BREAKDOWN IF POSSIBLE:

Salaries: [X]

Infrastructure: [X]

Marketing: [X]

Other: [X]]

Calculate:

GROSS BURN : Total monthly cash out

NET BURN : Gross burn minus monthly revenue

RUNWAY : Current cash / net burn = months remaining

Then model three scenarios:

SCENARIO A (Current) : Runway at current trajectory

SCENARIO B (Growth) : If I hire 2 people and double marketing, new runway?

SCENARIO C (Conserve) : If I cut non-essential spend 30%, how much runway does that add?

At what monthly revenue does net burn hit zero?

What is the fastest path to break-even?

PRO TIP

The most important burn rate insight is not the number itself — it is the break-even revenue calculation. Knowing that you need 45,000 in monthly revenue to reach zero net burn gives you a concrete target that connects financial health to sales activity. Every founder should know their break-even revenue number without having to look it up.

Pairs well with: 9.1 LTV:CAC · 9.6 Financial Model · 8.10 Expected Value · 9.9 Rule of 40

9.3 — North Star Metric & OMTM

Find the one number that predicts every thing else and focus your entire company on moving it

USE THIS WHEN

Your team tracks many metrics but none of them feel like the right one. Different teams optimise for different numbers. Metrics move up and down without anyone being sure whether the business is actually getting better or worse.

THE FRAMEWORK

The North Star Metric is the single metric that best **captures the core value your product delivers to customers and that, when it grows, predicts long-term company health.**

Examples: Airbnb's North Star is nights booked, Spotify's is time spent listening, Slack's is messages sent.

The OMTM (One Metric That Matters), coined in Lean Analytics by Alistair Croll and Ben Yoskovitz, is the one metric your company should focus on above all others at the current stage of growth. Unlike the North Star (long-term), the OMTM shifts as the company moves through stages. AI can help you identify both for your specific business model and stage.

Origin: Eric Ries / Lean Analytics — North Star Metric · Alistair Croll & Ben Yoskovitz, OMTM, 2013

HOW TO USE IT

1. Your North Star Metric must measure value delivered to customers, not revenue extracted from them.
2. The OMTM changes as you move through startup stages, what matters in pre-product-fit is different from what matters in scaling.
3. Instrument your product to track the North Star automatically, not manually.
4. Build every team's weekly goals around moving the North Star, not their departmental metrics.

Act as a growth strategy advisor specialising in metrics design.

My business : [DESCRIBE YOUR PRODUCT AND BUSINESS MODEL]

Stage : [PRE-REVENUE / EARLY TRACTION / GROWTH / SCALING]

Current metrics tracked : [LIST WHAT YOU MEASURE NOW]

Step 1 : Define my North Star Metric.

It must: measure value to customers, predict revenue, be trackable, and be moveable by my team.

Suggest 3 candidates and recommend the strongest.

Step 2 : Define my OMTM for my current stage.

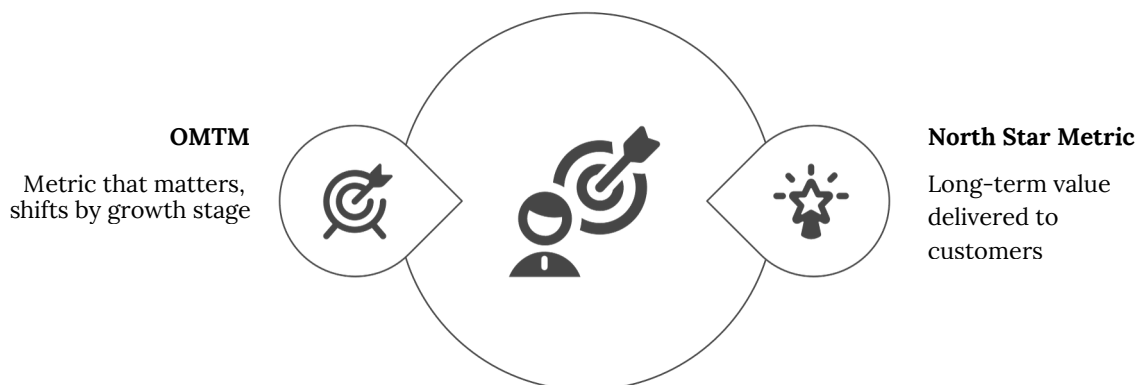
What one metric should I obsess over right now? Why this one above all others at this stage?

Step 3 : Build a metrics hierarchy.

What are the 3–5 leading indicators that predict movement in the North Star?

Step 4 : What is one metric I am currently tracking that is a vanity metric and should be dropped?

Understanding North Star Metric and OMTM



PRO TIP

The most common North Star mistake is choosing a metric that measures your activity instead of the customer's value. 'Registered users' measures your acquisition, not their value. 'Users who completed their first meaningful action' measures whether they got value. The metric must describe something good happening for the customer, not something good happening for you.

Pairs well with: 5.9 AARRR · 9.4 Funnel Analysis · 6.2 OKRs · 9.1 LTV:CAC

9.4 — AARRR Funnel Analysis Deep Dive

Turn your growth metrics into a diagnostic that tells you exactly what to fix

USE THIS WHEN

You are measuring acquisition and revenue but not the middle of the funnel. You are investing in growth without knowing which stage is most broken. You optimise the top of the funnel while the leaks in the middle undo all the gains.

THE FRAMEWORK

While AARRR was introduced in Module 5 as a marketing framework, in **the Finance module it is used as a quantitative diagnostic tool**. By populating each stage with real numbers not aspirations and calculating conversion rates between stages, you create a financial model of your growth engine. The compound effect of improving each stage by 10% is modelled to show the revenue impact. AI can build this model when given your actual stage metrics and calculate the highest-leverage improvement point.

Origin: Dave McClure, 500 Startups — AARRR, 2007 · Applied as financial diagnostic tool

HOW TO USE IT

1. Measure all five stages before analysing any of them incomplete funnels produce misleading conclusions.
2. Calculate stage-to-stage conversion rates, not just top-to-bottom the leak is almost always in one specific transition.
3. Model the revenue impact of a 10% improvement at each stage the resulting number reveals where to invest.
4. Run this analysis quarterly conversion rates change as your product and messaging evolve.



A 10% gain at every stage looks great on paper, but stages interact in the real world. Model the number, then verify it against what actually happens next quarter.

AI PROMPT — COPY & PASTE READY

Act as a growth analytics advisor running a deep AARRR analysis.

My business : [DESCRIBE PRODUCT AND REVENUE MODEL]

Populate my funnel with current numbers:

ACQUISITION : Monthly visitors / leads: [X]

ACTIVATION : % who complete first key action: [X%]

RETENTION : 30-day retention or monthly churn: [X%]

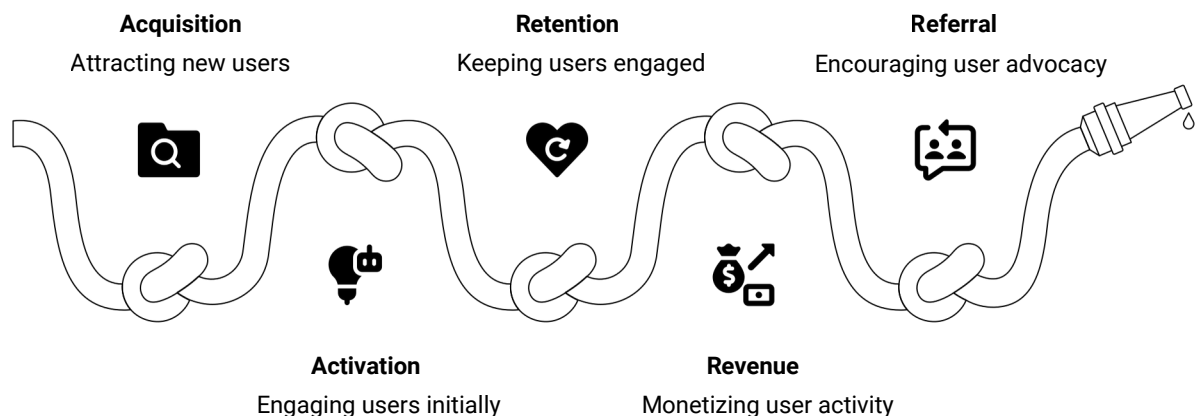
REVENUE : % who convert to paying: [X%] · Average revenue per paying user: [X]

REFERRAL : % who refer at least one other user: [X%]

ANALYSIS:

1. Calculate conversion rate at each stage transition
2. Identify the stage with the worst conversion the biggest leak in the funnel
3. Model the revenue impact if that stage improved 10%
4. Model the revenue impact if every stage improved 10%
5. Recommend the 2 highest-ROI experiments to run at the weakest stage
6. What is my current revenue per acquired visitor?

What would it be at healthy benchmark conversion rates?



PRO TIP

Run the 10% improvement model for each stage and compare the revenue impact numbers. The stage where a 10% improvement produces the largest revenue gain is your highest-leverage investment. In most early-stage businesses, this is Activation the transition from visitor to engaged user. Fixing Activation compounds through every downstream stage simultaneously.

Pairs well with: 9.3 North Star · 9.1 LTV:CAC · 5.9 AARRR · 5.8 Growth Loop

9.5 — Investor Narrative Pitch Spine

Tell the story of your business so investors lean in – not check their phones

USE THIS WHEN

You have a real business but your fundraising conversations are not landing. Investors say they'll think about it. Your deck is comprehensive but the narrative is not compelling. You're presenting data when you should be telling a story.

THE FRAMEWORK

The Pitch Spine is a narrative structure synthesised from the YC application framework, Sequoia's pitch deck template, and the StoryBrand methodology. It has seven beats: **The World As It Was** (the status quo that creates the problem), **The Problem** (specific, painful, underserved), **The Insight** (the non-obvious truth that makes your solution possible), **The Solution** (your specific approach why now, why this), **The Proof** (traction, metrics, or validation), **The Ask** (exactly what you need and why), and **The Vision** (the world your company creates at scale). Each beat must earn the next if the investor is not nodding by The Insight, The Solution will not land.

Origin: YC application framework · Sequoia pitch deck structure · StoryBrand narrative

HOW TO USE IT

1. Write The Insight first, it is the hardest and most important beat. If it is obvious, rewrite it.
2. The Problem must be painful enough that the investor immediately wants a solution. If it doesn't hurt, deepen it
3. Proof does not have to be revenue, it can be retention, NPS, letters of intent, or waitlist size.
4. The Ask must be specific: amount, use of funds, and the milestone it buys you.



If The Insight feels obvious to you, it will feel obvious to the investor too and the pitch stalls right there. Every beat after it inherits that flatness, no matter how strong your traction numbers are.

Act as a venture capital pitch coach.

My business : [DESCRIBE WHAT YOU DO IN 2 SENTENCES]

Stage : [PRE-SEED / SEED / SERIES A]

Traction : [YOUR BEST PROOF POINT - REVENUE, USERS, RETENTION]

Ask : [AMOUNT AND WHAT IT WILL BE USED FOR]

Write my Pitch Spine - all seven beats:

THE WORLD AS IT WAS : The status quo - how this problem has always been handled

THE PROBLEM : Specific pain - who feels it, how bad

THE INSIGHT : The non-obvious truth that unlocks the solution
(this is your unfair insight)

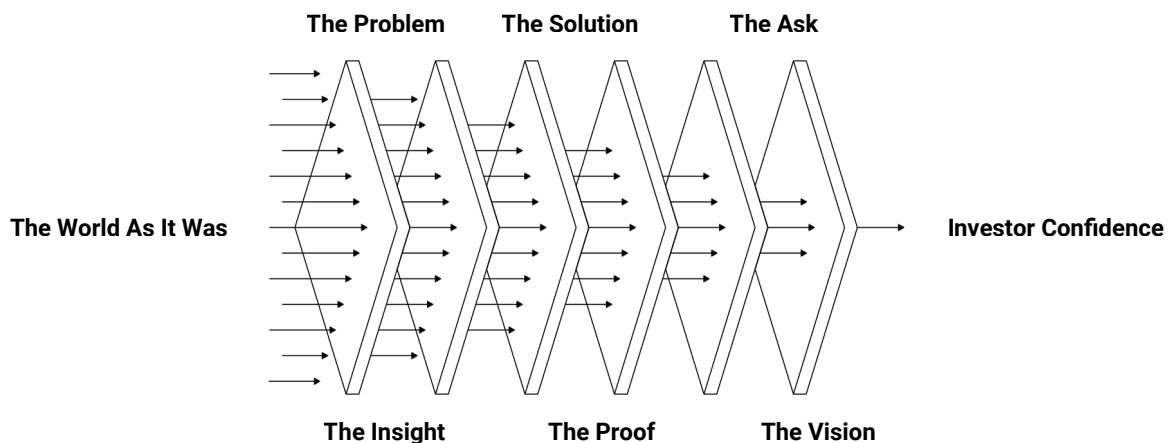
THE SOLUTION : What you built and why it works now

THE PROOF : Your strongest evidence it is working

THE ASK : Exact amount, use of funds, key milestone

THE VISION : The world your company creates at scale

Write each beat as 2-3 sentences. Make them build on each other.



PRO TIP

The Insight beat is what separates memorable pitches from forgettable ones. It should make the investor think: 'I've never heard it framed that way, but that's exactly right.' If your insight is something any well-read person already knows, it is not an insight - it is context. Push harder. The insight is often the founder's deepest, least comfortable belief about why everyone else is wrong.

Pairs well with: 9.1 LTV:CAC · 9.2 Burn Rate · 5.1 StoryBrand · 2.3 Lean Canvas

9.6 — 3-Scenario Financial Model

Plan for the future you want and the two you might get instead

USE THIS WHEN

You have a single financial plan that assumes everything goes roughly as expected. When reality diverges and it always does, you have no framework for how to respond. Every deviation triggers a re-plan from scratch.

THE FRAMEWORK

The 3-Scenario Financial Model is a planning practice used by CFOs and serious operators to replace single-point forecasting with range forecasting. The three scenarios are: **Base Case** (most likely trajectory - what you genuinely expect), **Bull Case** (everything works - best realistic outcome, not fantasy), and **Bear Case** (things go worse than expected - what you plan for but hope doesn't happen). The model forces you to define the key drivers of each scenario and the decision triggers, what happens in Month 3 that tells you which scenario you're in, and what you do about it.

Origin: CFO best practice — 3-scenario modelling widely used in venture-backed companies

HOW TO USE IT

1. Build the model around 3–5 key drivers, not 50 line items. Key drivers are the variables that most affect the outcome.
2. Define scenario triggers before you need them, what metric, at what level, confirms each scenario?
3. The Bear Case must be survivable, if it would kill the company, your base case planning is too aggressive.
4. Share all three scenarios with your board or key investors, single-scenario plans erode trust when they miss.



If your Bear Case would kill the company, you don't have a Bear Case, you have a Base Case wearing a disguise. Rebuild it until it's survivable, or the exercise is theater.

Act as a startup CFO building a 3-scenario financial model.

My business : [REVENUE MODEL, STAGE, CURRENT METRICS]

Planning horizon : [6 MONTHS / 12 MONTHS / 18 MONTHS]

Key revenue drivers : [WHAT DRIVES REVENUE - DEALS, USERS, USAGE]

Key cost drivers : [HEADCOUNT, INFRASTRUCTURE, MARKETING]

Build a 3-scenario model:

BASE CASE: Most likely trajectory

Revenue assumption, cost assumption, key metric target

End-state : cash position, burn, milestone achieved

BULL CASE : Everything works - best realistic outcome

What accelerates - which driver performs above base?

End-state : cash, burn, milestone, optionality created

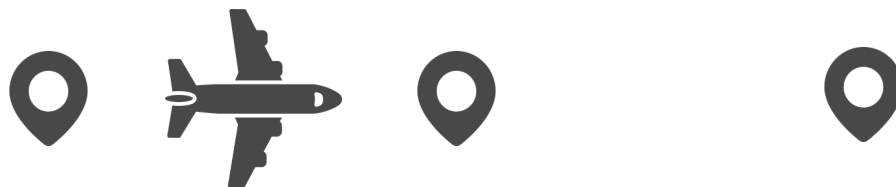
BEAR CASE : Things go worse - survivable but hard

What underperforms - which driver falls short?

End-state : cash, burn, how long can we operate?

SCENARIO TRIGGERS : What would I observe by month 3 that confirms each scenario?

DECISION PLAYBOOK : What do I do differently in each?



Bear Case

Worst realistic outcome

Base Case

Most likely outcome

Bull Case

Best realistic outcome

PRO TIP

The most important output from scenario modelling is the Bear Case decision playbook. Define now - before you need it - what you will cut first, what you will protect at all costs, and at what runway level you take action. Leaders who make these decisions in advance act calmly when the moment arrives. Leaders who haven't made them in advance make poor decisions under pressure.

Pairs well with: 9.2 Burn Rate · 9.1 LTV:CAC · 8.5 Scenario Planning · 8.10 Expected Value

9.7 — Balanced Scorecard

Measure what matters not just what is easy to count

USE THIS WHEN

Your business metrics are almost entirely financial – revenue, costs, and margin. But the things that will determine your financial results next year, customer satisfaction, team capability, operational efficiency, innovation pipeline, are not being measured at all.

THE FRAMEWORK

Developed by Robert Kaplan and David Norton at Harvard Business School and published in Harvard Business Review in 1992, the Balanced Scorecard measures business performance across four perspectives: **Financial** (how do we look to shareholders?), **Customer** (how do customers see us?), **Internal Processes** (what must we excel at?), and **Learning & Growth** (can we continue to improve and create value?). The insight is that financial metrics are lagging indicators – they tell you what happened. The other three perspectives contain the leading indicators that predict future financial performance.

Origin: Robert Kaplan & David Norton, Harvard Business School – Balanced Scorecard, 1992

HOW TO USE IT

1. Build the scorecard around your strategy, not generic KPIs. Each measure must connect to a strategic objective.
2. Limit to 4–5 measures per perspective, more creates noise and diffuses attention.
3. Financial metrics are the output; Learning & Growth metrics are the input. Both matter.
4. Review the scorecard monthly at leadership level quarterly is too infrequent for meaningful course correction.



By the time your Financial numbers move, the problem started months earlier in Customer or Learning & Growth. Watching only the lagging quadrant means you're always reacting to a story that already finished.

Act as a business performance consultant using the Balanced Scorecard.

My business : [DESCRIBE YOUR COMPANY, STAGE, AND STRATEGY]

Strategic priorities : [YOUR TOP 3 OBJECTIVES FOR THIS YEAR]

Build a Balanced Scorecard across all four perspectives:

FINANCIAL PERSPECTIVE : Objective, Measure, Target, Initiative

CUSTOMER PERSPECTIVE : Objective, Measure, Target, Initiative

INTERNAL PROCESS PERSPECTIVE : Objective, Measure, Target, Initiative

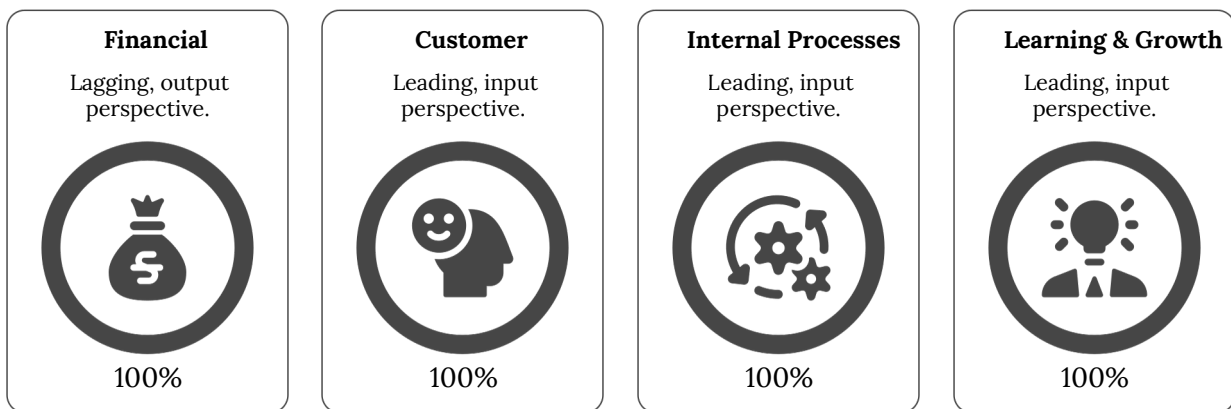
LEARNING & GROWTH PERSPECTIVE : Objective, Measure, Target, Initiative

After building: show the causal chain.

How does improvement in Learning & Growth lead to better Internal Processes, which leads to better Customer outcomes, which drives Financial results?

Draw the arrows explicitly.

Balanced Scorecard



The Balanced Scorecard balances financial outcomes with customer, internal, and learning perspectives.

PRO TIP

The causal chain exercise at the end is the most valuable part. If you cannot draw a clear line from your Learning & Growth measures to your Financial outcomes, your scorecard is a collection of metrics, not a strategy. The power of the Balanced Scorecard is not measurement, it is the explicit theory of how your business creates value.

Pairs well with: 6.2 OKRs · 6.10 Hoshin Kanri · 9.3 North Star · 9.4 Funnel Analysis

9.8 — Cash Conversion Cycle

Understand how fast your business turns activity into actual cash

USE THIS WHEN

Your business is profitable on paper but always tight on cash. Invoices are raised but payment is slow. You are funding your customers' operations with your own cash flow without realising it.

THE FRAMEWORK

The Cash Conversion Cycle (CCC) measures how long it takes for a business to convert its investments in inventory, services, or sales activity into cash receipts. **CCC = Days Sales Outstanding** (how long to collect from customers) + **Days Inventory Outstanding** (how long stock sits, if applicable) - **Days Payable Outstanding** (how long you take to pay suppliers). A negative CCC means you collect cash before you have to pay like Amazon or Dell. A high positive CCC means you are funding operations with cash before it arrives, creating persistent working capital strain.

Origin: Corporate finance methodology — Cash Conversion Cycle widely used in operations finance

HOW TO USE IT

1. Calculate each component of your CCC from the last 90 days, not estimates.
2. Days Sales Outstanding is usually the highest-leverage improvement for service businesses.
3. Shortening payment terms and offering early payment discounts both reduce DSO directly.
4. A rising CCC is often the first financial signal of a scaling problem, before it shows in the P&L;



A rising CCC won't show up in your P&L for months - profitability can look fine while you're quietly running out of cash. If growth feels good but the bank balance feels tight, check the CCC before you check the income statement.

Act as a working capital advisor using the Cash Conversion Cycle framework.

My business: [DESCRIBE YOUR REVENUE MODEL AND PAYMENT TERMS]

Current data:

Average days to collect payment from customers: [X days]

Average days inventory is held (if applicable): [X days]

Average days to pay suppliers: [X days]

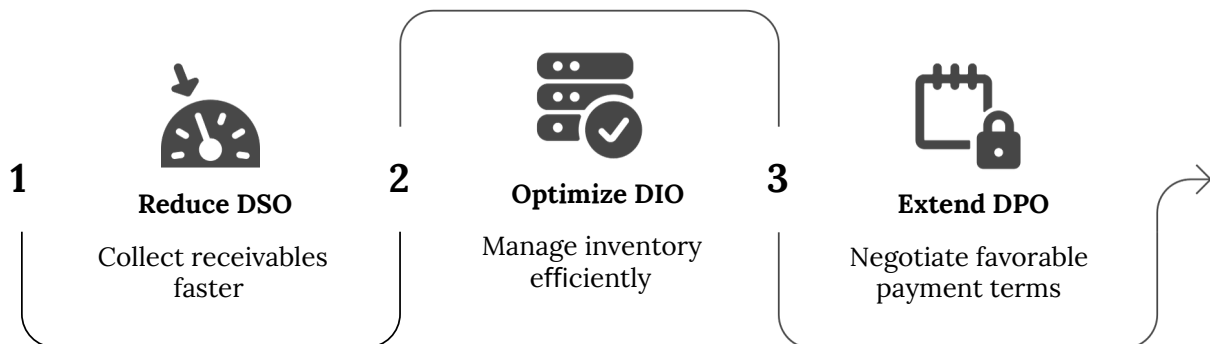
Calculate my Cash Conversion Cycle:

$CCC = \text{Days Sales Outstanding (DSO)} + \text{Days Inventory Outstanding (DIO)} - \text{Days Payable Outstanding (DPO)}$

Analyse:

1. What does my CCC tell me about my working capital health?
2. Which component is the biggest drag on cash flow?
3. What are 3 specific actions to shorten DSO?
4. What payment terms or structures would improve my CCC?
5. If I reduced my CCC by 10 days, how much additional cash would that free up at my current revenue run rate?

Optimizing Cash Conversion Cycle



PRO TIP

For service businesses, Days Sales Outstanding is almost always the lever. The most effective DSO reduction tactic is upfront payment or deposit - not better invoicing. Structuring contracts to collect 30–50% before work begins can transform a cash-tight business into a cash-positive one without changing a single cost line.

Pairs well with: 9.2 Burn Rate · 9.1 LTV:CAC · 9.6 Financial Model · 9.9 Rule of 40

9.9 — Rule of 40

The single benchmark that tells investors whether your SaaS business is healthy

USE THIS WHEN

You are a SaaS or subscription business trying to balance growth and profitability. Investors ask whether you are growing fast enough or profitable enough and you are not sure how to frame the answer in a way that makes the tradeoff clear.

THE FRAMEWORK

The Rule of 40 was popularised by venture investors Brad Feld and Fred Wilson as a benchmark for SaaS business health. It states that a healthy SaaS company's revenue growth rate plus its profit margin should equal or exceed 40. A company growing at 60% with a -20% margin scores 40. A company growing at 15% with a 25% margin also scores 40. Both are considered healthy. The rule allows a company to trade growth for profitability or vice versa, as long as the combined score stays above 40. Below 40 signals either insufficient growth or insufficient efficiency.

Origin: Brad Feld & Fred Wilson — Rule of 40 for SaaS, 2015

HOW TO USE IT

1. Calculate your Rule of 40 score monthly and track the trend the direction matters as much as the level.
2. Early-stage companies should skew toward growth (high growth rate, negative margin) the rule becomes more relevant at \$5M+ ARR.
3. Use the Rule of 40 to frame the growth vs profitability tradeoff in investor conversations explicitly.
4. If your score is below 40, use the model to identify whether the fix is growth acceleration or cost reduction.



Below \$5M ARR, the Rule of 40 isn't yet the right lens, investors expect growth to dominate, even at a steep loss. Applying it too early can make a normal, healthy growth-stage burn look like a problem it isn't.

Act as a SaaS financial advisor using the Rule of 40.

My business metrics:

Annual Recurring Revenue (ARR): [CURRENT ARR]

ARR 12 months ago: [PRIOR YEAR ARR]

EBITDA or Operating Profit Margin: [X% - negative if burning]

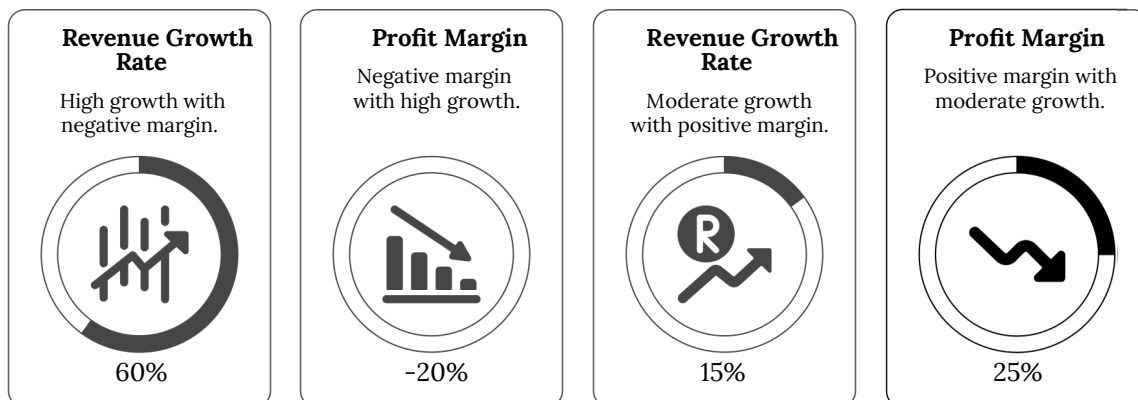
Calculate my Rule of 40 score:

Revenue Growth Rate = (Current ARR - Prior ARR) / Prior ARR

Rule of 40 Score = Growth Rate % + Profit Margin %

Analyse:

1. What is my current Rule of 40 score?
2. How does it compare to the 40 benchmark?
3. Am I growth-led or efficiency-led - which matters more at my current stage?
4. To reach a score of 40, should I prioritise accelerating growth or improving margin?
5. What is the single most impactful action to improve my score by 5 points in 6 months?



The Rule of 40 balances revenue growth and profit margin to assess business health.

PRO TIP

The Rule of 40 is most useful as a framing tool in investor conversations, not as an internal operating metric. When an investor asks about your growth vs profitability tradeoff, presenting a Rule of 40 score and explaining your strategy for where it should go signals financial maturity. Most founders don't know this number. Knowing it immediately sets you apart.

Pairs well with: 9.2 Burn Rate · 9.6 Financial Model · 9.1 LTV:CAC · 9.5 Investor Narrative

MODULE 10

Lead Yourself First

The company can only grow as fast as its founder.

WHAT THIS MODULE DOES

Every other module in this book helps you build a better business. This one helps you become a better founder. The habits, mental models, and self-awareness frameworks here are the ones that separate founders who scale from founders who stall. Three frameworks in this module come from Japanese philosophy Ikigai, Hansei, and Wabi-Sabi, because some of the deepest wisdom about purposeful work and graceful imperfection comes from outside the Western management tradition.

IN THIS MODULE

- 10.1 Personal SWOT
- 10.2 90-Day Planning
- 10.3 Weekly Review — GTD 5-15
- 10.4 4 Energy Quadrants
- 10.5 Three Horizons Vision
- 10.6 Atomic Habits Stack
- 10.7 Socratic Self-Questioning
- 10.8 Personal Brand Flywheel
- 10.9 Ikigai
- 10.10 Hansei — Reflective Practice
- 10.11 Wabi-Sabi — Imperfect Progress

Start here if you are new to AI, or your prompts feel hit-or-miss.

10.1 — Personal SWOT

See yourself clearly before the market does it for you

USE THIS WHEN

You are making career and business decisions based on a self-image that may not reflect reality. You either underestimate what you bring or overestimate your readiness. You haven't done an honest audit of where you genuinely stand.

THE FRAMEWORK

Applying the SWOT framework to yourself rather than to a business creates a structured self-assessment that combines honesty with strategy. Personal Strengths are capabilities and qualities you genuinely have, verified by evidence. Personal Weaknesses are areas where you consistently underperform or avoid. Opportunities are external conditions you could leverage given your specific strengths. Threats are external conditions that specifically threaten you given your specific weaknesses. The strategic output is identifying which strengths to double down on and which weaknesses need a hire, a partner, or deliberate development.

Origin: Stanford Research Institute – SWOT adapted for personal development

HOW TO USE IT

1. Ask three people who know your work well to complete the Strengths and Weaknesses sections, your self-assessment will miss things they see clearly.
2. Focus Opportunities on things only you can access given your specific combination of strengths.
3. For each Weakness, decide: develop it, delegate it, or design around it. Not every weakness is worth fixing.
4. Run Personal SWOT annually your position changes as the business evolves.



Skippping the outside input is the most common way this exercise fails, self-assessed strengths and weaknesses tend to reflect what you want to believe, not what's actually true.

Act as a personal development coach conducting a Personal SWOT.

My background : [DESCRIBE YOUR EXPERIENCE, SKILLS, TRACK RECORD]

My role : [WHAT YOU DO AND WHAT YOU ARE RESPONSIBLE FOR]

External feedback : [ANY FEEDBACK YOU HAVE RECEIVED - GOOD OR BAD]

Current goals : [WHAT YOU ARE TRYING TO ACHIEVE IN THE NEXT 12 MONTHS]

Build a Personal SWOT:

STRENGTHS : What do I consistently do better than most? What do others come to me for?

Give 4–5 specific, evidence-backed strengths.

WEAKNESSES : Where do I consistently underperform? What do I avoid or procrastinate on?

Be honest - what do people notice that I minimise?

OPPORTUNITIES : Given my strengths, what external conditions could I leverage that others could not?

THREATS : Given my weaknesses, what external conditions specifically threaten my goals?

Strategic output : top 2 strengths to build on, top 1 weakness to address immediately.

Personal SWOT

Quadrant	Strengths	Weaknesses	Opportunities	Threats
Description	Capabilities you genuinely have, verified by others	Areas you consistently underperform or avoid	External conditions you can leverage given your strengths	External conditions that exploit your weaknesses

PRO TIP

The most valuable Personal SWOT input is unsolicited feedback you have dismissed or minimised. The things people have told you repeatedly but that you haven't fully accepted - those are your most accurate weakness data. The reason you dismissed them is usually the reason they are true.

Pairs well with: 3.1 SWOT · 10.5 Three Horizons · 10.7 Socratic Self-Questioning · 10.9 Ikigai

10.2 — 90-Day Planning

The planning window that is long enough to matter and short enough to execute

USE THIS WHEN

Annual plans lose relevance by February. Weekly plans are too reactive to build toward anything significant. You need a planning rhythm that bridges long-term vision and short-term action — one that is committed enough to drive behaviour but flexible enough to accommodate reality.

THE FRAMEWORK

The 90-day planning framework, popularised by Michael Watkins in *The First 90 Days* and **widely adopted in the startup and executive world, uses a 13-week window as the fundamental planning unit**. Ninety days is long enough to complete a meaningful initiative, short enough to stay relevant, and naturally aligns with quarterly business rhythms. A well-structured 90-day plan has three elements: **three Breakthrough Goals** (the outcomes that will make this quarter meaningful), **Weekly Milestones** (the proof that each goal is on track), and a **Weekly Review habit** (the discipline that closes the loop). The framework fails most often not from picking the wrong goals but from picking too many. Three genuinely completed goals beat seven half-finished ones, and the discipline of saying no to the fourth goal is where most of the real planning work happens.

*Origin: Michael Watkins, *The First 90 Days*, 2003 · Quarterly planning methodology*

HOW TO USE IT

1. Choose three Breakthrough Goals — not ten. Three that are completed beats ten that are half-done.
2. Each goal should be uncomfortable to commit to — if it feels safe, lower the ambition or pick a different goal.
3. Build weekly milestones before the quarter starts, if you can't describe progress at week 4, the goal is not specific enough.
4. Schedule a 30-minute quarterly review on the last day of each 90-day period before starting the next.

Act as a 90-day planning coach.

My context : [YOUR ROLE, CURRENT BUSINESS STAGE, KEY PRIORITIES]

Longer-term vision : [WHERE YOU ARE TRYING TO GET TO IN 12-18 MONTHS]

Current blockers : [WHAT IS SLOWING YOUR PROGRESS MOST]

Build my 90-Day Plan:

BREAKTHROUGH GOALS : 3 outcomes that would make this quarter genuinely significant not just busy.

For each: define what done looks like measurably.

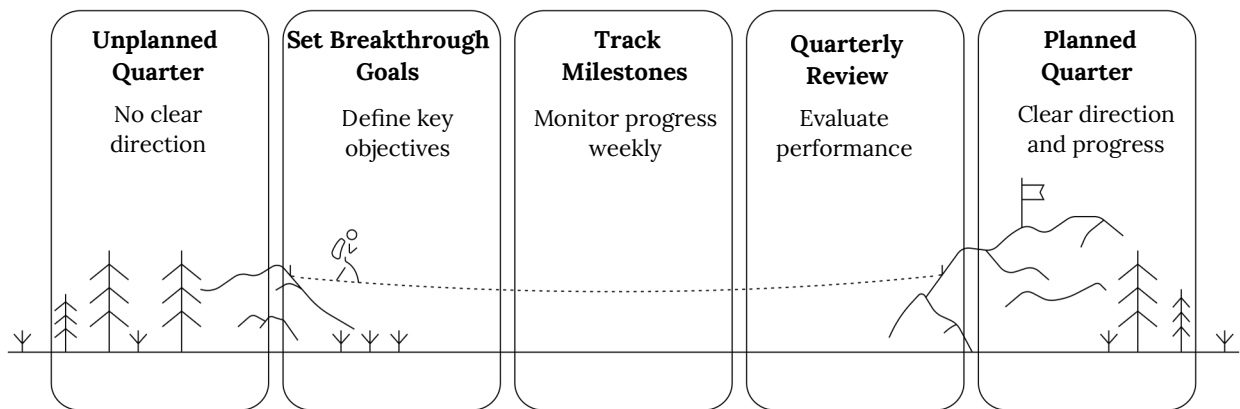
WEEKLY MILESTONES : For each goal what should I have achieved by week 4, week 8, and week 12?

KEYSTONE HABITS : 2 weekly behaviours that are preconditions for hitting these goals.

NOT-TO-DO LIST : 3 things I must stop doing or deprioritise to protect capacity for these goals.

WEEKLY CHECK-IN : One question to ask myself every Friday to assess whether I am on track.

Achieving Quarterly Goals



PRO TIP

The Not-To-Do List is as important as the goal list. Every 90-Day Plan assumes you will have capacity you don't currently have. That capacity has to come from somewhere and the only honest place it can come from is stopping or delegating something you currently do. Write the Not-To-Do List before you commit to the goals.

Pairs well with: 8.7 Eisenhower Matrix · 10.3 Weekly Review · 6.2 OKRs · 10.6 Atomic Habits

10.3 — Weekly Review GTD 5-15

End every week with clarity. Start every week with intention.

USE THIS WHEN

You end most weeks with a vague sense of what happened and start most weeks reactive responding to what arrives rather than acting on what matters. Your productivity is high but your progress on the things that matter most is slow.

THE FRAMEWORK

David Allen's Getting Things Done (GTD) system includes a Weekly Review as its highest-leverage practice. The 5-15 Report, popularised in the management literature - is a compact weekly review format: 5 minutes reviewing what you accomplished, 10 minutes planning what matters next week. **Combined with GTD's capture-and-process discipline, the weekly review is the habit that keeps your system honest and your priorities clear.** AI can run the review with you when given the right inputs, turning 15 minutes of structured reflection into a clean weekly action list.

Origin: David Allen, Getting Things Done, 2001

HOW TO USE IT

1. Schedule the weekly review at the same time every week - Friday afternoon or Sunday morning work well for most founders.
2. Do not start next week's planning until you have finished this week's review - close the loop before opening the next one.
3. The review is not a to-do list audit - it is a priorities audit. Ask whether what you worked on this week actually mattered.
4. Keep the review under 20 minutes. If it takes longer, the system needs simplification, not more time.



Checking off a full to-do list feels productive but says nothing about whether the right things got done. The review only works if it asks "did this matter," not "did I finish it."

Act as a personal productivity coach running my Weekly Review.

This week's context:

What I planned to do : [YOUR GOALS OR INTENTIONS FOR THIS WEEK]

What I actually did : [KEY TASKS AND PROJECTS WORKED ON]

What is unfinished : [ITEMS CARRIED OVER OR INCOMPLETE]

Upcoming commitments : [KEY MEETINGS, DEADLINES NEXT WEEK]

Run my Weekly Review:

WINS : What 3 things went well this week? What made them possible?

GAPS : What did I plan but not do? Was it worth doing? If yes — why didn't it happen?

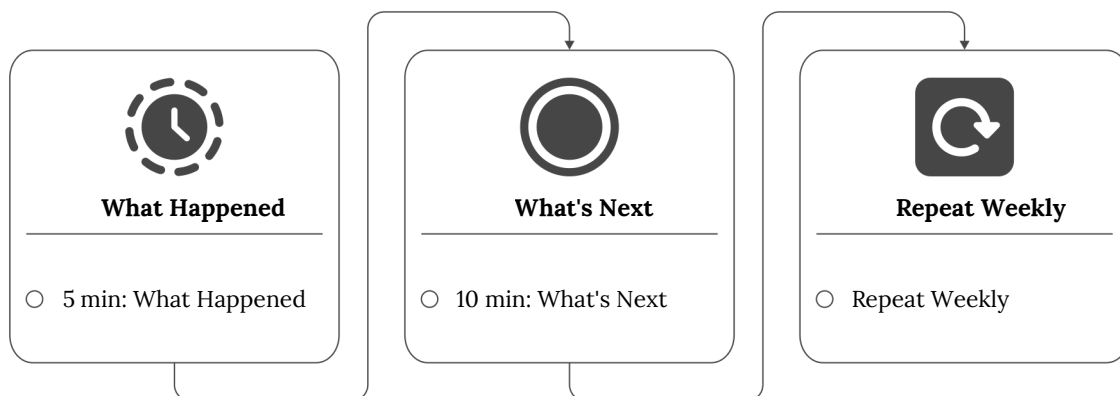
LEARNINGS : What one thing would I do differently?

NEXT WEEK PRIORITIES: My top 3 outcomes for next week. Not tasks, outcomes.

PROTECT : One block of time to schedule now for my most important strategic work next week.

CLEAR: One thing to decide, delegate, or delete today.

The 5-15 Weekly Review



PRO TIP

The single most important output of the Weekly Review is the one block of protected time for Q2 work scheduled in advance. Without scheduling it before the week begins, reactive Q1 and Q3 work will fill every available hour. The calendar must reflect your priorities before the week starts, not after it ends.

Pairs well with: 8.7 Eisenhower Matrix · 5-15 Report · 10.2 90-Day Planning · 10.6 Atomic Habits · 6.8 Meeting Design

10.4 — 4 Energy Quadrants

Manage your energy not just your time

USE THIS WHEN

You manage your calendar carefully but still feel drained and underperforming. You have the time but not the capacity. The problem is not scheduling, it is energy management. You are treating yourself like a machine that runs on hours rather than a human who runs on energy.

THE FRAMEWORK

Jim Loehr and Tony Schwartz, in *The Power of Full Engagement*, proposed that high performance depends on managing four types of energy: Physical (the foundation, sleep, movement, nutrition), Emotional (stability, resilience, positivity), Mental (focus, concentration, clear thinking), and Spiritual (meaning, purpose, alignment with values). Each type of energy has a capacity that can be built through stress and recovery cycles, like a muscle. Most high performers burn energy in all four dimensions without systematically recovering it, leading to diminishing performance over time despite increasing effort.

The mistake most founders make is treating time as the scarce resource and energy as unlimited. It is the opposite. You can always find more hours, but energy that has not been recovered does not come back just because you willed it to. Managing your calendar without managing your energy is optimizing the wrong variable entirely.

Origin: Jim Loehr & Tony Schwartz, The Power of Full Engagement, 2003

HOW TO USE IT

1. Audit your current energy management across all four dimensions before designing any new habits.
2. Physical energy is foundational, nothing else works well when it is depleted. Fix sleep first.
3. Identify your highest-energy time of day and protect it for your highest-cognitive work.
4. Build recovery rituals for each energy type, not just physical recovery.

Act as a high-performance coach using the 4 Energy Quadrants framework.

My current situation:

Sleep (hours / quality): [X]

Exercise (frequency / type): [X]

Emotional state (how you typically feel at work): [X]

Focus (how well you concentrate for deep work): [X]

Sense of purpose (how aligned your work feels): [X]

Main energy drains: [WHAT DEPLETES YOU MOST]

Audit my energy across all four dimensions:

PHYSICAL : Current state, biggest gap, one recovery ritual

EMOTIONAL : Current state, main drain, one stabiliser habit

MENTAL : Current state, focus blockers, one protection habit

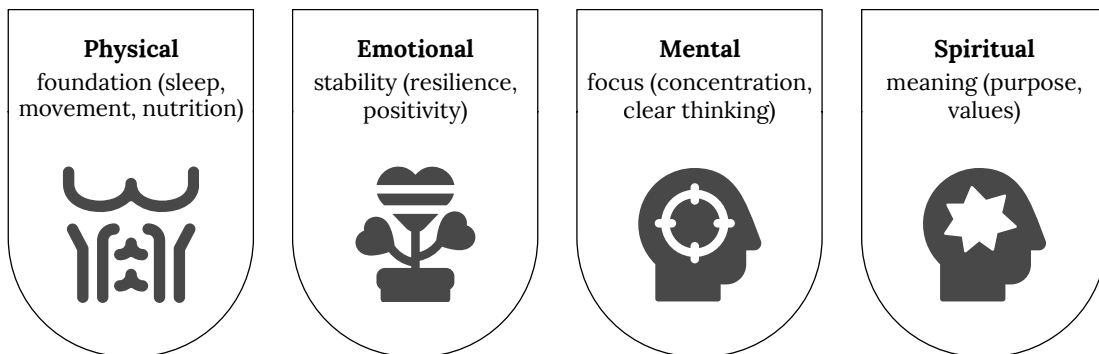
SPIRITUAL : Current alignment, what drains meaning, one anchor

Design my Minimum Viable Energy Routine:

The smallest set of habits that would most improve my total energy capacity in 30 days.

Maximum 4 habits. Each under 20 minutes per day.

Four Types of Energy



PRO TIP

The Minimum Viable Energy Routine is designed to be non-negotiable and sustainable not impressive. Most high-performers have complex morning routines they follow for two weeks and abandon. Four small, consistent habits performed daily for 90 days compound into a meaningfully different baseline. Start with sleep, then add one habit at a time.

Pairs well with: 10.3 Weekly Review · 10.6 Atomic Habits · 10.9 Ikigai · 10.10 Hansei

10.5 — Three Horizons Vision

Plan three futures simultaneously without losing the present

USE THIS WHEN

You oscillate between being too focused on today's execution and too lost in long-term vision. Strategic planning sessions drift into fantasy. Daily operations crowd out anything beyond this week. You need a framework that holds all three time horizons at once.

THE FRAMEWORK

McKinsey's Three Horizons framework, developed in the late 1990s, organises strategic thinking across three simultaneous timeframes: **Horizon 1 (12 months - defend and optimise your core business)**, **Horizon 2 (1-3 years - develop and scale emerging opportunities)**, and **Horizon 3 (3-5 years - create options for future growth)**.

The framework does not suggest sequential attention - all three horizons require investment and attention simultaneously, in different proportions based on company stage. Applied personally, it becomes a powerful vision tool for founders designing their own trajectory.

Origin: McKinsey & Company — Three Horizons framework, Baghai, Coley & White, 1999

HOW TO USE IT

1. Map your current allocation of time and energy across the three horizons most founders are trapped in H1.
2. H3 ideas require protection from H1 urgency, they will never survive if they must justify themselves on H1 metrics.
3. Build an H2 pipeline even when H1 is working well, H1 success is temporary without H2 in development.
4. Review your Three Horizons map quarterly, the business changes faster than annual reviews can track.

Act as a strategic planning advisor using McKinsey's Three Horizons framework.

My business : [DESCRIBE YOUR CURRENT CORE BUSINESS]

Stage : [REVENUE RANGE AND GROWTH RATE]

Current strategic priorities : [WHAT YOU ARE FOCUSED ON NOW]

Map my Three Horizons:

HORIZON 1 (This year) :

What is the core business I must protect and optimise?

Key metrics to defend. Main threats to manage.

HORIZON 2 (1–3 years) :

What 2–3 adjacent opportunities should I be developing?

What experiments should I be running now?

What would need to be true for each to become H1?

HORIZON 3 (3–5 years) :

What options should I be creating – even if uncertain?

What bets cost little today but matter greatly later?

BALANCE AUDIT :

What % of my time/energy goes to each horizon now?

What is the right allocation given my stage?

What would I need to stop doing in H1 to fund H2?

PRO TIP

The most common Three Horizons failure is treating H3 as a vision exercise and H1 as the only real work. H3 options are built through small, cheap bets made consistently over time. Amazon's AWS was an H3 bet in 2003 when their core H1 business was books. The value of H3 is not in the vision — it is in the options it creates.

Pairs well with: 10.2 90-Day Planning · 6.10 Hoshin Kanri · 2.9 Ansoff Matrix · 8.5 Scenario Planning

10.6 — Atomic Habits Stack

Build the habits that compound- one tiny behaviour at a time

USE THIS WHEN

You know what habits would make you a better founder. You have tried to build them before and failed. The problem is not motivation it is system design. You are relying on willpower rather than building an environment that makes the right behaviour automatic.

THE FRAMEWORK

James Clear's Atomic Habits (2018) synthesises decades of behaviour science into four laws of behaviour change: **Make it Obvious** (cue), **Make it Attractive** (craving), **Make it Easy** (response), **Make it Satisfying** (reward). Habit Stacking, attaching a new habit to an existing one, is the highest-leverage application of these laws.

The formula is: After I [CURRENT HABIT], I will [NEW HABIT]. This eliminates the need for a separate trigger and uses the existing neural pathway as the bridge. The habit succeeds or fails on how tightly it rides that existing routine, not on how much willpower you bring to it. AI can design a complete habit stack for any goal when given your current daily routine.

Origin: James Clear, Atomic Habits, 2018 · BJ Fogg, Tiny Habits, 2019

HOW TO USE IT

1. Map your existing daily habits before designing new ones - stacking requires anchors.
2. Start with the smallest possible version of each habit - two minutes maximum. Reduce friction to zero.
3. Design your environment before relying on motivation - visible cues beat willpower every time.
4. Track habits for 30 days minimum before evaluating, habits take longer to form than most people expect.

Act as a habit design coach using James Clear's Atomic Habits framework.

My goal : [THE OUTCOME I WANT, E.G. BETTER FOCUS, EXERCISE, READING]

My current morning routine : [WHAT YOU ACTUALLY DO EACH MORNING]

My current evening routine : [WHAT YOU ACTUALLY DO EACH EVENING]

Past habit failures : [WHAT YOU HAVE TRIED AND ABANDONED]

Design my Atomic Habits Stack:

Step 1 : Identify 3 strong existing habits as anchors.

Step 2 : For each new habit I want to build, apply the 4 Laws:

OBVIOUS : What is the cue? Where will I see it?

ATTRACTIVE : How do I make it appealing?

EASY : What is the 2-minute version?

SATISFYING : What is the immediate reward?

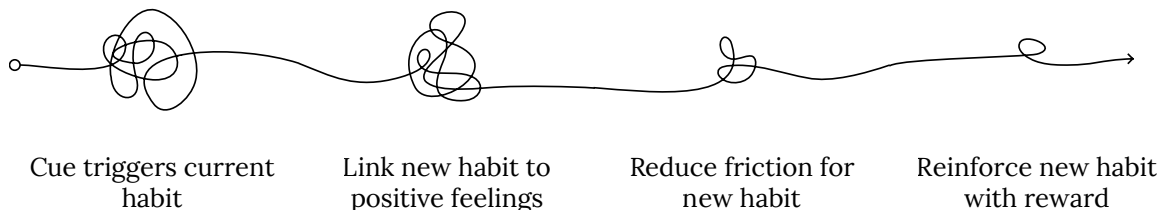
Step 3 : Write my Habit Stack as if/when-then statements:

After I [ANCHOR HABIT], I will [NEW HABIT].

Step 4 : Design one environment change that makes the most important habit easier without willpower.

Step 5 : What is the one habit that, if built, makes all the others easier?

Habit stacking progresses from awareness to reward.



PRO TIP

The keystone habit, the one that makes all others easier is almost always sleep. Every other habit in your stack performs better on sufficient sleep and degrades on insufficient sleep. If your habit stack has any room for only one new behaviour, make it a consistent sleep and wake time. Build everything else on that foundation.

Pairs well with: 10.4 Energy Quadrants · 10.3 Weekly Review · 10.2 90-Day Planning

10.7 — Socratic Self-Questioning

Challenge your own thinking before it becomes your strategy

USE THIS WHEN

You hold beliefs about your market, your customers, and your business that you have never seriously tested. These beliefs shape your decisions without you realising it. Some of them are correct. Some are expensive assumptions masquerading as facts.

THE FRAMEWORK

Socratic questioning named after Socrates' method of rigorous intellectual inquiry through probing questions is a **structured technique for examining beliefs, uncovering assumptions, and testing the logic of conclusions.**

Applied as a self-examination tool, it becomes one of the most powerful mental models a founder can use: before committing to a strategic direction, a major hire, or a significant investment, you ask a series of questions designed **to expose what you actually believe and why.** AI makes this practice available on demand a rigorous thinking partner that will push back without ego.

Origin: Socratic method — ancient Greek philosophy — applied to business strategic thinking

HOW TO USE IT

1. Use Socratic questioning on your most confident beliefs, not your uncertainties. Confidence is where blind spots hide.
2. Ask AI to steelman the opposite position before you commit to your view.
3. Write your reasoning before the session, vague beliefs survive questioning; explicit ones do not.
4. Run this exercise before any major strategic decision, not after it.



AI won't push back without ego" is the pitch, but it can just as easily mirror your confidence back to you unless you explicitly ask it to argue the other side.

Act as a Socratic questioner. Your role is to rigorously examine my thinking through probing questions — not to agree or validate. Push back on weak logic.

Belief or decision to examine:

[STATE THE BELIEF, PLAN, OR DECISION YOU WANT TO TEST]

Apply the six categories of Socratic questions:

CLARIFICATION : What exactly do I mean by this? Can I give a concrete example?

ASSUMPTIONS : What am I taking for granted here? What would have to be true for this to hold?

EVIDENCE : What is my evidence for this belief? How strong is it — anecdote or data?

PERSPECTIVE : How would a sceptic view this? What is the strongest opposing argument?

IMPLICATIONS : If this is true, what else must be true? What are the consequences if I am wrong?

QUESTIONING THE QUESTION: Is this the right question? What is the deeper question underneath it?

End with: the one assumption I should validate before committing to this belief.

Socratic Self-Questioning

Step	1	2	3	4
Action	Confident belief	Question the assumption	Steelman the opposite	What would prove this wrong?

PRO TIP

The most important Socratic question is "What would have to be true for me to be wrong?" This forces you to define the falsifiability of your belief - the conditions under which you would update your view. A belief that cannot be proven wrong isn't a belief, it's a story you've decided not to test.

Pairs well with: 1.6 First Principles · 1.8 Inversion · 8.6 Red Team · 10.1 Personal SWOT

10.8 — Personal Brand Flywheel

Build the reputation that brings opportunities to you – instead of always chasing them

USE THIS WHEN

You rely entirely on your network and referrals for business development. When you stop actively selling, the pipeline dries up. You have not built a reputation that generates inbound interest independently of your direct effort.

THE FRAMEWORK

The Personal Brand Flywheel applies the compounding logic of Jim Collins's Flywheel (Framework 5.10) to an individual founder's reputation and authority. The loop: distinctive **expertise generates original content**, which **builds an audience**, which **creates credibility**, which **attracts** speaking and press **opportunities**, which **expands the audience**, which builds **more authority**, which **compounds** expertise through feedback and the **loop spins faster with each rotation**.

The flywheel takes 12–18 months to build meaningful momentum, but once spinning, it generates inbound opportunities that become the best leads, hires, and partnerships in the business.

Origin: Jim Collins flywheel applied to personal brand – founder marketing best practice

HOW TO USE IT

1. Choose one specific topic to be known for generalists build audiences slowly, specialists build them fast.
2. Consistency of output matters more than quality of any single piece, weekly beats occasional brilliant.
3. Document your thinking, not just your advice people follow founders for their process, not just their conclusions.
4. Measure flywheel velocity: how many inbound opportunities came from your content this quarter?

Act as a personal brand strategist.

My expertise : [WHAT I KNOW DEEPLY — SPECIFIC TOPIC]

My target audience : [WHO I WANT TO REACH — ROLE AND INDUSTRY]

My goal : [WHAT I WANT THE BRAND TO GENERATE — LEADS, HIRES, SPEAKING, INVESTMENT, COMMUNITY]

Current platform : [LINKEDIN / X / NEWSLETTER / PODCAST / NONE]

Design my Personal Brand Flywheel:

DISTINCTIVE ANGLE : What is my specific point of view that others in my space don't have?

CONTENT SYSTEM : What format do I own? What cadence? What is my signature series or post type?

AUDIENCE GROWTH : What 2 channels will I focus on? What growth tactic fits my style?

CREDIBILITY SIGNALS : What proof points build trust? What should I be saying publicly?

FLYWHEEL SPIN : What is the first rotation? What does the flywheel look like at 12 months?

FIRST 30 DAYS: The 3 actions that start the flywheel.

PRO TIP

The Personal Brand Flywheel does not require a large audience to generate value. Fifty deeply engaged people in your exact target market outperform five thousand passive followers in terms of business outcomes. Build depth before scale, the flywheel accelerates faster with a small, engaged audience than with a large, indifferent one.

Pairs well with: 5.10 Flywheel · 5.4 Content Pillars · 5.7 Brand Voice · 5.2 Hook Framework

Japanese Framework · Toyota Production System / Japanese Philosophy

10.9 — Ikigai

Find the intersection of what you love, what you are good at, what the world needs, and what you can be paid for

USE THIS WHEN

You are successful by external measures but unclear on whether you are doing the right work. Or you are considering a major pivot and want to evaluate it against something deeper than market opportunity. You need a framework for purposeful direction, not just profitable direction.

THE FRAMEWORK

Ikigai (Japanese: iki = life, gai = worth or value) is a concept from Okinawan philosophy describing the reason for being the sense of purpose that makes getting up in the morning feel meaningful. In the Western adaptation popularised by Marc Winn and others, Ikigai is visualised as the intersection of four circles: **What You Love** (passion), **What You Are Good At** (vocation), **What The World Needs** (mission), and **What You Can Be Paid For** (profession). The sweet spot at the centre where all four overlap is your Ikigai. Applied to a founder's career and business decisions, it is one of the most clarifying frameworks available.

Origin: Okinawan philosophy — Ikigai — Western adaptation by Marc Winn, 2014

HOW TO USE IT

1. Be honest in each circle especially 'What You Are Good At.' Evidence-based, not aspiration-based.
2. The overlap between 'What You Love' and 'What You Are Good At' without commercial viability is a hobby not a business.
3. Ikigai is not found in a single session it emerges from reflection over time. Revisit annually.
4. Use Ikigai to evaluate pivots, new ventures, and career decisions not just to define your current path.

Act as a reflective purpose coach using the Ikigai framework.

My background : [DESCRIBE YOUR EXPERIENCE, CAREER PATH, KEY LIFE EXPERIENCES]

Current work : [WHAT YOU DO NOW AND HOW FULFILLED YOU FEEL]

Guide me through the Ikigai exercise:

WHAT I LOVE : What work makes me lose track of time? What would I do even without payment? What topics do I read about without being asked?

WHAT I'M GOOD AT : What do I do better than most people? What do others consistently come to me for? What has evidence, not just belief - proven?

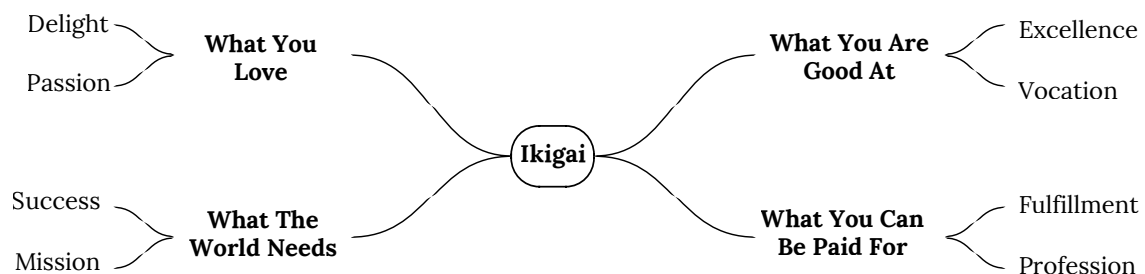
WHAT THE WORLD NEEDS : What problem genuinely needs solving? Who suffers without what I could provide? What gap do I see that others seem to miss?

WHAT I CAN BE PAID FOR : What will people pay for that sits in my other three circles?

IKIGAI SYNTHESIS : Where do all four overlap?

If no clear overlap: what small experiment in the next 90 days could test whether one exists?

Ikigai: The Intersection of Passion, Vocation, Profession, and Mission



PRO TIP

The most important Ikigai question is not 'what is my Ikigai?' it is 'what small experiment would test whether my hypothesis about my Ikigai is correct?' Purpose is discovered through action, not reflection alone. Design a 90-day experiment that puts you in the overlap zone and see how it feels. The body knows before the mind does.

Pairs well with: 10.1 Personal SWOT · 10.5 Three Horizons · 8.8 Regret Minimization · 10.10 Hansei

Japanese Framework · Toyota Production System / Japanese Philosophy

10.10 — Hansei – Reflective Practice

The Japanese discipline of honest self-reflection without self-punishment

USE THIS WHEN

You move from project to project, quarter to quarter, without pausing to genuinely examine what happened and what it means. You learn from experience, but not as systematically or as honestly as you could. Growth happens, but not by design.

THE FRAMEWORK

Hansei (Japanese: han = to change, sei = **to look back**) is a reflective practice embedded in Japanese culture and the Toyota Production System. It is the discipline of **honest self-examination, acknowledging mistakes not with shame, but with genuine curiosity and the commitment to improve**. In Toyota, Hansei is practiced after every significant project or event, not as a performance review but as a personal reflection ritual. Unlike Western post-mortems (which are group analyses), Hansei is individual, it asks the leader to look inward honestly before examining external factors. It has three movements: acknowledge what happened honestly, take personal responsibility for your role in it, and commit to a specific change.

Origin: Toyota Production System · Japanese cultural practice — Hansei, widely embedded in Japanese education

HOW TO USE IT

1. Practice Hansei weekly, not only after failures. Examining successes with the same honesty is equally valuable.
2. The first question in Hansei is always personal: 'What was my role in this outcome?' before 'What caused this externally?'
3. Hansei without a specific commitment to change is just reflection. The practice ends with a behaviour change, not a conclusion.
4. Write Hansei reflections the discipline of writing forces the honesty that verbal reflection often avoids.

Act as a Hansei reflective practice facilitator.

Event or period to reflect on:

[DESCRIBE WHAT HAPPENED A PROJECT, DECISION, QUARTER, OR RELATIONSHIP YOU WANT TO EXAMINE HONESTLY]

Outcome: [WHAT RESULTED]

Guide me through a Hansei reflection:

HONEST ACKNOWLEDGEMENT:

What actually happened? No minimising, no excusing.

Describe the outcome as it was not as you wish it had been.

PERSONAL RESPONSIBILITY:

What was my specific contribution to this outcome?

What did I do, or not do that mattered?

What did I know and ignore? What did I avoid seeing?

LEARNING:

What does this tell me about how I think or operate?

What pattern, if any, does this repeat?

COMMITMENT:

What one specific behaviour will I change?

How will I know in 30 days whether I have changed it?

GRATITUDE: What, despite the difficulty, am I grateful for?

PRO TIP

Hansei is uncomfortable because it requires taking personal responsibility before assigning external causes. The Western tendency is to explain external causes first and assign personal responsibility last, if at all. Hansei inverts this. The founder who practices it consistently builds a quality of self-awareness that no coaching, therapy, or feedback can replicate because it is chosen and honest.

Pairs well with: 10.11 Wabi-Sabi · 8.3 Post-Mortem · 7.9 Kaizen · 10.7 Socratic Self-Questioning

Japanese Framework · Toyota Production System / Japanese Philosophy

10.11 — Wabi-Sabi – Imperfect Progress

Ship imperfect work. Build a beautiful, incomplete company. Move forward anyway.

USE THIS WHEN

You are waiting for something to be ready before you ship, publish, launch, or share it. The standard in your head is higher than what is achievable in the time available. Perfectionism is wearing the mask of quality, but it is actually fear.

THE FRAMEWORK

Wabi-Sabi is a Japanese aesthetic philosophy rooted in Zen Buddhism that **finds beauty in imperfection, impermanence, and incompleteness**. Wabi (rustic simplicity, understated elegance) and Sabi (the beauty of aging, the patina of time) together describe a worldview that accepts and even celebrates the imperfect and the unfinished as a natural state of all things. Applied to the founder's experience, Wabi-Sabi offers an antidote to perfectionism and a philosophical foundation for the practice of shipping work, releasing versions, and building in public. The **product that ships imperfectly and improves beats the product that never ships perfectly**. The company itself, like everything else, is a work in progress rather than a finished monument, and that incompleteness is not a flaw to fix but the actual shape of the thing.

Origin: Japanese Zen Buddhist aesthetic — Wabi-Sabi philosophy · Applied to modern entrepreneurship

HOW TO USE IT

1. Use Wabi-Sabi as a check whenever you find yourself delaying a launch, revision, or communication because it 'isn't ready yet.'
2. Define 'good enough to ship' before you start building, not after you've been building for three months.
3. Practice showing work-in-progress to trusted people, the discomfort is the practice.
4. Ask: 'What is the cost of this imperfection if I ship now?' vs 'What is the cost of not shipping at all?'

Act as a Wabi-Sabi philosophical advisor helping me move from perfectionism to purposeful imperfect action.

What I am delaying : [DESCRIBE WHAT YOU HAVE NOT SHIPPED, PUBLISHED, LAUNCHED, OR SHARED AND FOR HOW LONG]

Why I am delaying : [YOUR REASON BE HONEST]

What 'ready' looks like in my head : [THE STANDARD YOU ARE TRYING TO MEET BEFORE SHIPPING]

Apply Wabi-Sabi:

HONEST DIAGNOSIS : Is this perfectionism or legitimate quality concern? How do I tell

the difference?

IMPERFECT VERSION : What is the version I could ship this week — flawed but honest and real?

COST OF WAITING : What am I not learning by not shipping? What feedback am I denying myself?

BEAUTY IN PROCESS : What is genuinely good — even beautiful — about this unfinished, imperfect thing?

COMMITMENT : What will I ship, post, or share by [DATE]? What does 'done enough' look like?

PRO TIP

The most honest question Wabi-Sabi asks is: 'Who am I protecting by not shipping?' The answer is almost never the customer, it is yourself. From criticism, from comparison, from the discomfort of being judged on real work rather than potential work. Wabi-Sabi teaches that the courage to show imperfect work is itself a form of beauty. Ship it.

Pairs well with: 10.10 Hansei · 2.6 MVP Design · 7.9 Kaizen · 10.7 Socratic Self-Questioning

Now use them.

The frameworks are the map.

You are the territory.

You have just completed 108 frameworks covering thinking, selling, marketing, leading, operating, deciding, financing, and living with purpose. No one uses all 108 at once. The leaders who get the most from this book use three or four deeply rather than all of them lightly.

The AI prompts are designed to be used not admired. Copy them. Modify them. Run them on your real business problems. The difference between a leader who reads a framework and a leader who uses one is not intelligence. It is the willingness to apply it before you feel completely ready.

THE ONE THING TO DO RIGHT NOW

Pick the one framework from this book that addresses your most pressing problem right now. Open the AI prompt. Fill in the brackets. See what comes back. Then do something with the output. That is the whole game.

— **Raphy Varghese**

Author — AI Operating System for Leaders

COMPLETE FRAMEWORK INDEX

108 frameworks across 10 modules · H = Japanese origin

MODULE 1 · THINK LIKE A STRATEGIST

1.1	First Principles Thinking	4
1.2	Systems Thinking	5
1.3	Mental Models Library	6
1.4	Design Thinking	7
1.5	Six Thinking Hats	8
1.6	First Principles (Socratic)	9
1.7	Second Order Thinking	10
1.8	Inversion	11
1.9	Bayesian Thinking	12
1.10	OODA Loop	16
1.11	SCAMPER	17
1.12	MECE Framework	18

MODULE 2 · DESIGN YOUR BUSINESS

2.1	Value Proposition Canvas	20
2.2	Business Model Canvas	21
2.3	Lean Canvas	22
2.4	Blue Ocean Strategy	23
2.5	Jobs To Be Done	24
2.6	MVP Design	25
2.7	Pricing — Value Ladder	26
2.8	Unfair Advantage — Moat Builder	27
2.9	Ansoff Matrix	28
2.10	Kano Model	29

MODULE 3 · KNOW YOUR MARKET

3.1	SWOT Analysis	31
3.2	PESTLE Analysis	32
3.3	Porter's Five Forces	33
3.4	Ideal Customer Profile (ICP)	34
3.5	TAM SAM SOM	35
3.6	Competitor Mapping	36
3.7	Market Positioning Statement	37
3.8	Voice of Customer — Empathy Grid	38
3.9	STP Model	39
3.10	Perceptual Mapping	40

MODULE 4 · SELL LIKE A PRO

4.1	Cold Outreach — AIDA	42
4.2	SPIN Selling	43
4.3	BANT & CHAMP Qualification	44
4.4	The Challenger Sale	45
4.5	Objection Handling — LAER	46
4.6	PAS — Problem Agitate Solve	47
4.7	Proposal Writing — Win Story	48
4.8	Follow-Up Sequences	49
4.9	Pipeline Review — Deal Health	50
4.10	Closing Techniques Matrix	51
4.11	FAB — Features Advantages Benefits	52

MODULE 5 · MARKET YOUR MESSAGE

5.1	StoryBrand Framework — SB7	54
5.2	Hook Framework for Content	55
5.3	Ps & 7Ps Marketing Mix	56
5.4	Content Pillars Strategy	57
5.5	Go-To-Market Canvas	58
5.6	Product Launch Playbook	59
5.7	Brand Voice Definition	60
5.8	Viral Loop — Growth Loop	61
5.9	AARRR — Pirate Metrics	62
5.10	Flywheel Model	63
5.11	STP — Segment Target Position	39

MODULE 6 · BUILD YOUR TEAM

6.1	RACI Matrix	65
6.2	OKRs — Goals That Drive	66
6.3	Action.. 1-on-1 Framework — GROW Model	67
6.4	Hiring with AI — Talent Filter	68
6.5	SBI Feedback Model	69
6.6	Culture Code Canvas	70
6.7	Delegation Ladder	71
6.8	Meeting Design — Meeting OS	72
6.9	Radical Candor	73
6.10	Hoshin Kanri	74
6.11	Situational Leadership	75
6.12	McKinsey 7S Framework	76

COMPLETE FRAMEWORK INDEX · CONTINUED

108 frameworks across 10 modules · H = Japanese origin

MODULE 7 · OPERATE WITH PRECISION

7.1	SOP Generation — SIPOC	78
7.2	Workflow Mapping — Swimlane	79
7.3	Theory of Constraints	80
7.4	ICE Scoring	81
7.5	RICE Scoring	82
7.6	PDCA Cycle	83
7.7	Automation Opportunity Finder	84
7.8	Agile Sprint Canvas	85
7.9	Agile Sprint Canvas	86
7.10	Kaizen	87
7.11	5S Framework	88
7.12	5 Whys	89

MODULE 8 · DECIDE WITH CONFIDENCE

8.1	The DECIDE Framework	91
8.2	Pre-Mortem Analysis	92
8.3	Post-Mortem Review	93
8.4	Risk Matrix	94
8.5	Scenario Planning	95
8.6	Red Team Thinking	96
8.7	Eisenhower Matrix	97
8.8	Regret Minimization Framework	98
8.9	Decision Tree Analysis	99
8.10	Expected Value Framework	100

MODULE 9 · FINANCE & METRICS

9.1	Unit Economics — LTV:CAC	102
9.2	Burn Rate & Runway	103
9.3	North Star Metric & OMTM	104
9.4	AARRR Funnel Analysis — Deep Dive	105
9.5	Investor Narrative — Pitch Spine	106
9.6	3-Scenario Financial Model	107
9.7	Balanced Scorecard	108
9.8	Cash Conversion	109
9.9	Cycle Rule of	40

MODULE 10 · LEAD YOURSELF FIRST

10.1	Personal SWOT	112
10.2	90-Day Planning	113
10.3	Weekly Review — GTD 5-15	114
10.4	4 Energy Quadrants	115
10.5	Three Horizons Vision	116
10.6	Atomic Habits Stack	117
10.7	Socratic Self-Questioning	118
10.8	Personal Brand Flywheel	119
10.9	Ikigai	120
10.10	Hansei	121
10.11	Wabi-Sabi	122

Your Next 30 Days

A simple cadence for turning this book into a practice.

The biggest risk with a book like this is reading it and doing nothing. The second biggest risk is trying to use all 108 frameworks at once. This page exists to prevent both.

Four weeks. One challenge per week. One framework at a time.

WEEK 1 Choose your challenge	Identify the one challenge that is costing you the most time, energy, or money right now. Open the Situation Index. Find the framework that matches it. Run the prompt in a single AI session today.
WEEK 2 Stack one more framework	Return to the framework you used in Week 1. Check the “Pairs Well With” line on that page. Add the second framework to your session. Notice how much the output improves when the frameworks work together.
WEEK 3 Tackle a second challenge	You now have a method. Apply it to the next most pressing challenge in your business or leadership. Different module, same approach. You are building a habit, not just solving a problem.
WEEK 4 Review and embed	Look back at the outputs from the last three weeks. What changed? What did you act on? What did you learn? Identify the three frameworks you will return to most often. These are the core of your AI toolkit.

WHAT 30 DAYS BUILDS

After 30 days, you will have used at least four frameworks on real problems in your business. That is not a reading habit. That is an operating system.

THREE FRAMEWORKS TO START WITH

Write them here before you close this book:

Before You Close This Book

Three questions worth five minutes of your time.

The best leaders are not just good at solving problems. They are good at pausing to ask the right question first.

a. What is the one challenge I have been avoiding that a framework could unlock?

Be specific. Name the problem. If you cannot name it, that is the first problem to solve.

b. Which three people in my life would get the most value from this book?

A leader who helps others think better multiplies their own impact. Share the Situation Index page with them.

c. What does good look like for me in 90 days if I use this properly?

Write one sentence. Not a goal list. One sentence that describes the future you are building toward.

A NOTE ON THESE QUESTIONS

Leaders who know where they are going make better decisions about which frameworks to reach for first. The third question is the most important one.

AI OPERATING SYSTEM FOR LEADERS

108 Frameworks. 108 Prompts. One Operating System.

Your time is not unlimited.

Every hour spent stuck without the right frame is an hour that will not come back. This book gives you the structure to move faster on every challenge a leader faces.

These frameworks represent the condensed thinking of the world's best strategists and operators. The AI prompts apply that thinking to your specific situation in minutes. Whether you are a first-generation founder, a student stepping up, a manager who was promoted before they felt ready, or a professional building something that matters this book was written for you.

108

Frameworks

10

Modules

108

AI Prompts

Raphy Varghese

Builder · Strategist · AI Practitioner

ISBN 978-X-XXXXXX-XX-X

Leadership · Business · Artificial Intelligence